



ENDEAVOR

SAUL COSTA

Endeavor

Saul Costa

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First Edition

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For Dad.

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Introduction

My name is Saul David Costa. I grew up a homeschooled Vermont farm boy, but I've always had a passion for using technology to solve real-world problems. In my early twenties, I followed that passion West to California, where I founded a startup that broke down barriers to online tech education. In early 2021, at age twenty-eight, I sold the company for forty million dollars. In the midst of this farm-to-fortune adventure, I faced and overcame the murder of my aunt at age fourteen, the sudden and devastating loss of my father six years later, and the diagnosed bipolar one disorder triggered by those traumas. My journey so far has been one of resilience, observation, and integration—and, two years ago, I decided to write a book about it.

However, these pages hold more than a memoir. I recognized my neurodivergences early in life and started paying attention to how my mind functions. That led to, well, a lot of thinking about my thoughts. I like to invent ways of explaining patterns, so I did that with the data I'd collected about myself and came up with a few zany ideas. This book contains several of them. Most relate to the productive relationship between the conscious and subconscious minds; but, at the end, I try to bring all the threads together and explain my life alongside my mind.

I do not dawdle in my retellings, and I have done my best to steer clear of embellishment and misrepresentation. This book contains my stories and—except in the case of my father—no one else's. A multitude of people have taught, aided, and challenged me, but only they have the right to tell their stories. Dad isn't around anymore to recount his tales, and they're worth sharing. They are good stories—fun stories. Mostly.

If transitions between some of the seven parts of this book feel somewhat abrupt, it's a result of my writing approach. Throughout, the tone, pacing, and vocabulary shift to reflect my mental state when the recorded events were taking place. These parts are not made up of stories; they contain snapshots of my mind while writing about different chapters of my life. I invite you

to explore them with me in the pursuit of meaning and understanding—and perhaps we will encounter even more than that.

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "Paul". The letter "P" is stylized with a long, sweeping vertical stroke that extends downwards.

June 25th, 2025

I

Childhood

Play is the highest form of research.

— Albert Einstein

Life on the Farm

I was born in Central New Jersey in May 1992, and then lived in Raleigh, North Carolina, for five years. In 1999, my family moved to Vermont, where I would spend the next fifteen years of my life. Our home's original construction dated back to the early 1800s—when Abraham Lincoln was a kid—and it was located on twelve acres of land outside a small town up north. A forest of dark pine trees dripping with sticky sap covered half of the property; the rest lay open to fields sprinkled with wildflowers and studded by the occasional crab apple tree. It was an hour to the closest city and just fifty minutes south of the Canadian border. Fewer than seven hundred people lived in our town, and the one small general store was only open every now and then. You had to go one town over to buy gas.

After purchasing the Vermont property, our family set to work turning it into a small farm. I grew up the eldest of six children—five boys and then a girl. Of the four of us who were around then, the oldest three were already capable of pitching in on the various farm chores. Because our parents had decided to homeschool us, we were available at any point to get assigned a task, of which there were many.

The property came with six full-grown blueberry bushes, and picking the ripe berries before the birds ate them was one of our first assignments the summer we moved in. Each evening after Dad got home from teaching at the university, my next few siblings and I would be corralled, handed our only large cooking pot, and told to not come in for dinner until it was full of blueberries. Six bushes can produce a huge amount of fruit, so this was always possible, but it meant braving the bloodthirsty mosquitos and crawling upside down under the scraggly branches to ensure we got every last berry. Some of the harvest was immediately baked into cobblers and

eaten, but most of it was bagged and deposited in the large chest freezer in the rock-wall basement for later use.

Before long, the summer days grew shorter, and a chill crept into the evenings. The mountains flared crimson, persimmon, and gold as the cold spread down their sides, freezing the leaves of maple, ash, and birch trees. In a few weeks, all the leaves had fallen, leaving behind a blanket of gray trees interspersed with patches of evergreens that stood out against their drab backdrop. Then the first snow fell, frosting the mountaintops and warning that true winter was mere weeks away. It arrived right on schedule.

Our first winter on the farm was a proper introduction to Vermont's climate extremes, with temperatures plunging to minus-twenty degrees Fahrenheit. Some nights were cold enough to freeze the insides of our noses as we lugged sloshing five-gallon buckets of water for our young pony to the old post-and-beam barn that stood some ways from the house. Small chunks of ice formed on our gloves when water splashed them, then melted against the heat of our hands, then froze again, and so on, until ice-crusts, soggy gloves hung limp from each wrist.

But the cold nights had more to offer than discomfort. Water in the air froze and fell, sharpening the brilliance of the glittering stars above. City lights were now just memories, and the shimmering Milky Way stretched in an embrace of galactic proportions around our budding life in the mountains. As we entered the new millennium together, all felt as if a safe and happy future was in store for us.

Just when it seemed as if winter would never release its grip, the massive sheets of ice drooping from the roofs began to drip steadily, then stream, then slide off entirely in cataclysmic-sounding avalanches. Before long, all but the snow piles lingering in the shade had melted. The mountains flashed a light purple as tree buds emerged. Then, almost overnight,

leaves everywhere burst out, blanketing the landscape in a vibrant green worthy of the state's name.

The growing season started in early May. Once the ground thawed and the frost stopped coming each morning, Dad plowed a large patch of earth for a garden, turning over dark, rich-smelling soil studded with worms and perfect for crops. We set to work planting rows of corn, potatoes, peas, green beans, and sunflowers. Every row had to be straight to make weeding later easier, and our work was inspected to make sure we spaced the seeds properly; otherwise, the plants would crowd one another and stunt each other's growth. It was hardly back-breaking work, but this chore cut into much-needed outdoor play time after a long winter indoors. So, we protested, albeit without success.

Following an evening of work in the garden, we youngsters would be covered in dirt, necessitating a cold hose-down before trooping into our three-bedroom home. The downstairs bedroom was used as our homeschool classroom, leaving the two bedrooms upstairs for the whole family. Myself and my next three brothers all slept in bunk beds in one room, and my new baby brother slept in my parents' room. Later, he and my little sister would sleep in the large hallway between the two bedrooms. It never felt cramped, though. We had lots of fun swinging on and between the bunk beds, stringing up blankets to construct forts, and hanging from the top bunks to annoy the lowly bottom-bunkers.

The bunk beds were entertaining, but my favorite part of our fledgling farm was, without a doubt, the chickens. We got our first brood of chicks that spring, and they were the cutest things I'd ever seen. I spent hours taking care of them every day. Chicks are very difficult to keep alive. The smallest disruption in their access to food, water, and heat can kill them in hours.

Despite my best efforts, we lost a couple of them early on, but most grew quickly. By the time the gardens were planted, the feathering chicks were ready to be moved outdoors.

We relocated the now teenage chickens to a squat rectangular portable coop, and moved it every few days around a large, flat piece of lawn that we used for home sports—aptly named the Soccer Field. This constant relocating meant fresh pasture for the chickens and a new supply of insects for them to peck off the ground. Their droppings also acted as natural fertilizer, and a couple days after moving the coop, a dark green patch of grass would appear. We just had to keep the coop and accompanying chicken droppings away from our playing field. Cold chicken poop squeezing up through your bare toes is a unique sensation—one worth trying to avoid and impossible to forget.

The portable pen worked well while the chickens were smaller, but soon they needed a bigger, permanent home. Work began on an indoor pen where they could stay at night after free-ranging during the day. We sectioned off a corner of the barn using chicken fencing, then attached roosts made of peeled branches to the old barn's huge beams. After installing half a dozen laying boxes, we cut a small door into the barn's aged clapboard walls and added a hinged cover to keep out predators. Now the chicken pen was ready for its first residents.

We completed the chicken pen late that spring on an unseasonably warm evening—the first of the year. It was a Friday. The last nails were hammered in at dusk, so the decision was made to move the chickens in the morning. They had grown too big for the portable pen, which was now overcrowded. With the sudden spike in temperature, the birds pushed their heads out the large gaps cut into the metal sides of the pen to cool off. Leaving them there wasn't ideal, but it was only for one night.

The next morning, my excitement woke me up early. I got out of bed and made my way downstairs, past my sleeping family, and out the metal screen door into the backyard. The sky was light, but the sun still rested below the mountainous horizon. The grass blades in the backyard between the house and the small coop were still heavy with cold bulbs of dew. I beelined for the coop, eager to begin transporting the chickens to their new home.

Now, we did not plan on eating any of these chickens. They were mostly laying hens, and we had named many of them. Chickens have unique personalities—more so than you might think for such unintelligent animals—and many form attachments to humans and act like pets after a while. I had raised these chicks from a few days old and cared about each of them, which made what I saw next very painful.

As I approached the chicken coop, I noticed that something was different. It should have been buzzing with activity, especially given the dense living conditions. But I heard almost no noise from the inside the coop. No heads stuck out the sides to greet me, and the few clucks were hushed. Something was wrong.

A few feet from the coop, I stopped, unsure of what I was seeing but aware that it was very bad. The ground was strewn with feathers, some light and stuck to the wet grass, others bunched together to form shapes that looked like chicken body parts. No, I realized: they *were* chicken body parts, strewn in all directions. The feathers that still clung to them were matted with blood and bent in abnormal directions, revealing the ferocity the poor animal had been subjected to. Then I saw streaks of blood smeared across the sides of the coop and dripping onto the grass around it, and it hit me that I was witnessing the scene of a predator attack on the chicken flock.

I began to sob and ran back into the house, up the stairs, and flung open the door to my parents' bedroom. My sudden entrance woke them instantly. I was shaking all over and found it impossible to explain what I had just seen. They grasped that something was wrong and that it had to do with the chickens, so Dad got out of bed to go see for himself what had happened.

Eventually, we pieced together the nighttime massacre. During the warm night, seeking cooler air, the chickens had continued to stick their necks out of the small coop. A pack of coyotes, many of which roamed the area, were drawn to the activity. When the chickens stuck their heads out, the coyotes bit their necks and pulled, usually severing the neck and providing the coyote with a small but easy meal. Sometimes, however, they managed to pull more of the chicken out through the hole and ravaged whatever body part was exposed.

Thus, our flock of two dozen chickens was roughly halved. Most of the slaughtered bodies remained in the coop, missing heads and sometimes more. I tried not to look as Dad carried their remnants to a hole near the garden that I'd helped dig. A couple chickens were gone entirely. Those left alive stayed silent and motionless as we treated their wounds, afraid to do anything that might result in their own demise.

I felt responsible for the deaths, even though the decision to wait to move them into their larger coop hadn't been mine. It saddened me that such a small action had resulted in so much suffering, and I understood for the first time how fast everything can change without warning. It was a lesson in the ephemerality of life, and a harsh awakening to how much care was required to keep the animals safe from the dangers present in the Vermont countryside.

Some chickens that were hurt during the attack survived for many years afterward. One hen's neck had been half torn off, and we duct-taped it back together. She made a full recovery, although her neck protruded in the front after that. Another had part of its head eaten, leaving her

brain exposed and halved. Astonishingly, she too recovered, and ended up outliving most of the other chickens. We renamed her Half Brain, and despite her missing gray matter, she continued to function just like any chicken, with one exception: every so often when standing upright like normal, she would collapse to one side, with no attempt to catch herself. She'd lie still on the ground for a few seconds, then shake herself off and stand right back up as if nothing had happened. It was the funniest thing I've ever seen a chicken do, and they can be real characters once you get to know them.

* * *

The fragility of life was not the only lesson the farm held in store. The value of our hard work was tangible as we completed each task. Hauling branches, mucking out our pony's stall, and tossing hay bales was tiring, but we could see the results of our labor. The fences had been cleared, the pile of composting manure had grown, and the hay sat stacked neatly in the barn. We took pride in completing the simple work and tried our best to do a good job.

Every fall, an opportunity to earn some pocket money arrived at the homestead in the form of a massive pile of cut and split logs. To save on oil costs, our home was heated primarily with wood, and the single woodstove kept our hybrid living and dining room warm. The kids' bedroom above it also stayed nice and toasty, although the kitchen and our parents' room cooled off in the winter. But even when outside temperatures plunged, the house rarely got cold.

To keep the wood dry and ready to burn, after the bulk delivery each piece had to be moved into the woodshed attached to the house. This was accomplished by throwing the wood through a door into the shed, then stacking it to ensure efficient space usage and easy access. For

each piece of wood we threw in, we were paid two cents. An entire load of wood represented around twenty-five dollars in potential earnings, and a few of the older kids always seized the opportunity as soon as the wood was dropped off.

In the fall of 2002, our wood was delivered a few weeks late. Frost had already appeared on some mornings, and the air had assumed its crisp, clear autumn smell. Before long, snow would be falling. This added to the pressure to get the wood into the shed, but I was motivated by something else.

I had recently watched the original animated *Tarzan* movie and become infatuated with the ape-raised human. My eyes were set on a particular Tarzan action figure at Walmart, but I needed to earn a little more money to cover the twelve-dollar price tag. Throwing wood into the shed presented a great opportunity to do so. The pile of wood was about two-thirds gone, but I suspected that enough remained to fund the difference. To thwart any of my siblings who might want to capitalize on the remaining wood themselves, I woke up before them that Saturday morning and began right away, prying loose the logs that had frozen to the ground overnight. A couple of hours later, I strutted into the house to announce that the wood pile was finished and demanded my wages. Dad had just enough cash to pay me out, and after accompanying Mom on her shopping trip that day and dumping a small mountain of change on the checkout counter as payment, Tarzan was mine.

Following this, Dad instituted a new rule: to receive payment, you had to stack your wood as well, instead of just throwing it into the shed. Stacking was a long and boring task that no one wanted to do. We went on strike, and eventually he reverted to paying the two cents per log moved into the shed. However, stacking became a mandatory group task. That further motivated each of us to throw in the wood, and fast. Otherwise, we would be stuck being paid

nothing to stack wood that others had thrown in. It's unlikely that Dad created this dynamic intentionally, but he certainly had a knack for incentivizing his child workforce.

Dad was always sharing some tidbit of wisdom with us kids. To my child's ears, they were just words he said applicable in the moment; but, looking back now at the ones that have stayed with me, I understand just how formative and valuable some of his insights were.

The Dad lesson I think of the most was shared the day I went to him with a bunch of sinew tangled into a seemingly impossible knot. I needed some for a bowstring, but I couldn't manage to untangle it myself, so I brought it to him. He took the messy ball in his hands and stood silent for a moment, turning it over to examine it from different angles. Then he started pulling on the strings, carefully, one at a time, until they were free of the knot. A long piece of freed sinew began to dangle down to mark his progress.

"Every problem," he said, still working methodically through the knots, "is made up of a bunch of smaller problems. If you fix those smaller problems, one at a time, eventually your main problem is taken care of too."

He handed the partially undone knot back to me to finish, and I did, one strand at a time.

Farm life afforded many opportunities for problem-solving. To save money, we serviced our own machinery as much as possible, taking apart small engines, fixing broken tires, and sharpening lawnmower blades with a huge metal file. Sometimes we would get partway through a project, like putting a gearbox back together, and realize we'd missed an important earlier step. It was frustrating, and as kids we might kick up a fuss, because now whatever we were working on was going to take that much longer. But Dad knew what to say to calm us down and get us back on task.

“Oh boy!” he’d say, his voice getting higher and an offbeat smile spreading across his face, lifting our downtrodden spirits. “It looks like we hit a gumption trap. That’s okay! We’ll just work backwards until we can undo it, then keep going.”

From there on out, he made sure to explain the task even more thoroughly. Not to make us feel bad about messing up—most of the time it was his mistake anyway—but to keep us engaged and make the task more interesting. Gumption traps were no fun, but once we were done, we walked away, proud of ourselves for sticking with it.

Childhood Pursuits

When I was ten, I decided I wanted to achieve high levels of financial freedom; or, put colloquially, to get rich. One day, as Mom drove us through our town, we passed a quintessential Vermont covered bridge nestled in the trees. She pointed to it and said that over the bridge and up the hill lived a man who had gone out into the world and made a valuable piece of technology. He was paid handsomely for the technology and then returned to the area to create for himself any life he wanted. I understood then: money gives you the freedom to shape your life. That made me want a lot of money.

From then on, I spent a lot of time daydreaming about being rich. I wandered around our property playing make-believe about some time in the future when I would be free to do whatever I wanted to because I was wealthy. I even made up and regularly sang a song about it:

Too cool to be a dude

Too rich to be a man

Too strong to be a hero

Too smart to be a genius

And too tall to be ten feet tall

It must be Saul!

Do do do do, do do do

My lyrical rendition of my life goals ceased when my parents began requesting performances for guests.

Budding dreams of being rich soon began to surface as entrepreneurial passions, with my siblings as my first customers. Each week after church, we were allowed to go to the general store in town and buy small bags of candy. Rather than eating all of my candy, I sold the bulk of it to my siblings at an absurd markup, finding the profits far tastier than the sugar. I continued this for a number of months and expanded my offerings, until my parents finally stepped in and began enforcing a two-bag purchase limit, severely hampering the scale of my operation.

With my in-home enterprise thwarted, I moved on to our church, where the small congregation presented a new customer base. Each Sunday after the sermon ended, I sold farm-fresh eggs in the lobby, attracting several recurring customers. Before long, my product offerings grew to include loaves of bread I baked the night before, and then homemade caramel squares. I was raking in a good ten dollars or so a week before the preacher placed a ban on hawking my wares in a house of God.

Then I had an idea. From observing our chickens, it became evident that they only laid eggs for two to three years, yet I'd heard they could live up to a decade. That meant that unless someone decided to turn their post-laying hens into soup, they could be stuck taking care of them for years to come. Like us, other families were sure to have turned their chickens into pets and

couldn't bring themselves to butcher their flock. I saw this conundrum play out on our farm and decided to start a business to capitalize on the opportunity.

The Vermont Chicken Rest Home—or TVCRH, as I called it in conversation—provided a safe place for laying hens past their prime to live out the remainder of their days in relative peace. Families could come and visit their residents, which were all tagged with bright-green numbered ankle bracelets to tell them apart. I even created a simple Microsoft Access database to store their information.

I negotiated a pro-rata fee for my share of the chicken feed costs with Dad and ran an advertisement in the local newspaper to announce the business. A few people responded, and one of them became a customer. They placed four chickens, so at five dollars a month per chicken, I was generating steady revenue. I received no regular allowance, so I really appreciated this alternative income stream.

Rather than care for the chickens myself, I paid my next two youngest siblings twenty-five cents each per month to do it for me. After feed and employment costs, I was making eighteen dollars a month in net revenue, translating to 90 percent profit margins. Regardless of the small scale of my current operation, I felt that I understood the end-to-end process of purchasing supplies, selling products, managing finances, and paying my employees almost nothing so that I could keep most of the money. It was time to expand.

Next, I wanted to set up a larger company that focused on egg production. I found space next to our barn where an old building had once stood, but now all that remained was the crumbling cement foundation. I saw it as the perfect location to construct a small barn to house several hundred chickens, so I used Excel to create the business model to prove the potential for

massive profit. Best of all, our hens who were no longer laying could be passed on to TVCRH, which would result in substantial revenue for the rest home. I saw it as a failproof venture.

I put together a PowerPoint presentation and pitched my parents on the idea. They sat quietly listening until I ended with what I believed a reasonable ask of them, given the potential for profits: co-sign a five-thousand-dollar loan with me at our local credit union. I needed the up-front capital for construction costs, chicken procurement, and marketing. I was expecting some hesitation from them, followed by a short conversation that would result in a resounding agreement to join as business partners.

Unfortunately, that was not the case. Five thousand dollars was too much additional debt for them to take on, but they were adamant that I should continue my business pursuits. I was disappointed, but not disheartened. And, had I known that years later I would be designing business models and putting together similar pitch decks for Silicon Valley investors and billion-dollar companies, I would have seen the attempt for what it was: practice.

* * *

Following my failure to raise funding for my egg production scheme, my pursuits turned technical. I wasn't allowed to have any video games, but one dark evening in late 2002, Dad came home and gave me something that proved to be very important in my life. Back then, we rarely saw CDs, and USB drives had just come out, so it was a now-archaic floppy disk that Dad handed me. It could store just a few megabytes of data and contained an actual tape, but it held the bits of my future dreams—and successes.

I was sitting at our Windows 95 desktop computer in the classroom downstairs when Dad came in, and I didn't turn around until he tapped me on the shoulder.

"If you want computer games," he said, handing me the floppy disk, "make them yourself." With no further explanation, he left the room.

I popped the floppy disk into the computer and opened it. It contained several files written in a programming language called QBASIC, which stands for Quick BASIC. Its predecessor, BASIC, was the original programming language used by Apple and Microsoft computers, and QBASIC was designed to make BASIC more approachable for new programmers. I had never used QBASIC, but it was already installed on the computer, so I dove right in.

I opened the file containing the code for the first program, and lines of instructions filled the screen: BEGIN. GOTO. PRINT. CLEAR. Those and many more repeated throughout a file about eighty lines long. I located the menu item to run the program and clicked it.

When it loaded, I found myself inside a game consisting of only keyboard characters. I pressed the arrow keys to navigate across a grid of letters and symbols, consuming the spaces containing asterisks. It was a rudimentary, text-based hybrid of Pac-Man and Mario Bros, or so I would have thought, had I ever played those games.

I played for a moment and then quit the program to view the code again. I saw the asterisk within the code and changed it to a dash, then reloaded the game. Dashes now replaced all the asterisks. Excellent! I exited again and continued reading the code. I saw some numbers that I assumed represented dimensions, so I changed those and re-ran the game.

An error popped up on the screen. I'd broken the program somewhere else. The message showed the line number that contained the issue, but I didn't understand the actual message.

Luckily, QBASIC provided extensive help documentation, and by reading that and continuing to adjust other numbers in the code, I got the program working again. The characters had now scattered all over the screen, but it ran, and that was exciting.

My interest in computer programming grew steadily from that point on. Soon I was writing my own programs, which I ran on Frankenstein computers assembled from whatever hardware I could get my hands on. Learning about computers and how to control them has benefitted me immensely throughout the course of my life. But back then, I was just excited to finally have some computer games to play.

Early Homeschool

One of the greatest impacts on my life was my parents' decision to homeschool me and my siblings through high school, and the zeal with which they did so. For many years following my homeschool graduation, I harbored negative sentiments about this educational approach. But as I matured, I came to appreciate just how beneficial it was in shaping who I am today. That said, homeschooling methods vary, and my parents' system made for quite an experience.

One event in particular captures my parents' foundational homeschool ideology. It took place when I was eleven years old, on a dreary Sunday afternoon, late in the winter of 2003. The sky was overcast, and the cool air felt damp from the melting snow, some of which ran in rivulets down our long dirt driveway, carving small trenches capable of rocking cars. Several inches of old snow lay on the ground, and the once-massive piles at the top of the driveway left from winterlong plowing stood just a few feet high.

Near these sullen mounds, my parents had built a bonfire. Not the fun type to be surrounded by excited children and, if those children behaved, used for roasting marshmallows. No, this fire was different. It had a specific, functional purpose: it was lit to burn books.

Dad owned several cardboard boxes full of books. Ever since moving to Vermont, they'd remained stacked in the far corner of the woodshed, their cardboard having since turned a wet, earthy brown that blended in with the wooden walls. I never saw Dad open a box, and I had seen only a couple of the books around the house. The most surprising was a copy of Charles Darwin's *On the Origin of Species* that, for a few months, never left Dad's bedside table—something I found noteworthy, given the belief in Creationism he had developed despite being a professional scientist.

Over time, hints had been dropped about the forbidden texts. They were relics from Dad's secular days, a sinful appendage he had yet to part ways with even years after becoming a devout Christian. Dad had abruptly transitioned from an absolute hater of religion to a fervent Christian just after moving to Vermont, and in every other way his and our lives had been reshaped to fit with his new beliefs. Yet for some reason, the books had been spared—so far.

But now, the books had to go. It was time to sever the last link to his old life and give himself over completely to the Lord. Donating them wasn't an option. Then others would read them, which defeated the purpose. Someone might find them if they were left at the dump. Only destruction would do. Thus, a book burning was announced at church and took place a week later. Of the twenty or so church patrons who were invited only one showed up, and just to watch.

My parents struggled to get the fire big enough to handle the load of books. They were forced to layer them on gradually, slowly emptying each box, one book after another, ripping the

larger books into pieces. The covers were dull and thick, and the pages had yellowed. None of them had a dust jacket. One at a time, without speaking, my parents incinerated them. Dad almost held a couple back, but in the end, all were consumed by the flames.

As I watched the books smolder, I wondered what content my parents had deemed so dangerous that it merited physical destruction. How could every single book bear some fault justifying its demise? As a child, I suspected secular elements like swearing, violence, and sex—all taboo in any form in our home. But now, I presume they contained something my parents thought far worse: ideas at odds with their narrow lens of the world derived from their Protestant-leaning Christian doctrine.

This strange event exemplifies the extreme level of information control in our household. But my parents also made active, everyday modifications to what we were exposed to. Prior to allowing a book into the house, they both screened it for anything they deemed offensive or incompatible with the worldview they were manufacturing for us. It was common for them to black out passages of textbooks with permanent markers or to remove entire pages if they disagreed with the contents. Any mention of the theory of evolution or timelines dating back more than the six thousand years that the Bible claims the Earth has existed were removed. Any revealing feminine image, even an illustration a half of an inch tall, was covered to remove its, quote, “immodesty.” The woman on the front of Santitas tortilla chip bags met the same fate.

This controlling behavior extended to music, movies, and video games as well—my parents rejected anything containing even a hint of adult themes. I once negotiated hard for a copy of a video game called *Age of Empires*, and almost succeeded, until Dad read the word “evolution” on the back cover. Even though stated in the context of evolving from using wooden tools to metal ones, I left the store empty-handed.

The internet was also banned from our home for being a portal to the very things my parents were trying to keep hidden from us. We lived without the internet until I was fourteen, and when we did get online, content was heavily filtered by a religious service provider, and our connection was five thousand times slower than today's average speed. Watching videos or loading pages with more than a few images was impossible, which may be why no part of our homeschool experience used the emerging collection of online educational resources.

The reality filtering left a mark on my development, but what had the most lasting impact on me was the fear that loomed over the homeschool, and therefore our home. At the turn of the millennium, homeschooling was far less pervasive than it is today, and many states, including Vermont, had strict laws meant to protect children from abuse and ensure they were receiving an education. However, Vermont had a religious exemption that my parents used to fend off the State's access to our education, which was partly why they had decided to move there.

My parents believed their right to homeschool was at constant risk. So, looking for support, they joined a popular organization called Homeschool Legal Defense Association, or HSLDA, which still exists. The HSLDA bills itself as a defender of the rights of homeschoolers, pushing an us-versus-the-state message to sow fear among families. This gains them support, which they use to reshape public policy in ill-conceived ways.

The HSLDA even provided guidance for what to do if Child Protective Services arrives at a home to perform a purportedly biased evaluation of the conditions that would without question lead to the children being hauled off forever. We rehearsed the plan a few times over the course of my childhood, and it was simple, really: avoid going near the windows and get to the basement as fast as possible. That is, if someone comes to check if you are okay, run and hide.

* * *

In spite of its authoritarian elements, the early days of my homeschool education were mostly uneventful. Mom designed a curriculum consisting of mathematics, select historical topics, essay composition, grammar, calligraphy, and Bible studies. I also learned the basics of logic and dabbled in Latin. We covered almost no scientific topics, but some of that information trickled in as a result of Dad's being a scientist. Modern history about countries other than the United States was completely absent. We did no timed or closed-book testing. The first time I ever sat through a timed test was when I took my SATs.

With so many children present in the homeschool, our parents relied on the older siblings to support the younger ones with their schoolwork, especially in mathematics, which was time-intensive and required frequent check-ins. Typically, all structured schoolwork was completed by early afternoon. With strict limitations on computer use and no television in the house, we filled our time by running around outside half naked or cozying up near the woodstove with a book or game of Monopoly, depending on the season.

As the eldest child, my only educational support came from my parents, which was enough—at first. Mom had an associate's degree in biology and understood mathematics through high school algebra. She also knew how to write effective essays and excelled at explanation. She did an incredible job creating and managing a self-sufficient learning environment through my middle school years; and, had certain events not befallen the family around that time, I believe she would have continued to do so.

Dad helped out too. Throughout the day, we piled our finished schoolwork on the counter behind his seat at the dinner table, and each night after we ate, he reviewed our work to check on our progress. This provided very valuable oversight and ensured we maintained a steady pace. It was also a nice feeling, having Dad look over our work. He often shared ideas or suggestions for improvement and ended each review with encouragement.

Sometimes Dad would bring home a single news topic for discussion—our only exposure to what was happening in the outside world, due to our lack of internet and television. During our mandatory sit-down family dinners, we would critically examine the topic from different viewpoints, evaluating it within the context of what we did know about the world. Ideas carried a high value in our home, and everyone got to share theirs, provided they could shout loud enough. Eight people—all but one of them of Sicilian descent, with voices to match—packed around a table meant to seat six resulted in quite the din.

Part of our education was going to work with Dad at the university campus. We sometimes assisted him with lab work, or just did our schoolwork at a spare desk stacked with insect-dissection equipment and lined field notebooks. Compared to home, this work environment was serene, interrupted only by the occasional quiet hiss from a glass tank of Madagascar hissing cockroaches that rested perilously on a high shelf nearby.

The best work trips were when Dad took us into the field to gather data needed to design or conduct his experiments. His work then focused on controlling a beetle that kills hemlock trees, which entailed inspecting thousands of trees for signs of infestation, so it is no surprise that he recruited from his unpaid workforce. The trips were usually to Massachusetts, and featured an overnight motel stay after a small dinner out together, which was a rare treat. The trips were special, and I am grateful to have had those times with him.

Fun

Spending the golden years of my childhood being homeschooled on a family farm in rural Vermont during the early 2000s was, all-in-all, an incredible experience. With no internet or television, little music, and scant video game access, we invented our own fun. My siblings and I roamed our property, building forts out of bunches of massive green ferns, tearing apart the root structures of huge overturned trees in the forest, and damming streams to make frog ponds. We followed deer trails through the woods and scaled the side of the Big Rock, despite the risk of encountering striped garter snakes sunning themselves along its crevices.

Each spring, we went barefoot as soon as the sun had cleared a few small patches of sodden earth. Once it was warm enough for swimming, we would set up a circular above-ground pool in the backyard and spend hours each day in it. One of our favorite activities was creating powerful whirlpools by running around the edge of the pool. When the whirlpool got strong enough, we would drop down and jet around the pool in the current, then switch directions and swim as hard as we could against it. Once, we made our whirlpool so strong that the center of the vortex was completely cleared of water, which elated us.

Dad joined in our fun every chance he got. He researched and taught at the University of Vermont, commuting over an hour each way. During the summer when the days were long enough for him to get home before dark, he would pull up the driveway, rush inside to change out of his work clothes, and then come join us in whatever game we were playing on the Soccer Field. As a big family, there were enough of us to cobble together teams for soccer, kickball, wiffleball, and other group activities, which we did almost every day during the summer.

If Dad found us in the pool when he got home, he would run inside to swap into a bathing suit, burst out the back door, and run up to the edge of the pool. Then he'd turn around, take a

few big steps back, and yell, “Pirates of the ocean!”, spinning on his heels to face the pool, a big grin on his face.

“Pirates of the ocean!” we would scream in return as we cleared out to the sides of the pool, and then started counting him down. “Three! Two! One!” On cue, he would sprint to the pool, vault over the edge of it, and cannonball into the middle. As he surfaced, we would rush in and jump on him, begging for a game of Marco Polo, to be tossed into the air, or to make a whirlpool. Usually, we did a little of each, then dried off to go cook and eat dinner together.

One evening late in the summer of 2006, Dad arrived home while we were playing a game of soccer. Between us and the driveway lay a large, flattish rock encircled by flowers, their colors now muted in the dimming light. Dad didn’t want to miss out on the fun, so as soon as he turned off his car he ran straight towards the field, leapt onto the rock, and bounded off of it onto the grass to join our game. He didn’t care who was on what side—he just ran to the ball and kicked it in a direction. Following an on-the-fly negotiation, he joined the opposing team, since they were down a few points. Then he raced around in his work clothes, suit jacket and all, laughing and passing the ball back and forth.

Those were mostly happy days. We were sheltered to an extreme from the outside world and content with being together as a young family on our small Vermont farm. But our happiness was not to last. Soon, life as we knew it would end with the violent loss of someone we loved very much, and we would never be the same again.

I

Murder

Murder is not about lust and it's not about violence. It's about possession.

— Ted Bundy

Aunt Dawn

Mom's family was close, and while growing up I spent a lot of time with my maternal grandmother, aunt, uncle, and cousins. They all lived in New Jersey, but some of them came up each year to visit us on the farm, where sugar cereal and the Pokémon demon were equally unwelcome, and barn-chore participation was a must. Best of all was whenever my family could afford to join them on their annual Virginia Beach trip for a week of oceanfront fun—and memories of happy moments that will last a lifetime.

Each member of the New Jersey family was special in their own way, but Dawn, Mom's older and only sister, had a rare combination of grace and confidence that made her a wonderful person to be around. She was kind, forthright, and a wellspring of positivity for those around her. She sought to create moments of happiness for her family and succeeded many times. Most winters, she would make the icy trip up to Vermont with her son, who was two years older than me. We had a blast racing sleds down the long driveway, tackling each other down the slopes of towering snow piles, and eating maple drizzle candy off of the fresh snow. Dad made sure to rope him into hauling logs into the house for the woodstove and shoveling pathways, perhaps in the hopes that some physically demanding chores might be novel for a city boy, or maybe just to make use of the extra set of hands.

Sometimes members of Mom's family visited Vermont for birthdays, but in late November 2006, just my immediate family had gathered to celebrate one brother's ninth birthday. Birthdays were very exciting for us kids because they were the only times we were allowed to eat copious amounts of sugar, delivered on these special days in cake, soda, and ice cream. Somehow, my siblings' and my birthdays were all spaced two months apart. I do not know if this was by design, but it meant regular celebrations like the one on that fateful day.

The house was loud. Almost all the children were running around, full of tacos and hyperactive from soda, eagerly awaiting the forthcoming cake and ice cream. Our parents were upstairs, most likely collecting themselves before venturing back down into the fray.

The ring of the phone barely cut through the din. Our maternal grandmother always called to wish us a happy birthday, so the sound was not surprising even at nearly eight in the evening. The birthday boy retrieved the phone and answered, a goofy smile on his face in anticipation of a call just for him.

He stood still for a moment; then the grin changed to an expression of confusion. He didn't say anything, but pulled the phone away from his ear and called loudly for Mom, then ran upstairs to take the phone to her.

A moment later, a guttural scream sounded from upstairs. Everyone froze in place. A piercing wail followed, and then another scream that trailed away into silence as breath was exhausted.

"No, no, no!" screamed the voice a few seconds later, now recognizable as Mom's. "No, no..."

We looked at each other for an instant, then rushed upstairs and crowded into the narrow staircase outside our parents' room. I was far enough up the pile to view the scene. Mom sat on our parents' bed, her head drooping forward. Tremors ran through her whole body, like the painful retches that precede vomiting. Her brown hair hung in loose curls down the side of her head, hiding her face from view.

Dad sat on the edge of the bed, holding Mom's shoulders, likely all that prevented her from collapsing onto the mattress. At the sight of everyone heading for the room, he kicked the door shut and shouted for us to go downstairs and wait. His eyes said he meant it.

We retreated to the living room. The birthday boy was crying, but we interrogated him nonetheless, eventually learning that the call had indeed been from Grandma, but he didn't know what it was about. She had been crying and telling him to get Mom. It had been hard to understand her through the sobs.

Speculations as to what had happened began right away. Someone had died, that was clear. Nothing else would elicit such a strong reaction. Who was close enough to Grandma to justify such a response to their death? She cared for and loved many, so the options abounded.

Then someone remembered: after years of unsuccessful in vitro fertilization, our uncle and his wife had just welcomed a son into the world six days before. Something must have happened to the baby. That was it, we all agreed. The baby had died.

A moment later, Mom and Dad walked into the room. Mom's limp facial expression revealed little. She was dazed, not fully registering her environment. She sat down on the couch and held onto the youngest two children, pulling them close against her. Two more siblings sat on a small side couch, and one perched in the rocking chair. I stood near the dining room table.

Dad stopped to my right and faced the room.

A demand sounded from the crowd: "Whoose dead?" Then we all started talking at once, spouting off our hypothesis, trying to get ahead of the situation. We had already accepted that the baby had died. It was sad, but also plausible, given the infant was less than a week old. It was very unfortunate, but everything would be okay.

Dad's voice returned us to silence.

"Someone has died," he said. Then he stood quiet for a moment as he slowly scanned the room, looking at each of us in turn, as if to take in one last moment with a family that was about

to change forever. Finally, he continued, his voice trembling with the emotion he was working to hold back: “Aunt Dawn is dead.”

A few younger siblings burst into tears, while myself and another demanded to know what exactly had happened.

Dad told us, his voice monotone but clear enough for all to hear. “Andy ... killed her,” he said. He choked on the name of the ex-boyfriend from whom she had recently split, and the words emerged as a hoarse whisper. His eyes drifted above our heads, staring blankly into the distance, unable to believe the words coming out of his mouth. Then he repeated himself: “Andy killed her.”

The world became absent for me as I heard these words. I saw nothing and I felt nothing. I was still conscious, but just—gone. I thought I had fallen, but as reality came crashing back, I found myself in the process of throwing a nearby dining room chair across the room. I was sobbing and screaming. Everything was spinning around me, blurred into streaks. The sounds of other siblings breaking down were loud but distorted. An overwhelming wave of confusion clouded all my thoughts. Nothing made sense.

Dad rushed to me and held me, pulling my face into his chest with one arm and placing the other around my shoulders, gripping them, holding tight. I sobbed for a moment, hyperventilating as I tried to regain my hold on sanity. Once I could stand on my own, I started to pull away from him, but he resisted and held me for another few seconds, then gently released me. He had many other people to go comfort.

After a long time spent crying and asking for confirmation in many different ways to ensure we had heard what we had just been told correctly, we entered a state of shock and grew quiet. Everyone was numb, unable to comprehend the horror of the situation. Eventually, we

somehow pulled ourselves together enough to start packing. We had to drive down to New Jersey that night to be with the family. It was past ten p.m. by then, and we spent the next two hours loading our fifteen-passenger family van, then climbed in for the overnight drive.

The children escaped into brief periods of sleep on the way down. I rested for a couple of hours. After we crossed the border into New Jersey, I moved up front to sit with Dad and help keep him awake. Normally, it was effortless to spark a conversation between us. But now we could find nothing to say to each other. The drive continued in silence as the wisps of clouds crisscrossing the brightening sky began to turn pink in the rearview mirror.

Dawn had arrived.

* * *

We reached Grandma's house just past six in the morning. Her small two-bedroom condo was already filled with family members. My siblings and I drifted through them until we reached her. She sat on her sofa in the living room, her head drooped and her entire body slumped forward as if her spine had been removed. She seemed dead, save for the occasional weak, limp sob that caused her to heave, her head shaking side to side as the grief passed through her. We froze, too scared to move in closer.

Mom came up behind us, and at the sight of her now only living daughter, Grandma became animated again. They hugged one another and cried, choking for air as their sobs intermingled with broken words. Dad joined them, and then we piled in as well. Grandma's energy did not last, and she returned to her near-comatose state, unable to face the violent, unthinkable reality that was now hers and ours.

We exchanged many hugs with other family members, although some were inconsolable, having collapsed into dark corners of the house, their faces wet with tears that refused to cease. The home was a constant murmur of sorrow, pierced every so often by a sharp, short scream from Grandma.

“The bastard!” she shouted once, her voice lacerated by hours of crying. “I’ll kill him! I’ll kill the bastard!”

We all wanted to.

The next hour passed quickly as we made our rounds. After I had hugged everyone I could, I found myself in Grandma’s kitchen, leaning against the curved linoleum countertop, staring across the tiny room at the floor. People were talking now, some even about topics other than Aunt Dawn’s murder as they tried to distract themselves, even for a moment, from what was happening. Voices grew louder as everyone tried to remain heard. My thoughts drifted, away from the forced conversations and cramped condo, and away from the terrifying, dangerous world I had found myself thrust into.

Suddenly, an idea burst into my mind. It instilled in me a sense of urgency and the feeling that whatever I was thinking at that moment was important. I rushed to find some writing materials and procured a ballpoint pen and a small, square white napkin. I flew to the table in the corner of the kitchen and slid onto one of the wooden benches. Then I started to write, my pen pressed hard against the soft paper, flattening the small white bumps that formed the heart-shaped pattern on the napkin.

On the napkin I scrawled the basic plot of a fantasy book. It would star a young elven warrior-in-training, who possessed the unique ability to wield a double-bladed sword and be set in a world absent humans, where magic existed and good always vanquished evil in the end. The

note consisted of just a few words, but they were enough of a connection back to the thought to continue it later, when the harshness of the day had faded enough to leave me with more than an instant of consciousness free of debilitating emotional pain.

Already, though, I felt the weight of the characters on my mind. They were omnipresent, shrouded beings revealed as outlines in my mind's eye, yet unknown to me in their composition, character, and contributions to this story that now had to be told. The realness of their presence startled me, but my primary emotion—so difficult to detect beneath the overwhelming sorrow—was excitement. I looked forward to getting to know them and seeing them come alive in this book. Alongside this desire came a yearning to be home, away from everything and everyone, and lost inside my mind.

* * *

In the days that followed the murder, details began to emerge. Our parents did their best to keep some of the more graphic ones from my siblings and me, but to no avail. Mom's family was too big and talkative for secrets.

Based on the evidence, to say that Andy had murdered Aunt Dawn was an understatement. He slaughtered her. He cornered her in the kitchen of the house that they had shared when she went back to collect some of her belongings, then attacked her with a medium-sized knife that he found there. When she ran out of the kitchen, he chased her, stabbing her while she fled. She tore through the house, staggering between rooms as she grew weaker, her delicate fingers leaving long, bloody prints on the white-painted door frames.

Finally, she ran into the basement, hoping to bar the door behind her. But Andy forced his way in and continued his onslaught. When she collapsed, he sat on top of her, stabbing her chest over and over, continuing long after she was dead. Forensics would later count forty-two stab wounds in total, extending from her lower abdomen up to the middle of her neck. At her funeral, they dressed her in a thick, black turtleneck to hide the wounds. She had always hated turtlenecks.

Shortly after murdering Aunt Dawn, Andy left the house and walked down the road, covered in her blood. Neighbors quickly called the police, who apprehended him, but not before he called his sister to tell her what he had done.

“I killed the bitch,” he had said, as later revealed in court. “The bitch is dead.”

The slow trickle of these horrid details and the sustained interactions with the criminal justice system kept the emotional wound of Aunt Dawn’s murder open and agitated for over a year. The case never went to trial, but attending the arraignment and eventual sentencing testimonies meant sitting in the same room as Andy for hours while emotional letters written by my family were read. The entire time, he remained motionless, never turning to face us.

He apologized only once, just before his sentencing, in an attempt to display a shred of empathy to the judge in order to reduce his term. He was sentenced to twenty-five years and will be released in 2031, then immediately deported back to his native Poland. Twenty-five years of his undeserved life in trade for the entirety of Aunt Dawn’s was a hard calculus to accept—even more so, now that his time in prison is nearing its end—but I know he will never escape the eternal damnation of the Universe for what he did.

Impact on Me

Immediately after returning to Vermont following Aunt Dawn's murder, I began writing my book, which I titled *Elven Warrior*. I laid out the core plot beforehand, but most of it was a stream of consciousness. The words flowed onto the page, piling up into sentences that I got to experience as I wrote them. The living characters and budding fantasy world grew clearer in my mind, like shadows giving way to the light of morning. As I immersed myself, I found the escape I needed from the outside world. Within three months, the book had reached novel length, and I shed not one more tear until the last word was written—at which point I broke down sobbing and hyperventilating. I edited my manuscript for a month, then wrote a sequel in six weeks.

This world had probably been under construction in my mind for some time, given a childhood affinity for high fantasy novels. However, on that terrifying day at Grandma's house, an inner part of me delivered this book to protect me, as a means of coping with my tattered existence. It knew that to survive the difficult days ahead, I needed to escape my active thoughts—now tangled and frantic—so it devised a temporary shelter from the worsening storm of consciousness.

Around this time, I started getting headaches and migraines, which would plague me for the next fifteen years. I spent a lot of time lying in dim light on the couch in the living room, reading about the minds of serial killers, which became an obsession after Aunt Dawn's murder. I consumed a series of books on the use of behavioral profiling with mass murderers, searching for something to explain what could drive someone to kill others. The pattern was obvious: people who hurt others have often been hurt themselves. I still hated Andy after I learned that, but I did understand a little more.

A change taking place within me that was much less evident to myself and most others were the first symptoms of a mental health disorder, evidenced by my frenzied writing sessions. I wrote nonstop from late morning past midnight, sometimes skipping meals and always finding it difficult to sleep. It was now the depths of the winter of 2006, so the nights came fast and persisted. As I wrote hard, a comforting white light crept in from the edges of my eyes, and my vision became a tunnel that revealed only the words on the screen. All that existed was the book in front of me. Its completion was my anchor to the belief that, even in the face of this tragedy, I could continue forward in my life. Something very bad had happened to me, but it would not stop me.

At one point, Mom took me to our family physician to get input on my erratic behavior. They found nothing physically wrong with me but suggested that she continue to monitor the situation because it could be hypomania. This form of intense behavior was characterized by an obsession with specific projects, accelerated speech, increased agitation, and ephemeral bursts of extreme energy, which I was now regularly exhibiting. The doctor warned that if this were hypomania, I risked developing actual bipolar disorder in early adulthood. The topic was never discussed again, and I forgot all about the random office visit, whispered diagnosis, and anger in Mom's eye when someone suggested there might be something wrong with her child's mind.

Some of it did stick, however. What I heard then furthered a hypothesis of my own: in general, my mind worked a little differently than most peoples', and perhaps in some beneficial—albeit unpredictable—ways. Believing this made me start to spend more time thinking about my thoughts, and my mind became more interesting to me. I started to test my ability to manipulate its functions—specifically, the ability to self-induce sleep. I'd had trouble sleeping ever since Aunt Dawn's death. I often spent hours lying awake at night, staring off into

moonlit fields outside my bedroom window, unable to slow my racing thoughts. I was desperate for a solution, and my mind created one for me, then left it up to me to discover it.

I began by closing my eyes and visualizing a circular staircase, which I recreated from a memory of the last Virginia Beach house we had all—including Aunt Dawn—shared with one another. Its frame was made of cool, tubular metal painted black, but the pointy diamond treads lining the steps were almost painful to walk on barefoot. There were twenty-seven steps—at least in my mind—and by visualizing myself walking down them slowly, feeling the sharpness of the treads, counting the steps out one at a time, I descended into my inner mind.

At the bottom of the stairs lay a beach of pale sand, flickering in the faint glimmer of a moon filtering down through dark gray clouds. To my left stood a rainforest of trees indistinguishable from one another, and on my right an ocean of blues bordering on blackness that gently lapped the shore. I understood right away that my destination was the water.

I crossed the beach while focusing on the feeling of the cool sand caressing the sides of my feet. When I reached the edge of the water, I waded in without hesitation until I could no longer touch the bottom. Then I began to swim slowly, charting a course away from shore. A tentative calm came over me, so I continued, even slower, and then plunged beneath the surface.

Around me I saw only open ocean and the distant silhouettes of sharks, which were my greatest fear. But I knew that they would not hurt me and continued my descent until I reached the ocean's sandy floor. I now felt extremely tired and, with imagined hands made heavy by exhaustion, I started digging into the sand. A hole of sorts opened, and I shoved my body into it, headfirst, then passed into a state of unconsciousness. I awoke the next morning feeling the most rested I had been in months.

* * *

No part of life was left unaffected by the murder of Aunt Dawn, including our homeschool, which collapsed due to Mom's dwindling participation in our education. She withdrew from many parts of daily life to the shelter of her bedroom, no doubt struggling through some of the hardest days of her life. Dad tried to pick up the slack, even calling from work a few times a day to check in on us, but our volume of planned schoolwork plummeted. The stack of completed materials behind his seat at the dinner table grew smaller and smaller with each passing month.

I began to develop new skills in response to the reduction of structured learning, specifically the ability to self-direct my education. There was still plenty I wanted to learn, so I did the best I could to work through the available resources on my own. My primary interest was math, and I made it partway through precalculus before my lack of trigonometry skills hampered my progress.

In the spring of 2008, several weeks after my sixteenth birthday, I finally realized that my parents would no longer be able to support me in my math studies, and that, in general, our homeschool was finished. I was stuck on a precalculus problem that I mostly understood, but again the trigonometry element was causing issues. I'd tried teaching myself trigonometry and made it through the basics. But when I hit a wall, I'd moved on to precalculus, which at first required only an understanding of algebra.

I asked Mom the math question when she drifted by, but she did not know how to approach the problem and said to check with Dad later. At this point, he was coming home from work and immediately cooking dinner, so I waited to ask until after we'd eaten, when things had

calmed down. Once the table was cleared, I spread out my textbook and notes to show him where I needed help.

Dad studied the page for a moment, then checked the solution to the problem to see if he could work backwards from it. Unable to do so, he flipped back a few pages in the textbook to see if he knew any of the more fundamental information. Finding that he did not, he continued to flip further back into the book until he reached the beginning.

Dad closed the book gently, its blue-gray cover settling silently into place as the pages condensed onto one another. Without looking at me, in the most quiet and crestfallen voice I had ever heard from him, he admitted he did not know how to help me. He walked away without saying anything else, and I never asked for help with another math problem.

It may seem unthinkable that I did not immediately seek help on the internet, which had been introduced to our household two years prior. In hindsight, I wish I'd done exactly that. I am not sure what materials would have been available online in 2008, or if they would have been accessible on my slow, heavily-filtered connection, but surely something out there could have helped me.

The fact is, I already felt a sense of accomplishment in having made it into precalculus, written two novels, and taught myself computer programming. I decided that I had pushed my home education far enough. I also started to realize that I was outgrowing my household, and perhaps my community in general. This made me start thinking more seriously about my future and what I wanted to do with my life once I made it out into the world.

Teenage Transitions

In June 2008, I started working at a local family-owned hardware store as a salesclerk, which to date is still the most fun job I've ever had. Within my first week, I was teaching other employees how to better use their BASIC-based computer software, and before long, I had memorized the codes for thousands of individual products and stepped up to organize the store's inefficient delivery system. Most engaging of all was learning the basics of the plumbing and electrical trades from customers and coworkers, which opened up new opportunities to work with my hands.

The owners were quick to recognize my eagerness to work hard and do a good job. I was soon given other responsibilities, like ensuring adequate inventory for special-ordered items and managing invoicing for equipment rentals. A coworker nicknamed me the "Little Tyrant" due to my focus on efficient operations, and a few employees bristled at my intrusion into their work. However, some of our largest customers and our outside sales representatives began to work exclusively with me because they knew I did my best to get their orders right—something not everyone else seemed to care enough to do.

A few times, my quality of service was aided by the attention I had started paying to unconscious dreams that seemed linked to the future. They occurred every few months just prior to waking and were always about bringing some random tool or other item to work. There was no logical reason for doing so, but after ignoring the dreams a couple of times and finding myself empty-handed when a customer needed a quick adjustment to some strange part they had lugged in, I began acting on them.

Twice, customers were surprised by my having had such a seemingly random object on hand. This led me to consider these forward-looking dreams alongside the leaping of a fantasy

world into my mind. When I reflected on this cognitive activity, I saw that my brain was operating in two unique ways: a conscious state in which I spent most of my waking time, intermingled with some other background mode that seemed to possess useful abilities. Dream-based communication was a strong indicator that the source was subconscious, and it fascinated me to consider the possibility of a clever inner machine capable of predicting future states in reality with moderate accuracy.

* * *

Once I had a job that involved interacting with the public, my social network began to expand. It was a community where everyone knew everyone else, and—despite my lack of frequent public socialization up to then—I found it easy to develop good relationships with the people I worked with and served. My uncommon lack of popular-culture exposure elicited incredulity among my coworkers, but beside that, it was not immediately evident that I had been homeschooled. People were often surprised when I told them so.

What caused the most confusion was how young I looked. Although I was sixteen, I appeared to be no older than thirteen, and that did not change much during the four years I worked at the hardware store. My baby face is a genetic trait I inherited from Dad, who even in his late forties was sometimes mistaken for my older brother. Due to my youthful appearance, some people did not take me seriously at first, but that changed when they saw me exhibiting maturity beyond my assumed age.

Not long after starting at the hardware store, I was given permission to mingle with other teenagers at a youth group hosted by a church twenty-five minutes from home. While, again, I

was able to get along with others, I did note a marked difference between myself and my peers. Self-directed pursuits such as my novel composition and learning computer programming were not practiced by others, nor did they exhibit a general curiosity about the world. I found this disappointing and began to group my friends into two categories: those I anticipated maintaining a long-term, post-Vermont relationship with, and those I did not. Only one person made it into the former category, and we remain close friends to this day.

In these new environments full of people my own age, my hypomania began to cause problems for me. If I was finding it difficult to socialize, I consciously induced the release of chemicals into my body to get myself hyped up. It is hard to describe how this worked, but the sensation was of pulling my ears closer to my head and thinking about the state I wanted my mind to be in. A warm rush would fill my brain, my spine would tingle, and I would be energized and ready to engage, having successfully induced an ephemeral state of hypomania.

My actions when I was hypomanic were sometimes inappropriate. My ego swelled, and I was often unkind to those around me. I commanded rather than participated. The people around me either recognized that I had extreme moments and tolerated—and sometimes benefited—from them, or they justifiably wanted nothing to do with me.

* * *

Another two years passed, and still tragedy loomed over our family. Each event, no matter how joyous, was overcast with the absence of the life that had been stolen from us. Slowly, however, many of us were processing the grief. Little by little, our lives, although forever marred by the loss of Aunt Dawn, began to regain shreds of normalcy.

I turned eighteen in May 2010 and officially completed my homeschool program, although I hadn't done any schoolwork in over a year. I enrolled in the local community college and took a couple gen-ed classes to reduce future tuition costs and free up time at a four-year school, which I knew needed to be my next step. The classes were good exposure to a formal educational environment, and all reinforced my desire to pursue a higher-quality education than was available near home.

Despite my plans to attend a university, I wasn't sure exactly which career I wanted to pursue and did not prioritize identifying one. A mixture of youthful ignorance, unfamiliar emotions, and teenage hormones led me to stop thinking seriously about my future, except for one thing: I needed to get out of rural Vermont. The lure of the world beyond my community had grown stronger as I watched many local friends head down unhealthy paths in life that I refused to accompany them on. I already had enough problems, most stemming from the volatile romantic relationship I was in. My mood swings were also worsening, especially during the winter, when I succumbed to moderate seasonal depression and became unhappy, irritable, and bitter.

My relationship with my parents—especially Dad—had grown challenging. Fathers and teenage sons often clash with one another, and we were no exception. His inability to grant me adequate autonomy as I got older and my adolescent belligerence resulted in many fights—some physical—as I strove to establish myself as a young adult in a household that afforded very little personal freedom. Things reached a breaking point in January 2011, the first time my parents left me alone for the weekend. Perhaps as payback for eighteen years of suppression, I threw a destructive New Year's Eve party at our house. For this, Dad justifiably kicked me out.

I moved in with a friend from work, and late one morning six weeks later, as I was approaching nineteen, I found myself alone in the living room, sitting on the beat-up couch. I had already drunk one raspberry Smirnoff Ice and was working on a bubbly second. As it, too, disappeared, I paused to consider my drab surroundings and asked myself: Is my life heading in a good direction? The obvious answer was a resounding no. My gap year was almost over, and it was time to move on to a four-year school as planned.

I opened my laptop and began researching military colleges. My life lacked structure, which I believed I would find in that environment. There are surprisingly few military colleges in the United States, so I had a short list to work from. Once I filtered those schools down to institutions still accepting rolling admissions—as the normal enrollment periods had passed—only a few remained.

One in particular stood out: Norwich University, the nation's oldest private military academy and the birthplace of the Reserve Officers' Training Corp (ROTC), located just over an hour south in Central Vermont. Its student body was split in two: the majority participated in the Corps of Cadets program, and the remainder made up a civilian coalition. Cadets, although technically not members of the military, were presented on the Norwich website as being subjected to similar levels of physical rigor and lifestyle limitations. Cadets wore United States Army uniforms, held different ranks, and were expected to uphold the military traditions instituted by the university. It was exactly the challenge and structure I was looking for.

The fact that Norwich was located in Vermont didn't stop me. It felt like the right distance: close enough for my first solo venture, but far enough from home for me to start building my own life. I wrote an introduction letter and submitted an application that afternoon for Norwich's mathematics program, although after I researched their degrees further, I shifted to

their cybersecurity program. A few days later, I made up with my parents, moved back home, and began to train for the physically demanding experience I believed awaited me.

Several weeks later, Dad burst into my bedroom while I was exercising, holding a big white envelope with Norwich's maroon logo on it.

"Only acceptance letters come in envelopes this big!" he said excitedly as he shoved the mail into my hands. He was beaming, and once I opened it, so was I. I had been accepted and granted an \$11,000 presidential scholarship that would cover a third of my costs.

Dad grabbed me in a huge hug. Tears filled our eyes as we clapped one another on the back, laughing and rocking side to side. I was proud of myself for getting my life back on track. My future felt more under my control than it had in years, and I saw only brighter days ahead. I couldn't have imagined then how much pain would assail my family yet again before my first year at Norwich was over.

II

Dad

Anyone can be a father, but it takes someone special to be a dad...

— Wade Boggs

Life With Dad

Scott David Costa, my father, was born in upstate New Jersey in 1957, the second youngest of five children. He grew up amidst the counterculture social movement in the early 1970s before joining the United States Navy at age seventeen. After serving for several years, he was honorably discharged for back issues, and took with him a collection of stories ranging from scrubbing toilets with toothbrushes to his ship almost shooting down a passenger jet.

When I was a child, Dad entertained my siblings and me with these no doubt heavily embellished tales of his Navy days. But I know very little about what happened in his personal life between his discharge from the Navy in 1977 and meeting my mother thirteen years later. I know that he had been married in his mid-twenties, had a daughter whom we saw very little of growing up, and had survived some rough times that necessitated begging for food on the streets. Other than that, this period of his personal life is a mystery to me.

It seemed as if Dad's life had begun anew the moment he met Mom. His world revolved around his new family, a sharp contrast to the one he had started previously, which, as I later found out, he'd left only a year after my half-sister was born. Dad had plenty of personal stories about meeting, wooing, and marrying Mom, but very few about his adult life before that. My siblings and I rarely pried, although small snippets of his past life would sometimes be revealed through the lessons he tried to impart on us, such as how dressing like a slob had gotten him fired from working at a post office.

Professionally, I know a bit more. Dad obtained a master's in agriculture from Rutgers University in the late 1980s, when he was in his early thirties, after which he joined the staff of Merck Pharmaceuticals. He grew to abhor his work because it sometimes involved animal testing, including on cats and dogs. Although he was making a significant salary, in 1992, just

after I was born, he decided to leave Merck and pursue a doctorate in entomology at North Carolina State University in Raleigh, despite the income reduction to a meager annual student stipend.

By the time Dad completed his PhD in North Carolina in 1999, my next three siblings had arrived. With the degree in hand, it was now time to realize his next dream: owning a farm. He secured a job as an assistant researcher at the University of Vermont and moved us north, and the story you have been reading thus far began.

Dad was an intense person, no doubt due in part to the pain of having been physically, emotionally, and sexually abused by his mother as a child, which included regular beatings with a bat and being locked in the basement in the dark for days. He was surprisingly open with our family about the trauma he had experienced—never to contrast it with our upbringing or to make us feel privileged by our lack of abuse, but to demonstrate his own origins and how they had shaped him as a person.

Dad was prone to mood swings that sometimes came out of nowhere and later abated just as unpredictably. I am certain that he had a mood disorder, likely genetically inherited from his mentally unstable mother. He often exhibited periods of unbounded passion that extended beyond the normal range of emotion, and at other times would drift into ruts of sadness, although not for long. His family brought him much joy that, I believe, staved off the worse of his depression.

The most unsettling trait of my father's personality was his ability to flip between emotional states when the situation required it. Mom and Dad fought a lot, especially after Aunt Dawn was murdered, which placed a huge strain on their marriage. They often could not make the five-minute drive to church on Sundays without erupting in a shouting match. Within

moments of entering our massive van, Dad would be yelling over Mom while my siblings and I sat silently in the back, sometimes crying and pleading with them to stop or to get a divorce. Then, when we reached church, Dad had no problem switching to a different mode for public display. A smile would wash away his angry expression, and his voice would drop to normal levels containing no trace of the recent stream of unpleasant words. We would enter the church with him seemingly back to normal but everyone else still frightened and wiping away tears as we tried to prepare ourselves to be around other people.

Mood instability and argumentative tendencies aside, Dad was an amazing person and wonderful father to his six younger children. Never have I met someone who so fearlessly loved and cared for his family. He was supportive of our ambitions—provided they did not conflict with his overdeveloped moral code—bragged about things we had done to friends and colleagues nonstop, and always sought to help maintain amicable relationships between us. He loved spending time with us, and when he joined our backyard games, it was more like having an exuberant older sibling around than a parent.

Dad's intellect allowed him to contribute to a conversation on any subject. He could tie whatever was being discussed back to an area he was knowledgeable in—of which there were many—by crafting clever analogies and thereby expanding the discussion. He could strike up a conversation with anyone, from babies to the elderly. He had an especially soft spot for individuals with disabilities. I always admired his ability to make every person he met feel like they mattered, regardless of who they were.

However, an uncontrollable sense of justice beset my father. He took it too far at times, such as when he launched an affirmative-action case against some coworkers at the university for their blatant discrimination of a Middle Eastern doctoral candidate. Even the candidate did not

want the issue raised, but Dad couldn't stop himself. Unfortunately, the proceeding left a mark on both their professional reputations, and Dad was ostracized by many of his colleagues for years—and by some, forever. This led to a period of stagnation in his career, which exacerbated our family's financial situation.

Although Dad had a PhD and worked at a university, our family still lived paycheck-to-paycheck. Raising six children on his salary was made possible only by our fortune of good health. Food costs alone placed a huge burden on the family finances. Milk for six growing kids cost hundreds of dollars a month when we reached our peak consumption of two gallons a day.

Dad went grocery shopping every two weeks, right after his paycheck cleared. He could fill an entire cart with groceries for a hundred dollars, although this was a quarter-century ago. After arriving home in a car stuffed with groceries, we would unload the bags as a team and deposit them on the kitchen floor. One evening, he came into the house with the last bag to find us rifling through the rest, looking for a can of black beans or peaches we could snag and demolish before dinner. The family had hit its lowest financial point, and by the end of each two-week period, food was scarce. This was especially true outside of dinner time, which was when Dad was around to make sure we got fed. That meant our stomachs were empty as we tore open each plastic bag in search of a snack.

Dad swooped in, like an eagle scaring away vultures from a carcass. “This is it, for two weeks!” he shouted, not mad, but to make sure we all heard. “Once you eat this, it's gone. No more food.”

That sobered us up, and we backed off. We understood the gravity of the situation well enough to do our best to keep our hands off the food, even when Dad wasn't home. Sometimes, though, we just got hungry.

Similar obvious displays of our financial struggles were evident to anyone paying attention, which, as the eldest child present, I was. Dad wore his lack of money on his sleeve and never seemed embarrassed by it. When his sneakers started to fall apart, he would duct-tape them back together and wear them until the tape was worn through, then wrap them up again. If he lost a lens from a pair of glasses or if one of the temples fell off, he would continue to wear the glasses as if nothing had happened. He never worried about being judged by others.

There were other regular reminders of our financial situation. We made it to very few family vacations in Virginia Beach, and group presents were the norm for Christmas. Money entered our parents' conversations often enough for me to realize that nearly every decision they made was determined by their bank account balance. This balance remained under constant observation, and was kept up-to-date using a blue plastic checkbook register containing lined pages full of tallies of the checks deposited, bills paid, and remaining funds.

One evening, as I made my way to bed, I found Mom sitting at our small kitchen table hunched over this register. Her head was resting in her left hand as she held a plain blue Bic pen in her right. The checkbook register lay open on the table in front of her, its pages filled with her neat handwriting.

She didn't look up at me when I passed by. Her brow was furrowed, and a silent murmur of calculations caused her lips to move slightly as she worked through each line. She flipped back a page in the register to double-check her math, the point of the pen hovering over the numbers as she scanned down the page, until reaching the final balance listed. Then she flipped forward again to verify that the value on the next page was the same.

Although Mom struggled with many of her household and homeschool responsibilities after Aunt Dawn's death, she continued to manage the checkbook register. She spent evenings

like this one poring over it, looking for inaccuracies in her tallies or disparities with bank statements, so that my parents knew exactly how much money they had. Sometimes, this soothed the worry that Dad might not have enough money to buy gas to get to work that week. But it could just as easily lead to a tearful conversation between her and Dad when the uncertainty of being able to make ends meet became overwhelming. Dad always did his best to comfort her when that happened, especially if she had made a mistake that left them and us staring down another two weeks where any small, unexpected cost would have derailed life entirely. But, somehow, we always made it through.

A Bug's Life

Dad was fascinated by the interactions between small living things, which is what led to his PhD in entomology and subsequent career as a researcher in the field. His focus throughout was finding ways to control insects using natural means rather than pesticides. For his PhD, he studied how a specific bacteria slowed the growth and reproduction of Colorado potato beetles, a significant pest impacting multiple crops to this day. Later, at the University of Vermont, he developed a method of using whey to enhance a fungus that kills hemlock woolly adelgid—an invasive aphid-like insect that decimates hemlock trees by sucking them dry of sap and injecting them with toxins. Those days in the field with him have left me unable to walk past a hemlock tree without flipping a branch over to check for signs of infestation.

Dad's love of insects was renowned throughout our family and community. Our first few summers in Vermont, he hosted "Backyard Bug Days" and invited families to bring their children to look at the huge cases of pinned insects he'd borrowed from the university. Young eyes lit up at the gleaming green beetle exoskeletons, bright blue butterflies wider than a hand,

and lanky yellow grasshoppers that looked ready to leap off the Styrofoam. A sense of excitement and wonder pervaded the gatherings, fueled by the simple yet engaging explanations about insect life provided by Dad throughout the event.

The same backyard was the location of a special entomological occurrence that happened several times in the early 2000s. In the fall, an orange river of Monarch butterflies would flow through our backyard as the summer's emergents began their long migration to the forests of Mexico. We would walk gently out into the living current as the insects wove around us, save a few whose soft wings brushed against our skin as they flew by. It felt like stepping into a fantasy world.

Dad's passion for insects was infectious, and as a child, I ran my own backyard experiments. I sequestered Colorado potato beetle larvae to a rusty red toolbox in order to observe their rate of food consumption and measure how long it took them to die after they were deprived of nutrients. I used natural pesticides to purge rose chafers from long comfrey leaves and set ground traps to monitor the insect ecosystem. Then I assembled my own bug collection, full of specimens painstakingly pinned down to hold their body parts in place as they dried. I even exchanged beetle samples with a researcher in France after meeting him in the blogosphere.

The appreciation for insects passed on to me by Dad was shared in different degrees by many other people he came in contact with, especially the students of the entomology basics class he taught at the University of Vermont. He titled it *A Bug's Life*—after contacting Disney for their approval to use the movie title—and in its second year, it grew to be the largest elective class on campus. Having attended many of the lectures myself, I know why: Dad made the class fun. A lot of fun.

To raise awareness for the class, Dad constructed a giant purple caterpillar head using papier mâché and chicken fencing, to which he connected a long, green sheet striped with yellow paint. He attached wooden rods to the sheet every few feet, then enlisted a few of us to march around campus with him, one of us leading the way by peering through the peepholes in the huge mask, and everyone else doing their best to alternate raising and lowering our segment to mimic the movement of a caterpillar. All the while, Dad would be handing out flyers about his class. It all worked out much better than I had expected, except for when we wormed our way into the cafeteria and got tangled up amongst the diners. As we writhed our way back outside, bumping into ourselves and others, Dad temporarily shifted to distributing warm apologies instead of colorful printouts.

A Bug's Life served as a case study in how education can be engaging and fun for everyone involved. The classes bordered on entertainment—the excitement in Dad's voice carried across the giant lecture hall unaided by a microphone as he explained the unique biology of insects, the ways in which they can cause harm, and their critical importance to our survival. His passion for his field was evident, and he truly cared that each student left his class appreciating the importance of these small creatures we take for granted.

The coursework was of a similar spirit. Every student received a take-home project in the form of a Monarch butterfly larva in its cocoon, their task being its successful emergence into a full-fledged adult insect. Even failures received a passing grade, provided the student had recorded their effort. When the topic of insect navigation was reached, a few brave volunteers would come up to the front of the classroom to demonstrate the waggle dance performed by bees to communicate the location of resources to their hive mates. Insect anatomy week included the live dissection of a giant Madagascar hissing cockroach to demonstrate how its limbs could be

manipulated by pressing on different areas of its brain. Most enthralling of all was when Dad would bring in a forensic entomologist to share gruesome real-life stories about how insects are used to catch murderers.

Dad maintained this energy throughout the semester, which culminated with the aptly named “Bug Banquet” in place of the last lecture. It featured insect dishes made by our family and volunteers from class, and it was attended by the students, our family, and other professors. Once, even the dean showed up, probably just to see with her own eyes the scores of people eating insects at a university-sanctioned event. Trays of celery sticks loaded with peanut butter and crickets, stacks of mealworm crackers, and amber lollipops containing scorpions were all in abundance, alongside several insect-free dishes, for those who wished to abstain from the more eclectic options.

Insects were more than just a field of study for Dad. For as long as I knew him, they were a way for him to share his passion for life in all its forms with those around him. Even though technically he spent his whole professional career coming up with natural ways to kill them, it was obvious to all: Dad loved bugs. They seemed to reassure him that some form of intrinsic self-worth existed within each of us. Through his devotion to understanding these tiny creatures and sharing what he learned with others, I believe he was trying to say something: “If even the bugs are special, then boy oh boy, we sure must be too.”

Dad Gets Sick

I started at Norwich University in the fall of 2011 as a member of the Corp of Cadets. New cadets arrive a week early to participate in “Rook Week,” during which they are subjected to five a.m. cannon-fire alarms, having their beds torn up and mattresses flipped by senior cadets,

being constantly screamed at, and drilled on different marching maneuvers. Some parts of the experience were fun, though, like rappelling down a wooden tower or hiking a mile down a river carrying as big a rock as possible. Rock abduction was later banned after a student crushed and lost a finger.

Norwich was not at all what I expected. I had been training hard all summer and was ready for a physical challenge and sensical structure. But neither of those were present. Many students were not in shape, which meant no engaging physical group challenges were doled out. Power was wielded arbitrarily by people only two years our senior. This was an environment of control, not cultivation.

These shortcomings I could accept and tolerate, but once the cadets in command started wasting huge amounts of my time, I decided it wasn't for me. They made us rooks spend hours standing with our backs against a wall for no reason other than because they could make us do it. That was a misuse of my time, effort, and tuition; so, after a couple of weeks, I left the Corp and became a civilian student.

By that point, civilian housing on campus was full, so I temporarily switched to commuting from home. That worked out okay because I'd been waived through my freshman programming classes, and the sophomore replacements lined up nicely with my schedule. Everything seemed to be going well, until just after the deadline to drop classes had passed, when the university's administrative department notified me that they had reduced my \$11,000 presidential scholarship to a tenth of its original value.

The university stated that my becoming a commuter student had reduced my living expenses, so my lower school costs no longer justified a scholarship. They refused to reverse their decision even after being informed that the situation was temporary and I already had

housing allocated for the next semester. Nor did they reinstate the scholarship when I moved back on campus.

That was a lot to take in, and it was my first experience with institutionalized greed and abuse of power. I almost left Norwich for a different university out of state, but stayed for two reasons: the cybersecurity program I had switched to was one of the best in the country—despite the school’s general lack of academic rigor—and a standout professor had taken a keen interest in my success. These were enough to retain me, and staying close to my family ended up being a wise decision.

Although my first semester at Norwich was chaotic, compared to the emotional turmoil that awaited me in subsequent ones, it was enjoyable. I liked being around people with similar interests, and I was ready to further immerse myself in my education once I moved back onto campus. Life seemed to be turning over a new leaf—which it was, just not in the way I thought then. Before the end of the next semester, my life and my mind would be shattered. For the remainder of my time at Norwich, I would be picking up the pieces of a life I no longer recognized as my own.

* * *

I moved back onto campus at Norwich the spring 2012 semester. The dorms were fun, and the noise didn’t bother me as much as I had anticipated. Being on campus meant that classes were no longer a long drive away, and now I could join friend groups I had hovered at the periphery of as a commuter. My class load was heavy, but I was excited about each course. The semester got off to a great start.

When my first spring break arrived in March, I envied those of my new university friends who were headed to warmer climates. Most students had already left for break by the time I finished my last class and started the hike to my dorm from the main part of campus. It was the day before the official start of break, and the sidewalk leading up the steep hill to my dorm was layered with ice, so I walked in the snow next to the slick concrete to avoid a trip to the infirmary.

Halfway up the hill, I took out my phone and called Grandma. I needed to talk to her in the relative privacy of the outdoors before getting to my room. Dad hadn't been feeling well, and he'd gone to the hospital earlier that day to have some tests run. She would have heard the results. My parents had said they would share them with my siblings and me that weekend, but with my classes done and my mind cleared of coursework, I wanted to know now. Grandma had always been honest with me and would give me a straight answer.

Dad's back had bothered him for years, but the pain had recently gotten much worse. His local doctor had diagnosed it as a slipped disc, but when he started rapidly losing a considerable amount of weight, it became clear that something else was wrong. Being away at college removed me somewhat from the situation, but I worried that the signs were pointing towards cancer.

Grandma answered the phone quickly. Her voice was dull and coarse. From the other end of the phoneline, I assumed she had a cold. Now, I know she had been crying.

I asked her if she had heard the results, and she said yes, and that the doctors had found something, but it wasn't anything to be concerned about. Mom and Dad would have more details when they talked to us. I hung up the phone, confident that Grandma had told me the truth. She always had before, even when it hurt or she shouldn't have. This time, however, she lied to me.

* * *

I felt uneasy on my drive home the next day, and my attention escaped to my surroundings. Along the roadside, stratifications of dirt on what'd once been fresh, clean snow revealed how many times huge, orange snowplow trucks had passed by that winter. I knew that out in the untouched fields, the fluffy powder of early winter had turned into tiny ice balls crusted by an inch of snow that collapsed into a sinkhole when stepped on. A childhood memory of taking then-big steps into such craters left by Dad flickered in my mind, and I was disturbed by the anxiety it now elicited. I reassured myself that everything would be okay. It had to be. My family had suffered enough.

When I arrived home, I found things almost as I had left them. Dad did indeed look a little thinner, which was surprising, because I'd just seen him a few weeks ago. However, his demeanor revealed no apparent signs of distress, so I held fast to Grandma's reassurances.

"I know it's nothing," I said to Mom at one point, trying to gauge her response. She looked at me for a moment, but did not speak.

"We'll talk soon," she finally muttered, then walked away. That left me slightly concerned, but still anchored to my belief that everything was going to be fine. This was simply another case of my parents making much ado about nothing.

At last, Mom and Dad took my next brother and me up to the bedroom that the two of us had built for ourselves above the woodshed a few summers back. It was a large room, but most of the space was cut off by the sharp slope of the roof, and the edges of the room were almost inaccessible. My bed was located in the only dormer, and my brother and I sat on the end of it as

my parents positioned themselves on the far end of a couch, closer to each other than I'd seen in a long time.

"I know it's nothing," I all but shouted. "I talked to Grandma yesterday, and she said they found something, but it's nothing to be concerned about."

My parents looked at me but were silent. Then Mom started to speak, staring straight at us without seeing as she repeated words that were clearly rehearsed.

"In our bodies are cells," she began, "and those cells are constantly replicating."

I held my breath. We had covered very little biology or anatomy in our homeschool curriculum, but I remembered enough about cancer to know it had to do with cell division. But so did benign tumors, so I clung even harder to my fading hope that everything was going to be okay.

"Sometimes," she continued, "those cells get out of control, and they begin replicating the wrong way." She paused and drew in a deep breath. She reached back and placed a hand on Dad's thigh, and he rested his own hand on hers. "When that happens, they call that, well, they call that..."

Her voice trailed off and she looked at Dad, unsuccessfully trying to hide the tears welling in her eyes. Her free hand moved to the surface of the couch to prop herself up. My heart began beating rapidly. Something was very wrong.

"When that happens," Dad continued after a pause, "they call that cancer. I have stage four pancreatic cancer."

For a few seconds I sat frozen, unable to think. My thoughts resumed slowly, operating with only basic concepts. Cancer. Stage four. Cancer has only four stages. Dad has late-stage cancer. Dad is going to die.

“What are the numbers?” I demanded, unable to breathe. I needed more data. A torrent of emotions was being held at bay, and I hung onto each detail, hoping for something that would render my fear excessive.

“Five percent,” he said, but he couldn’t finish the sentence. His will to break his children’s hearts yet again had forsaken him.

Mom regained enough strength to continue, and she did, swallowing her tears.

“Five percent,” she said quietly. “Five percent of patients live one year. They told us that Dad has three months.” She hid her face with her hands and bent forward as she started to cry.

Hearing that my beloved father had three months left to live shattered the person I had been going into the room that day. Finding out that the man who had been my foundation in life would soon be gone ripped me apart at my core. My mind fragmented until it was not my own, and nothing made sense. I could not think. So I ran.

I screamed and staggered for the door, bolting out of the room and down the steep stairs. I was still screaming as I ran out into the driveway, choking on the tears that were flowing in hot streams down my cheeks. I turned in a dazed circle, trying to think of somewhere to go where I would be safe from what I had just heard. Then I started running away from the house, past the Big Rock, beyond the edge of our property, and through the neighbor’s cow field, until I reached a square wooden post set in a large cylinder of concrete on the opposite side.

My arms flew around the post, and I held onto it as tight as I could. The world spun in every direction, even with my eyes closed, but the post remained still, an island untouched by the sea of pain, anger, and disbelief circling around me. I wrapped my legs around the post and clung even tighter, my mind still unable to process what was happening.

When at last I cracked my eyes open, through the tears I saw Dad running towards me as fast as he could, stumbling in the deep snow. His faded and duct tape-patched canvas coat hung open, and his tall rubber boots crushed my footprints as he leapt towards me. Each step he took defied the weakness and immense pain already instilled by the cancer. But nothing could stop him—not when one of his children needed him.

He reached me and threw his arms around me, hugging me from behind. The sharp edges of the post dug into my arms as he embraced me, his head next to mine. His cool, woodsy scent washed over me, and I wanted the moment to never end, because here I was safe, because here I had Dad with me. He held me for a long time, unflinching, unyielding in his need to be there for his child.

“I’m going to beat this thing,” he said, but I knew him far too well to miss the doubt in his voice. “I’m going to fight and fight, and beat this thing.”

Although I perceived his doubt, Dad’s words and embrace gave me the strength I needed to release the post and return to the house. Tears continued to stream down my face, and I wept as my parents informed the other children, also in pairs, with information attuned to their age. After everyone had been told what was happening in some form, we all stood in a circle, squeezing each other’s hands as hard as we could. Mom prayed, and everyone else was silent. Except for me. I couldn’t stop crying.

Three Months

I returned to school after spring break, with my parents—especially Dad—insisting that despite what was happening, I had to continue my education and earn my degree. The structure of the educational environment was soothing, and I found some refuge in my studies. Removed

from the household, I could tell myself a story: when I went home that weekend, Dad would be doing a little better.

But that was never the case. Week after week, he grew thinner, and then crossed the line to skeletal. By the time he died, his five-foot-ten body would weigh just seventy pounds. Mom and my siblings cared for him throughout this whole period, and I know only a few stories about the sacrifices they made and what they witnessed during those difficult days. I received a jarring reminder that Dad was dying each time I went home for the weekend. They lived with him as he died.

I tried to save Dad. Late-stage pancreatic cancer is still almost impossible to overcome, but I tracked down several medical studies researching new treatments. One looked promising, and a glimmer of hope flashed in my heart as I looked up the contact information for the lead researcher and called her. She didn't pick up, so I left a message.

She called me back a few days later while I was sitting in the Burlington airport, waiting to board a flight to Virginia, where I was to present some programming work I'd done on Norwich's library website at a conference. I stepped away from the two accompanying faculty members, desperation coursing through my numbing body. She and I spent several minutes discussing Dad's diagnosis. Once I shared what I knew, her voice grew soft.

"I'm so sorry," she said, "but your dad has a very rare type of pancreatic cancer that isn't included in our study. I'm really, really sorry and I hope you find something that can help him."

After thanking her and saying goodbye, I hung up the phone and returned to sit with the other conference attendees. One of them tried to talk to me about something related to the event. I stared off into the distance as I murmured an automatic response. My only thoughts were about

losing Dad. I saw now, unequivocally, that he was going to die—and that there was nothing I could do about it.

I managed to make it through the conference and the remaining six weeks of the school year, going home every weekend to see Dad and spend time with the family. When summer break began, I returned to work at the hardware store, so my observation of Dad's last days was still conducted from a distance. I helped out when possible, and had the responsibility of taking him to some chemotherapy sessions at a hospital forty-five minutes away.

The morning of one such session, I made him a plain bagel with butter before we left, hoping that he would be able to keep it down. This was unlikely, given the cancer was now causing his body to reject all food. We drove out in his car. As a child, I had practiced navigating up our long driveway while sitting on his lap in the driver's seat. Now, I was driving him in it to have poison injected into his body, in the hope that it might destroy the cancer before killing him.

Halfway there, Dad asked me to pull into a gas station's parking lot. He was feeling nauseous, although he had held down the bagel longer than usual. But as we pulled in, he reached for the white plastic wastepaper basket he now kept in his car for getting sick in and vomited out the bagel. I saw from the contents of the basket when I dumped it out that it contained only small bites of the bagel and some yellow bile. His stomach had nothing in it.

When we reached the hospital, I assisted him to the room where his chemotherapy was to be administered. I sat in a chair next to him as the nurse hooked up his IVs, and then we turned our attention to the small television mounted in the corner of the room, which was playing *The Truman Show* starring Jim Carrey. We watched in silence until almost the end, when Truman starts smashing through the fake wall after discovering his whole reality had been a lie.

Dad slowly lifted a thin arm, dangling with empty skin where mere months ago strong muscles had been, and pointed at the screen.

“That’s what I feel like,” he said, tears etching their way around the sharp cheekbones on his malnourished face. “Like none of this is real, and if I try really hard, if I just keep trying, I can break out of this.”

But multiple rounds of chemotherapy, the green diet Mom switched him to, and the prayers of three towns couldn’t make that happen. Three months to the day from when he had been diagnosed, I received the call at work I had been expecting and dreading for weeks.

I needed to come home. It was time.

* * *

I sped home. When I arrived, I ran into the living room, which now contained Dad’s hospital bed, where he had lain for a month after growing too weak to walk. Mom and Dad’s older sister, who had come to help out, were hovering around him, trying to do what little they could. Something had happened, and they were uncertain how to handle the situation.

Dad could no longer speak.

His eyes were still open, and when I entered, he looked directly at me and held my gaze. His face was now just a skull wrapped in skin, and almost unrecognizable. But his eyes were the same and still shone with awareness. For the first time in my life, as we looked at each other for what would be the last time, I saw fear in my father’s eyes. Fear triggered by the understanding that this was it. He knew his time had come to an end.

I was ushered out of the room but returned a few moments later, once things had quieted down. Dad was resting now, his eyes shut, never to reopen. I pulled a chair next to his bed and sat, staring at him, unable to comprehend that this wasted-away body was my father. I took his hand, which lay limp on the mattress, and rubbed it gently for a moment. His bones, much thinner than I'd expected, shifted beneath my thumb. The chemotherapy had made his skin soft and hairless. These weren't Dad's hands.

Then I began to speak. I talked to him for a few moments, not knowing if he could hear me. Sadness arose from within, and then I was overcome by it.

"I can't do this without you," I cried, bowing to rest my forehead on the mattress next to his hand. Tears dripped from my eyes onto the light blue sheet beneath my face, pattering against the fabric before soaking in. I wanted to never have to lift my head again.

Then, I felt Dad squeeze my hand, twice. Not twitches, but two deliberate and consistent movements. I jerked up. I knew exactly what it was.

"Was that a 'no'?" I asked, my tears making it difficult to speak. It would be no surprise if even in this coma-like state, Dad had found a way to communicate with me. His new physical limitations stood no chance in the face of his desire to remain a part of our lives for as long as he could.

He squeezed my hand once.

"One for 'yes', and two for 'no,' right?" I confirmed, and after a few seconds he squeezed my hand one time.

Using this binary language, he and I had what would be our last conversation on this plane of existence. We spoke for some time as I recalled happy memories and sought comfort by asking what he thought his future might hold. He firmly believed that heaven awaited him and

that we would see each other again one day, so I described some of his beliefs and then asked him if he still believed in them. He said that he did. Although I did not—could not—I found solace in his expression of hope for more time together.

As our conversation drew to a close, I promised him that I would take care of our family, and he squeezed my hand. Yes. Then I started to cry again and told him that my dreams would be impossible to achieve without him here to support me. He quickly squeezed my hand twice. No. Absolutely not.

After I stopped crying, I drew a long breath, and then made him my final promise:

“I will not let this stop me. Losing you will hurt so much, and I will miss you with all my heart, but I will keep going. I will not stop. I promise.”

He squeezed my hand as tight as he could and kept squeezing for many seconds. Yes. Yes, Saul.

We sat quietly for a moment. Then I told him how much I loved him, stood, gave him a long kiss on his forehead, and left the room. I don’t remember if I returned later that day, and this is my last memory of the wonderful, special times I shared with Dad.

* * *

The next morning, I woke up early to take my girlfriend to her high school, where she was a senior. She had spent the night with me, and thanks to her presence, I’d been able to sleep. We barely spoke as we got ready to go. I stopped to see Dad on the way out, finding Mom already awake and sitting with him. He did not stir as I kissed his forehead. Mom gave me a sad but strong smile as I turned to leave.

My girlfriend and I got into the car and started the thirty-minute drive. A rare silence hung between us. Words had lost all meaning. We drove for five minutes until we reached the edge of town.

Then I felt Dad die. A bright light in my chest I hadn't even known was present until it was gone was extinguished in an instant, and the darkness it left behind collapsed in on itself. A wretched pain engulfed me, where before there had existed the feeling of safety and love that Dad had instilled. I gasped for the breath that had been torn from me, and only small sips of air passed over my lips. My whole body started shaking.

I braked hard and spun the car around in the tiny parking lot of the general store, then sped towards home.

"I need to go back," I managed to say. "Dad just died."

The fierce drive back to the house passed in an instant. I tore up the rocky driveway, slammed the car to a standstill, and flew out of it, leaving the door open in my haste.

Mom had seen me coming up the driveway and met me at the door leading into the house.

"He's gone," she said, the sad smile still on her face, now overlaid with the expression of a mother who is ready to comfort her child, whom she knows is in a state of great pain. "He smiled six times, and then he went to be with Jesus."

She gave me a long, tight hug, and then I went inside and waited by his bed. I did not cry, because I felt nothing inside. No emotion seeped into my heart. I felt only the emptiness that had been instilled in me the moment he died.

My siblings trickled in, and we huddled together, holding one another. They did not cry either. Many of them had refused to believe he was going to die until this moment proved them

wrong. Now they, too, were feeling the hollowing loss of his love, in a state of shock, unsure what to do next.

Far too soon, the undertakers arrived and placed Dad on a gurney, then rolled him out of the house and through the backyard, past the standing pool that just a year before he had been able to leap into. They loaded him into the back of a shiny, black hearse and shut its curtained doors.

My siblings and I trailed behind them in a daze, then stood at the top of the driveway, gripping each other's hands as we watched the beetle-like vehicle bearing the body of our dead father rumble away, pull out into the road, and then disappear over the hill. We said nothing. There was nothing to be said. At just fifty-five years old, Dad was gone forever.

III

Bipolar

The mind is its own place, and in itself can make a heaven of hell, or a hell of heaven.

— John Milton, *Paradise Lost*

Onset

The loss of Dad left my mind fractured and pushed me over the border from the hypomania I had experienced as a teenager into clinical bipolar disorder, although I didn't know it then. As already introduced, some people are born with a predisposition to developing bipolar disorder, which, if it happens, occurs in their late teens or early twenties. Most people progress safely through this dangerous phase and into adulthood, but a traumatic event during this period—such as losing a loved one suddenly—can trigger the onset of bipolar disorder. That is what happened to me.

Bipolar is a sinister mental illness that does its worst damage when you least expect it. It rips apart your life and livelihood, yet you feel supreme in the moments of greatest harm, believing your actions to be ordained. What you think are your best moments turn out to be the times when you do the most damage, and no aspect of your life is safe—especially your relationships with others.

This self-sabotage results from a bipolar symptom called mania. Mania is a more extreme version of hypomania that detaches you from reality and places you in a new one in which you are God. Everything you say, do, and think becomes divine and a gift to Humanity. There are no limits, and you can do no wrong. You are the smartest, rarest, most incredible person in the Universe: past, present, and eternal future.

It is during the periods of mania that you wreak havoc in your life and the lives of others. You do things you wouldn't have otherwise, such as breaking up with a significant other, buying something you cannot afford, or deciding to cause issues at work. All the while, your actions feel so much like the right thing to do that you never stop to verify if that is the case. Only after the

mania ends—which takes weeks, or even months—do you start to comprehend the consequences of your actions.

As manic episodes accrue, you begin to assign parts of your identity to the mania. It grows from an occurrence to a core, sought-after component of your life, and then it rises to consume your entire sense of being. You become defined by your mania and start to believe that it is the best part of you. It is what makes you special. Without it, you would be nothing. You were nothing until this gift was bestowed upon you.

This consumption of identity is what makes bipolar almost impossible to self-diagnose. Nothing feels wrong to you, and, regardless of the consequences, there are still many periods of your life during which you feel fantastic. You believe that you are operating on a level far above other people and see nothing wrong with that. People who cannot tolerate you are but weak individuals, incapable of recognizing greatness when it stands before them.

With this mindset, it does not take long for those around you to start asking themselves if the good in you outweighs the emotional pain you continually inflict on them without warning. Those who leave your life do so shaking their heads, wondering how someone they thought they knew could suddenly change so much, do them indiscriminate harm, and even seem to enjoy their malicious behavior.

The people who stay in your life find themselves never quite sure which version of you to expect each time they encounter you. Will you display traces of human emotion reminiscent of the person they knew and still love? Or will you be the cold, self-inflated, chaotic personality they have come to dread? Only those who care about you the most are able to bear this uncertainty and keep you in their lives. All the while, the changing moods that mystify them feel perfectly normal to you.

Bipolar extends beyond these changes in mood, however. Psychotic symptoms are present in a fraction of cases, during which perceived reality is altered in the form of visual or auditory hallucinations. They are often unpleasant sensations, such as menacing figures lurking in a doorway or screams in the walls. Eventually, this constant feed of mild insanity leads you to question everything you see and hear, never trusting that what your senses present you with is real. I experienced primarily auditory hallucinations, which began when I returned to Norwich in August 2012, two months after Dad died.

* * *

I was twenty when I resumed my studies in the fall of 2012, now double-majoring in cybersecurity and computer science. I had a massive courseload, and buried under this mountain of work, I found a little shelter from my crippling emotional pain. A mind immersed in a calculus problem or in the flow of writing code was harder to draw back into the turbulent river of infuriating sadness and collapsing mental health that had become my life.

Despite my brokenness, I managed to maintain two friend groups during this time, and this closeness helped stave off a confusing bout of homesickness. When I missed home, I had to remind myself that the home I longed for no longer existed. I was adrift, without port or destination. I'm appreciative to the friends who stood by me then—I know a few of them truly cared about me, in spite of the strain I placed on our relationships.

Some friends might have been hanging around because I was one of the few students with a nice car on campus: a brand-new Ford Focus I'd leased just a few days before Dad died. It had not been a planned commitment. I did not need a new car, could barely afford the payments,

and would eventually wreck my credit with it. But the decision to get the car just seemed so right as I strode into the dealership, so I went for it. This was the first instance of my bipolar disorder presenting the classic symptom of compulsive, egregious spending.

As the days grew shorter and the biting cold set in, any shrouds of comfort found in my studies began to dissipate. I succumbed to the worst seasonal depression I had ever experienced and sought pseudo-psychiatric treatment from the infirmary. They prescribed me an antianxiety medication, but it started triggering electric shocks throughout my entire body. The shocks continued to escalate in intensity until I sometimes tripped and dropped whatever I was holding when they struck. I discontinued the medication and tried two others, which each caused their own side effects, leading me to abandon them, along with my general openness to medications.

One day not long after the permanent snowfall had set in, amidst this swirl of heartache, depression, and ineffective medications, I found myself headed towards the long flight of fifty or so steps that led to the back of the dorm I lived in. Ice covered the concrete steps and had formed bumps atop the black paint coating the rail, so the stairs presented an ideal opportunity to engage in the risk-seeking behavior I craved.

I was not suicidal then, but I also wouldn't have cared if I died. I sometimes opened the window of my fifth-story dorm room and leaned out on it as far as I could, daring myself to slip and fall to a freeing death. Once, I lost my balance but did not fall, giving me a dose of the fear of death I needed to discontinue that specific activity. However, plenty of other ways to risk my life lay all around me, including descending this treacherous flight of stairs by icy rail.

At the top of the stairs, I sat on the rail and looked down. Save for a few small platforms the size of large steps, it was a direct shot down the steep hill to the bottom. The cold of the rail

seeped through the seat of my jeans and sent a chill through me as I inched out onto the first sloping rail.

The instant before I lifted my hands to begin my descent, I heard Dad's voice in my right ear—only a loud whisper, but clear:

“Saul, stop.”

I seized the rail and spun to my right, forgetting for an instant that it was impossible for Dad to actually be standing there, because he was gone. But the voice had seemed so real. I'd felt the percussion of his breath in my ear and the sway of the small hairs on my skin, as if he were right next to me. There was no perceptible difference. Dad had returned to take care of me.

My grip released, and I slid down to the first platform, then moved to the next inclined rail and prepared to descend a second flight.

“Saul, please, stop.” The need to impart the importance of his words now thickened Dad's voice, and in my mind I clearly saw the image of his face shadowed by concern for the safety of his child.

I slid down the rail, and then the remaining ones, until I reached the bottom. My feet landed in the snow, and I paused, waiting, listening.

Nothing. A muted silence owed to the tons of fallen snow was all that met my fast-freezing ears.

In the months that followed, I continued to seek Dad's voice by risking my life. It worked about a third of the time, which was more than enough to continue to race my car through twisty roads faster than ever, or run down these same icy stairs. It didn't matter to me that what my actions would have disappointed him or that it violated my deathbed promise. Nor did I stop and

question the sudden appearance of these hallucinations. I just wanted to keep him with me a little longer.

* * *

Towards the end of winter, the voice began to change. Dad's voice no longer accompanied my life-threatening behavior, and, as it faded, so too did my willingness to die. Although I had abused it, the presence of his voice and his plea for me to cease my stupidity had been an ample, albeit immature means of making it through that first and hardest depression of my life. I reminded myself of my promise to him—to not let his death stop me—and soldiered onward, even though each accomplishment was empty and painful because I could not share it with him.

Dad's voice was much missed, for in its place arose the wrenching scream of a woman in pain. At night as I studied, her wailing would fade into my consciousness, first as a gurgling murmur, then growing louder and clearer as the days passed. As I neared exhaustion each night, her scream penetrated deeper inside my head, carving out a place as an element of my reality. The physical sensations of the voice in my ear—still my right ear—gradually reduced as the volume increased. As with hearing Dad's voice, this occurrence went unquestioned, until it was just a thing my mind did.

During this time, I also began experimenting with alternative sleep schedules, which no doubt exacerbated these psychotic symptoms. I managed to pull off one of the more extreme ones for a month before triggering a four-day period of insomnia that almost wrecked my entire

semester. I had already been doing a fine job of that myself, thanks to having mentally checked out of several classes.

Concurrent to, or perhaps as a result of, these mental health challenges, my vision for my future began to shift away from a cybersecurity career leading to employment with one of the so-called three-letter agencies, such as the FBI, CIA, or NSA. Early in the fall 2012 semester, I had taken a CIA aptitude test and, at the beginning of the spring 2013 semester, was flown to Washington, D.C., to attend an informational session about interning with the agency.

I arrived at the session late due to flight delays. When I entered, I found myself in a rectangular, linoleum-floored room surrounded by people at least a decade older than me, and some even more than that. I still did not look my age, and when I entered the room everyone turned in their seats to survey what they must have thought was an at-most sixteen-year-old sauntering in on their own schedule.

The speaker at the far end of the room paused while I took a seat. Heads turned forward again, some slower than others, and the session resumed.

During the next break, I introduced myself to the lead agent presiding from the front of the room.

“Ah,” he said, “you made it.” But his tone was pleased, not accusatory. His gaze was sharp and direct, but a faint smile hovered at the corners of his mouth.

The session resumed shortly thereafter. It began with a description of some of the things that would disqualify prospects from an internship. Among them was having smoked marijuana or been around anyone while they did. I checked the latter box, but I said nothing, because there was no way for them to verify anything like that.

However, what they said next made me decide to reveal my deviant behavior.

“Anything you write for the public,” the agent said, “will need to be run through our communications department, to ensure you are not disclosing sensitive information. That is the case even if you only complete this internship and never actually work for the CIA.”

He had barely finished speaking before my hand shot up, requesting a discussion regarding one of the disqualifying activities. Ever since writing my fantasy novels, I had harbored the dream of pursuing my passion for writing, and had no interest in giving a government agency control over any future publications. Fuck that.

An agent stepped outside with me, and I revealed that I had recently been in the proximity of a marijuana user. He seemed crestfallen, but I almost ran for the elevator. By the time I left the building, I had abandoned any goal involving working for a government agency. Sitting here today, free to write anything and everything, I know I made the right choice.

Rerouting

For the next two months, I lacked a clear direction in life; but, for the first time since losing Dad, I noticed tentative glimmers of happiness breaking through my sorrow. The lengthening days and my having immersed myself in my friendships during this time helped. My bipolar disorder had yet to result in significant damage to my platonic relationships, although I had started to exhibit a thread of callousness in my demeanor. This resulted in some strain, but not catastrophe.

For spring break, I went to Florida to visit my half-sister, who was twelve years older than me. By now, my interest in cybersecurity had vanished because I knew that path led to working for a government agency or a company contracting for the government, which was no longer the life I wanted to create for myself. Even beyond the restrictions on publications, the

strict, structured life I'd sought out at Norwich had lost its allure. I also knew that healing would be difficult alongside such rigor, and that one day, I needed to start healing. So, I let go of my dreams and began a search for new ones.

The natural and immediate career pivot was toward my computer science degree and lifelong strengths as a programmer. My interest in software development began to resurface, and spring break afforded me the first time in a while to think about the next steps I wanted to take. The seed of an idea that had been growing in my mind since walking out on the CIA began to take root: I needed to move to California. New dreams were taking shape, lit by the rays of a westerly sun and made real by the opportunities I was sure to find there, far from the places where I had experienced so many traumas.

But most of all, I needed to prove to myself that in spite of Dad's death, I could still move forward with my life. Restarting life thousands of miles away from home seemed like a good way of doing that. So I got to work. Silicon Valley was the obvious place to start looking for a summer internship, and I created a profile on a website used by startups and programmers to connect with one another. Sitting on the shaggy carpet in my sister's living room in Florida, I started searching through the available internships.

What I found astounded me. Hundreds of companies were searching for talent, and they offered salaries and benefits far greater than I had ever dreamed of for an internship. Most far exceeded the peak salary Dad had ever achieved—and for internships! I couldn't believe it. It was 2013, and the Silicon Valley tech scene was in an upswing, with unprecedented amounts of money flowing into software companies as venture capitalists searched for their next big win.

I started applying to companies *en masse*, and by the next day had matched with dozens of them. I moved on to phone interviews with ten or so, overwhelmed by the speed of events and

filled with an excitement I had not experienced before. For the first time, I was creating a future all my own.

It must be said that while I was growing up, Dad did an adequate job of making space for me to pursue my interests, including the college degree and career I chose to pursue. Nonetheless, I had made many decisions about these things with his approval in mind. Despite the freedom he gave me in certain respects, my desire to live my life in a way that was satisfactory to him had shaped my existence. My whole life, I had wanted to make him proud.

After Dad died, I decided to work to make myself proud. That left me free to choose my own path in life, absent Dad's unintentional influence. And already, a new chapter in my life was unfolding as I began taking the interview calls. I spoke with one company but didn't like their product, so I declined. I moved on, feeling confident that I would find a match, given how many interviews were left. But I would need to take only one more call.

My next conversation was with someone who would soon be my boss but quickly become my best friend. Within the first twenty minutes, we both knew that we had a special connection. He was only a couple years older than me, had been homeschooled and developed an interest in computers and coding early on, and was a passionate entrepreneur. We talked for five hours, sharing our stories and bonding more than should have been possible in an introductory call among two individuals separated by thousands of miles.

After the call ended, I sat in silence for a moment, almost unable to comprehend the meaningful, personal exchange I'd just had. On top of everything, one special thing about him stood out: his name was Scott.

I recovered from an intense feeling of serendipity, opened my computer, and canceled all my other calls. I had already missed some of them due to my long conversation. My new friend

needed to check in with his startup's co-founder before sending me an offer letter, but that didn't stop me. I wanted to work with him and no one else.

The next afternoon, the offer letter came through via email. I cried as I read it, because it—like my wonderful conversation the day before—seemed too good to be true. My starting salary was sixty thousand dollars, an almost inconceivable amount after growing up in a family often earning just over half of that. I read the offer over and over to make sure I wasn't missing something, still convinced during the first few passes that I was adding an extra zero to the number. But the offer was real, so I signed the letter and sent it back. It was the happiest I'd been since Dad died.

* * *

When I got back from spring break, my passion for the startup life of Silicon Valley exploded. I came up with my own idea for a startup and began working on it in earnest, recruiting people from my friend groups to assist. It was my first time building a real team, and running it came naturally. I found the work similar to guiding the energy of my younger siblings, in that each step towards achieving my vision was accomplished by two simple things: identifying who can do what best, and keeping everyone excited about what they are working on.

Unfortunately, what we were working on was a pretty bad idea. It was an app for rating musicians, video games, restaurants, and the like, using colors instead of stars. I called the company Vybe Project, realizing too late that it sounded more like a company making sex toys than a poorly reimagined version of Yelp. Regardless, I learned a tremendous amount about

setting up a business entity, building and running a team, and product management—all skills that would be put to use again soon.

Back in Vermont, the few months between spring break and the end of the semester flew by. I was already unsure if I would be returning to Norwich in the fall. Now that I had found out that college degrees didn't matter to the tech startups handing out six-figure starting salaries to junior programmers, the prospect of returning for another two years to rack up tens of thousands in additional high-interest student debt for a couple pieces of paper from a predatory institution was growing less appealing by the day.

When the time came to leave for San Francisco, I packed my Focus and set off, navigating the interstate system Southwest, stopping every five hundred miles or so to explore places like Hershey, Pennsylvania, or Saint Louis, Missouri. Eventually, I made it to the northern edge of Texas, then through that state to New Mexico, and on to Nevada before reaching the southeastern California border late on the fifth night.

The motel I stayed at just over the state line featured a red and white sign that anyone from California knows well, proclaiming the presence of chemicals known to the state to cause cancer, birth defects, and other harm. I had never seen such a disconcerting announcement and asked the motel owner behind the counter what it meant, thinking that perhaps the building was condemned.

She laughed as she explained that because they used bleach and other cleaning chemicals, the State of California required this notice. That was my first introduction to the overbearing rules rampant in California's legislation, but such opinions were far from my mind then. I was just glad to have found a place to spend the night that would not leave me stricken with illness.

The next day, I started the last leg of my drive west. I planned to reach the Pacific and then continue north on Route 1, which follows the coast all the way up to San Francisco. As I passed through the rolling hills covered in blonde summer grasses that swayed in a never-ending current of wind, all I could think about was the ocean.

A few hours later, I saw it. The glint of sunlight on the water flashed through the curves of the hills in front of me, and when I reached a crest from which I could see even a sliver of the blue water, I pulled over and jumped out of the car.

As I stood and watched the water, it felt surreal that I had just driven across the entire United States. It was followed by a mixture of joy and excitement for the high-paying tech internship that awaited me. An instant later, a wave of grief swooped in when I remembered that I could not call Dad and tell him about this special moment. He had always loved the ocean.

But here, thousands of miles away from where all the painful moments of my life had taken place, it was easier to let those feelings pass. When I returned to my car, thoughts of my brightening future reemerged. I smiled. It was too incredible a day to stay sad for very long.

San Francisco

In San Francisco during the summer of 2013, the farm boy was usurped by the classic Silicon Valley programmer, adorned in dark washed jeans and charcoal startup t-shirts. Right from the start, I knew I was where I needed to be. My entrepreneurial spirit was boosted by the thousands of other like-minded individuals there—everyone seemed to either have their own startup or to be working on a side project they hoped might eventually turn into one. People lived and breathed the tech hustle, and it was intoxicating to be around.

Like my wardrobe, my mind, too, shifted once I reached the West Coast. It is difficult to look back this far and identify periods of mania, because, as mentioned earlier, manic periods feel completely normal while they are taking place. Unless it's known what symptoms to watch for—rapid speech, a reduced need for sleep, or a steady flow of epiphanies—it is impossible to recognize the mania until the damage is done.

Nonetheless, based on certain behaviors I exhibited that summer, I feel confident labeling it as my first sustained period of true mania, set off by the excitement drawn from my surroundings, warming weather, West-Coast orientation, and sudden propulsion into this fantastical new life. Regardless of the cause, I would soon witness the impacts of these periods of unchecked intensity.

My physical health was the first part of my life to deteriorate. I submerged myself in my work, both for my friend's startup and my own, which was still limping onward despite an unsatisfying app launch. After a while, my interest became academic, as it afforded me an opportunity to apply the new tech skills I was learning at my friend's startup. I cut back my amount of sleep by hours so that I could work more, and neglected exploring the area as the summer months sped by.

Next to crumble were my relationships with my roommates. I was living with a girlfriend and two guys I knew from college, one of whom I considered a close friend. I had looked forward to spending the summer having fun together in the Bay Area; however, as the mania set in, I deprioritized maintaining a good relationship with them. It wasn't that I pushed them away—I just dropped them out of my life. They no longer mattered to me.

By the middle of the summer, my friends and I were barely speaking. When our first significant conflict arose over the payment of an apartment cleaning fee, I decided that my

approach was infallible, and theirs flawed. Because I didn't care about the relationships anymore, I was completely inflexible. This created a rift between us that would eventually start to mend, but not for long.

* * *

When the end of my internship drew near, my startup friend asked me to stay at the company instead of returning to school in Vermont. They were willing to up my salary by tens of thousands of dollars and give me stock in the company if I agreed. It took a couple weeks to arrive at a decision, but eventually, I chose to return to campus and finish my formal education.

The thing that persuaded me was a memory of Dad from my childhood. During one treasured pre-murder summer, I'd struggled to stay focused on completing goals, even more so than usual. I had started and abandoned several projects over the mild summer months. One that was hard to miss was a model castle I'd begun constructing using small rocks and cement atop a large boulder whose surface jutted out next to our driveway. I'd started it early in the summer but deserted it after the walls reached a few inches high. The unfinished ramparts sat there for months, and, one evening late that summer, Dad commented on it.

"You seem to have difficulty finishing things," he said as we walked up the driveway and past the discarded effort. He gestured at it as evidence. "Be sure to keep an eye on that."

His tone was matter-of-fact, not accusatory. I'd done nothing wrong by not finishing the project; his intent was to highlight a pattern he had observed in my life and leave it up to me to decide what I wanted to do about it, if anything.

With this memory in mind, I resolved to turn down the lucrative offer and return to Norwich. However, I gave myself only one more year. That would let me graduate next spring and return to the Bay to resume this enthralling life. I mapped out the classes required to complete both the computer science and computer security degrees, and managed to find a schedule that would work—but it necessitated between twenty-eight and thirty credits each semester. Although my peak credit load had been twenty-two, to my manic mind, this unhealthy plan seemed achievable.

However, the per-credit overage fee would have added many thousands of dollars to my already burgeoning student debt, so I chose to instead drop my computer security degree. That freed up my workload significantly and reduced the overage fee I would have to pay. Best of all, most of the classes ended up being introductory ones that I had skipped to focus on others more relevant to my interests. In the end, with the help of a few supportive faculty and some College Level Examination Program exams, I managed to rework my remaining degree requirements to free up numerous electives. That enabled me to focus even more on computing courses during my last two semesters.

The 2013–14 school year passed unremarkably. I rented my first apartment near campus, and my auditory hallucinations conflated themselves with the noise of the downstairs resident. Seasonal depression struck again, but I started using a sunlight lamp, which staved off the worst of it. I focused on excelling academically my last two semesters, and did so. Then, in June 2014, after graduating *magna cum laude*, I returned to San Francisco.

* * *

In 2014, the Silicon Valley tech bubble was still expanding. When I arrived back in the Bay Area in June, I felt that I'd missed very little of the action, and the life I had started creating for myself the previous summer resumed in earnest. I rejoined the startup I had interned at and began working on software that sorted through data from billions of websites, looking for indications of what internet technologies the site's owner was using in their product. All the time, I was learning about what it took to create a Silicon Valley startup of my own.

I moved back in with my close friend from college, having rebuilt our relationship during the preceding school year. He had relocated to an artificial island called Alameda, which was created by digging a channel between Alameda and the city of Oakland for the United States Navy to use. Alameda is aptly called the "Jewel of the Bay" and sported safe, beautiful parks, bike-friendly roads, excellent schools, and a small downtown filled with boutique shops and cozy restaurants. It was the place to be if you wanted to raise a family in the area, and I very much enjoyed the relative oasis it afforded from the busy and dirty cities around it, which I found difficult to enjoy after growing up roaming the open woods of Vermont.

I worked in San Francisco's South of Market district, which was accessible by ferry from Alameda. Riding the ferry each day was a great commute. In the mornings, a food truck sold coffee and pastries just before the gangway entrance. The ferry sold wine and snacks in the evenings, and, thanks to overlapping schedules, I frequently encountered the same fellow passengers. I even met one of my now-lawyers on the trips back and forth.

One day after finishing work in the city, I lined up with twenty or so other people to wait for transport back to Alameda. The ferry dock was topped with boards that revealed their age through deep grooves etched into their wood by salt water over the decades. I stood with my

fixie bike leaned against me as I scrolled on Facebook, unaware that the dreams of my childhood had already begun to unfold.

A call notification appeared on my screen. It was a former professor who had taught several computing and engineering courses at Norwich, a man in his early thirties. We hadn't spoken since I graduated, nor had we planned to, so his call surprised me. I answered regardless.

After exchanging the usual pleasantries, my professor explained his reason for calling. It was his first year teaching introductory computer programming courses, and he was overwhelmed by the amount of work required to grade all of the students' coding assignments. Each one required completing a cumbersome process of downloading their code, setting it up in an integrated development environment—or "IDE"—on his computer, running it, verifying the output, and entering a grade online. He'd noted my entrepreneurial passions when I was his student, and had a question: Would I consider building a tool to automate the process of grading programming assignments?

As he spoke, I recalled the many evenings at Norwich that I had spent tutoring computer science students. Most of this I did through the university's official tutoring program, but some students just paid me cash to help them when they got stuck. It had been fun. And then, while standing on the dock with my phone to my ear, an observation I'd made as a tutor resurfaced.

The issue my professor was detailing was similar to one I'd seen before. Computer science students had to perform a similar process to run their code on their computers, but, being inexperienced, many were unable to overcome the complex IDE set-up on their own. Even if they did get that far, they would sometimes then break it by mistake. It wasn't their fault—the IDEs were built for professionals, not students. That was not ideal, because the students needed

to apply what they were learning to get hands-on experience with their new skills, not to mention to complete class assignments.

I noted how this complexity stood in sharp contrast with my childhood experiences, when I started learning to code with QBASIC. Launching into that forgotten computer programming environment had taken only a few clicks. But the state of computer science educational tools appeared to have degraded since then, with barriers to learning being created rather than mitigated through thoughtful product design. I treasured the memory of my first few moments of being a programmer, and it saddened me to think about the many students who must have felt incapable or even dropped their computing major when they encountered unnecessary complexities.

Combining these thoughts with the instructor's grading support needs—which I knew could be monetized—made it clear that the lack of a straightforward tool for running and evaluating programming assignments was a significant roadblock for teachers and students. Perhaps, I thought, if such a tool existed, it could solve the issues faced by both parties. By the time I hung up the phone, I had already decided that this was a problem I cared about enough to take all the way. I was twenty-two years old and felt ready to do a real tech startup of my own.

It was time to go for it.

IV

Startup

All our dreams can come true, if we have the courage to pursue them.

— Walt Disney

Early Days

During the first two years of my startup adventure, my bipolar disorder was still undiagnosed and untreated. This was a very difficult period of my life, filled with incredible stress, many moments of debilitating anger—no, rage—tattered relationships, and complete physical and mental self-neglect. I seized an opportunity to channel my emotional pain into my work—with no thought for the well-being of myself and those around me, even starting to believe that I could commit myself with such ferocity because of my pain. Perhaps there is some truth to that. Pain is not a prerequisite to passion, but passion can be fueled by pain.

It was with passion that I undertook this new venture. The weekend after getting the call from my former professor, I officially shut down Vybe Project and began work on my new company, which I named GradeTrain. I created the initial product by myself, coding every evening into the early morning hours and nonstop on weekends. Within six weeks I had a usable tool, just in time for testing in my former professor's class during the fall 2014 semester.

The initial test deployment went well, so as the spring 2015 semester approached, I reached out to computer science professors at other universities to see if they would like to try the tool. They did, and by the end of the school year, about a half dozen teachers and over a hundred students had used GradeTrain. That was already more use than the Vybe Project app had ever received, and with good reason: this new product solved an actual problem.

San Francisco was full of pitch events that provided opportunities to present my startup in front of crowds to collect feedback on the idea. I entered a small competition and beat a few other teams there vying for the prize of mere recognition. Then, I participated in a pitch event hosted by Amazon's cloud computing division and won ten thousand dollars of platform credits, which I put to good use over the next year.

Bolstered by these small early successes and driven forward by a wave of excitement, I started planning to quit my job at my friend's startup. I saved up fifteen thousand dollars—then about six months' worth of living expenses in the Bay Area—and set out on my own. It was the spring of 2015. I was almost twenty-three and wanted to devote my complete energy to getting my startup off the ground.

After quitting my job, I began work on the next iteration of the product. The initial version required students to upload a file of the code they needed graded. This saved instructors the time spent on grading but did not address the problem I was most interested in: making it easy for students to write, run, and test their code completely online. In effect, a cloud-hosted IDE as accessible as QBASIC had been for me.

This second version replaced the code file uploads with a student-oriented coding interface. Learners opened the tool and started to code directly from their web browser, without having to download or set up any software whatsoever. Everything was hosted in the cloud, which had the added bonus of making their work accessible from anywhere.

Most importantly, this tool was curated to include only the few features essential to the student's success, and did away with the mess of menus and buttons present in traditional IDEs. It was the first IDE to take this education-centric approach, and one of only two or three cloud-based IDEs in existence. But the others, built for professional developers, were, therefore, unnecessarily complex for students.

Equipped with this new product, I started my search for a startup accelerator. These are companies that provide startups with networking opportunities, chances to increase their public profile, connections to investors, and advice from mentors. They also provide a small amount of funding in exchange for a significant portion of your company's stock (5 to 7 percent is

standard.) I felt confident in what I had built and knew there was a market for it, so I believed that it was the time to take this leap.

I was wrong. Joining an accelerator as early as I did was a mistake. I should have waited until I validated my business model further and expanded the user base. Startup accelerators, at their best, are like wood being piled on a company's existing flame of growth to fuel an already-burning fire. But my startup was just a spark still in need of additional care to help it catch on, so the value of the accelerator was diminished.

Unbeknownst to me, the startup accelerator I joined really did not care if my startup was ready for them. Their core objective was to take ownership in as many companies as possible, in the hopes that a few of them would turn out to be big successes. That is not a fault, merely the way such business was done. It would have been nice if one of the mentors had pointed out the company's lack of preparedness, but it was ultimately my mistake.

The thought pattern underlying this error was one that would trail me throughout the company's existence. For those considering founding their own startup, take note: product features are not growth. Nor are they a marker of your company's success. Features are merely ways to facilitate growth. At that point, I had been coding on and off for fifteen years, and because of that, I focused too much on the product itself and not enough on growing my customer base. I fell into a trap of believing that if I added more features, people would take notice and growth would naturally follow. That is not how it works. Features are features, and growth is growth.

This overfocus on my startup's product resulted in a mad dash through several versions of it in the first eighteen months of the company's existence. My advisor at the startup accelerator I joined was accustomed to working with startups that sold to other companies rather

than to teachers or students, so he encouraged me to explore ways I could do that as well. He saw potential for the product to become a platform that other companies could use to integrate hands-on learning experiences with their own educational products. This business model could result in contracts extending across many schools at a time, which would grow the user base and revenue in leaps and bounds.

This approach appealed to me more than working with individual students and teachers, because it meant that I would have fewer actual customers to manage, allowing me to keep the team small and costs low. My goal was to bootstrap the company as much as possible and avoid raising too much money from investors, so that I could retain most of the company's ownership.

Not raising significant capital from investors may have also caused me to miss out on growth opportunities, but I think it was probably for the best. I made a lot of mistakes while building this first real company, especially in the years prior to receiving treatment for my bipolar disorder. My combination of inexperience and decisions made while caught up in the euphoria of mania dragged the enterprise in different directions, never giving it time to settle and take root. In Silicon Valley there is a saying: "startups succeed by not dying." That is what mine did. It turned out well in the end, but never really took off like it perhaps could have.

Part of the reason for this was deciding to sell to large companies. After pivoting to focus on this business model, I targeted the biggest customer type I could find: textbook publishers. They sold across thousands of colleges globally, and their huge contracts would secure our revenue stream for years to come. However, working with big companies as a small startup proved very dangerous, and more than any other decision, this trajectory shaped the DNA of my startup from that point on.

I neglected to educate myself in advance, and as a result was unaware of just how much power corporations wield behind the scenes during the negotiation of the legal contracts that govern transactions with them. Nor did I realize that there are provisions designed specifically to prey on smaller companies like mine by locking them into exclusive licenses preventing the startup from working with their direct competitors. Corporations do this to damage their competition while also making themselves a primary beneficiary of a startup's work. This tactic also limits the startup's customer base, leaving the smaller organization even more dependent on the corporation for its success.

I found out about these types of contract clauses months into closing a deal with Cengage Learning, a multibillion-dollar textbook publisher. By then, I had already spent precious time building publisher-oriented features to entice them into signing a deal, and I was banking on revenue from their contract to keep GradeTrain afloat for the foreseeable future. It was a hard lesson to learn. Deciding to move forward after being presented with these limitations helped ensure the longevity of the company, but it also limited its growth opportunities with other major textbook publishers.

My most significant bargaining chip was that GradeTrain's product was the only one of its kind and satisfied a Cengage need. Like my former professor, they had started exploring the idea of grading code online, in response to feedback from the instructors using their textbooks. Our product paired well with their new online textbooks and added value to their e-learning offering—and they knew that partnering with us would make them the first publisher to bring a computer language textbook with a code autograder to market.

This small amount of leverage was useful, because I was able to push back on some of Cengage's stupefying terms, such as their gaining access to all the code behind the product if my

startup was ever purchased. That would have made the company worth much less to a future acquirer, and I managed to get it and a few other clauses struck from the contract. Regardless, by the time the deal was done, my startup was securely tethered to the corporation.

After the deal was signed, I was lucky to find myself working with some great people at Cengage. They were a team that truly wanted to solve a problem for teachers and students, and their manager—my counterpart within the company—was a determined woman who waded head-first into the sea of bureaucracy to get things done. Best of all, she was very supportive of me and GradeTrain from that point forward. She was especially impressed with my tenacity once I told her about my “Box of Horrors”—a small Rubbermaid tote I kept under my desk filled with wrist guards, elbow pads, eye drops, eye patches, and other apparatus I accumulated while pushing my body to its absolute limits trying to get the company off the ground. One night, after witnessing my complete setup in a mirror, I slammed out a blog post titled “How to Survive 80+ Hours of Programming Every Week” that enumerated the tactics I employed, which was met with praise among hardcore gamers and justifiable condemnation by medical professionals.

* * *

One valuable productivity technique I used while building my startup not cover in the how-to post will be familiar to some pre-copycat-AI-era computer programmers who have also spent hours trying to spot one small typo in their code. These mistakes, called “bugs,” can cause product issues if not fixed; or, in programmer lingo, “debugged.” Code bugs happened to me as much as any programmer and were a major source of stress. Simple mistakes would crack open my composure, through which my inner hatred of life erupted, often resulting in my freaking out

at the innocent computer. The tangled varicose veins in my lower legs throbbed in pain—harbingers of the toll the anger was taking on my body. I can scarcely imagine how terrifying it must have been to be around me when I lost control. Finally, after this self-destructive behavior had gone on for far too long, I started attempting to think my way out of the situation.

I began by considering the facts at hand. My rampant anger issues were well known to me and others and, unfortunately, were not something I was in a position to do anything about at the moment. Improving my mental health was too monumental a task to undertake alongside building a startup. Even just finding a therapist would have been difficult. I just didn't have time to devote to that—or so I told myself—and even if I did, healing takes time. I needed a solution now. These bugs were killing me.

Then, I considered my worst moments, when I utterly lost control and gave up, feeling stupid and hating myself for failing. Because of my severe anger issues, I possessed a lot of data, but it was easy to recall standout moments of complete despair that had stripped me of all energy. Those moments of rampant anger drained my mind and body until they became numb. They were moments of defeat—yet in the end, I overcame them. How? I lacked an immediate answer, but I kept it in mind as I soldiered on.

The next time I lost myself in my anger, I paid attention to what happened next. I knew from memory that every time I finally escaped my desk and beat-up chair, only one idea remained in my mind: sleep. For the love of God, sleep. So, I did, crashing face-first onto the couch and blacking out in seconds. When I awoke, I wasn't just rested—I had won. I knew the location of the bug in the code, and its solution. But rather than rushing to my desk to implement the fix, I paused to consider what had happened in my mind.

When I examined the thought behind this new understanding, I found that while the logical path to identifying the issue was clear in retrospect, I didn't know how the solution had been reached. That is, I couldn't trace my pre-nap thoughts about the problem to the thoughts containing the precious solution that surfaced when I woke. Some sort of gap had been filled for me while I rested.

Chaining together the related thoughts before and after napping required developing a timeline. One thing was immediately obvious: other than self-loathing and the plea for sleep, the only thoughts in my mind preceding sleep had been about the bug. I was fixated on it. But what about after resting? When had the idea for the fix entered my mind?

The most recent solution had been the first thought to surface once my nap ended. Not an early thought—the first. As I examined it further, something else became apparent: the absence of worry that this attempt to solve my problem would result in failure, as my ideas so often did after hours of futile debugging. This post-nap thought simply felt right. Confident, even. But the confidence had not come from considering the thought after waking using logic. No, this confidence had shone across this thought within me. It felt like true, inherent confidence, rather than an assertion of confidence based on reason.

At this point, I recalled the futuristic dreams I'd had as a teenager, perhaps early instances of ideas being delivered to my waking mind at the very end of sleep. Back then, the item to bring to the hardware store was contained in my last dream, but these programming gifts were presenting as thoughts just after waking. Given the short distance between the end of sleep and the start of wakefulness, it seemed likely that these two types of thoughts were related. Perhaps, I thought, this represents some type of evolution. If so, did that imply that whatever

process was taking place could be iterated upon? I set this question aside and instead focused on what I'd learned about the mind over the last seven years.

The most relevant information is what I learned about human cognition during a remote student research project I did the same summer Dad died. It had explored how computer security tools could prevent hacking someone's brain if it were connected to a brain-to-computer implant. Some knowledge garnered during that project was relevant to this budding line of self-discovery; in particular, the differences between the conscious and subconscious minds. So, before continuing my story, I'll share a little about those—and a few thoughts of my own.

* * *

Let's begin this excursion with the conscious mind, which you are using right now to read or listen to these words. Most of a person's time awake is spent using their conscious mind to influence reality by directing their physical movement, interacting with objects, and communicating. In other words, the conscious mind is what lets someone participate in the real world.

The conscious mind can remember things, but very little, and nothing for long. It uses something called "working memory" as short-term memory storage, which clears once what is being remembered no longer applies to the current conscious thought. Fragments from a larger set of long-term memories can be placed here; however, recalling that information, knowledge, or understanding to working memory can sometimes be challenging. Very few people can do it with exceptional success, but most of us can draw from long-term memories well enough to give our conscious minds what they need to direct the live-action show.

To illustrate how the conscious mind's working memory functions, let's consider the task of solving an algebra problem. An appropriate first step is to collect information about the problem's composition by examining its functions, variables, and constants, which are then stored in working memory. Then, based on the observed information, techniques known to be relevant to the problem are recalled from long-term storage. That knowledge is also placed in working memory. Each strategy is then applied, one at a time, based on an understanding of math derived from past education and observation. After the math problem is solved, working memory clears and is replaced with the end result.

In this way, working memory acts as the conscious mind's tiny whiteboard of sorts, upon which it scribbles notes before frantically erasing them to make space for new information, knowledge, and understanding—collectively known as concepts—relevant to the current conscious thought. This scramble is impressive but hampered by the continuous need for recall, by limited working memory capacity, and by the lack of concept permanence.

Despite this cognitive limitation, the conscious mind is capable of something very special: logic. Logic is what enables structured problem solving—algebra or otherwise—by using ordered thought. Solving math problems requires that certain steps be performed in a specific order; otherwise, incorrect answers could result. Logic enables the connections from initial function examination through knowledge recall and the application of understanding to arrive at a result. This ordered form of thought is a gift we share with few other animals, and only our species has used it to great effect. Logic has enabled us to compartmentalize systems and reassemble them based on our objectives, using information we amass to create knowledge. But sometimes the point of the knowledge is missed, and understanding is lost.

We can see the impact of our conscious minds on reality all around us. Because of this, it's easy to forget that there's much more to the mind than just thinking up ways to explain and alter what we can interact with using our bodies. Much of this cognitive work is performed by the subconscious mind, which operates behind the curtain of consciousness, performing tasks requiring no active thought. This includes the medley of tiny, constant adjustments to the body required to maintain proper functioning. The subconscious mind keeps the heart beating, regulates breathing, manages the immune system, regenerates cells, digests food, adjusts body temperature, and enables balance—automatically, nonstop, all at once. Doing this consciously is beyond impossible. Imagine trying to operate a marionette that complex!

The subconscious mind is also responsible for long-term memory management. Some of the information collected while awake is stored as long-term memories. But not everything a person sees, hears, touches, tastes, or smells is retained. Most of this sensory data is discarded when no longer relevant to the current operation—such as navigating around an object—similar to how working memory operates. The information that does make it through to the subconscious mind is processed during sleep, sometimes resulting in dreams related to what the person experienced that day, and then organized within the gargantuan memory bank maintained by the subconscious mind.

During this subconscious memorization, the new information is intermingled with recently acquired knowledge and understanding garnered during wakefulness. It's conceivable that the subconscious mind generates more of these concepts as it itself inspects, learns, and contemplates. The usefulness of such subconscious knowledge and understanding is nuanced, because this inner mind is incapable of logic. Instead, it learns by observing patterns among concepts. These patterns have little value in the conscious mind, which favors empirical thought.

But they are very powerful mental constructs that enable the subconscious mind to assemble thoughts using indicators of actuality without having to continually reassess concept associations and interactions, as the conscious mind must.

This use of patterns enables the subconscious mind to perform expansive cognition. Expansive cognition is thinking big rather than thinking quickly, and it unlocks advanced problem-solving. When questions are considered by the subconscious mind within a context of all or much of the information, knowledge, and understanding it has ever stored, ideas of any magnitude can emerge. Sometimes this misfires, and the idea produced is rejected by the conscious mind's logic filter. When this check fails and the "wrong" words emerge from a person's mouth, those ideas may be met with incredulity from others, and might not even make sense to the speaker, once uttered.

It's not possible to quantify the subconscious mind's relative memory speed and capacity. However, by virtue of its capability to rapidly process new concepts—which requires memory reorganization to maintain neurological concept proximity—it seems reasonable to posit that the subconscious mind's interactions with memories far exceed those of the conscious mind. A key unknown is if the subconscious mind uses short-term memory storage as part of its operation, which would be rendered unnecessary by extraordinary memory recall speeds. There is no point in copying to a whiteboard what can be accessed directly from a primary source at least as fast. Additionally, pattern recognition itself suggests that long-term memories are instantly accessible by the subconscious mind when it thinks, due to the breadth of concepts this operation requires.

To deliberate on the base operating speed of the subconscious mind is unnecessary, because research shows, and common sense collaborates, the astronomical rate of operation in this background cognitive atmosphere. Instead, it is more productive to consider how to interact

with this dimension of elevated thought in repeatable ways. To do so requires resuming my story and examining this curiosity through the shards of sanity that comprised my addled conscious mind.

* * *

Committing conscious thought to the control of my subconscious mind shifted how I viewed this inner part of me because I now understood its potential for conscious operation. To test its use as a code-bug squasher, I started running more experiments, which meant taking breaks from difficult issues sooner to increase the volume of data. This had the advantageous side effect of reducing my stress levels; and, as solutions streamed out, I grew more confident in my ability to find the answers to problems throughout the long journey that still lay ahead.

I wish I could say that I escaped many, or even most, of my angry bug-lust scurryings using this technique. But anger takes pleasure in seeping out of a cracked soul. When I did finally break away from the senseless rage, I found that I could steadily churn out the solutions to programming issues, letting the especially hard ones process overnight and present their solutions in my final unconscious dream. Advanced product-architecture decisions were released following walks along the Bay, during which I spent the first half focused on my environment—not the problem I needed to solve. Then, when I turned back toward home, I let my active thoughts resume. Without fail, they would contain the solution, often intermingled with several incorrect ideas that had to be evaluated and discarded using logic. I later learned that this focus on surroundings is a form of mindfulness, which quiets the conscious mind and gives the subconscious mind time to think.

In the course of these frequent tests, I identified three patterns: First, solutions that were not dreamt were always the first to arrive in my conscious mind after waking, which provided evidence of a reliable means of receiving output from my subconscious mind. Second, each thoughts' quality of "rightness" persisted as the feeling that an action was meant to occur, its only variable up to that point having been when. Lastly, these solution-containing thoughts were always accompanied by positive feelings. I developed a deeper appreciation for these feelings, be they confidence, joy, or satisfaction. I began to understand that although these were feelings I was capable of, I as the person conceived by my conscious mind had not conjured them. These were feelings experienced by another part of me, yet to my conscious mind, they were still my feelings, and therefore recognizable. And they felt good.

In light of these observations, I codified a set of steps for using my mind to solve difficult programming issues. It was simple in the end: study the problem, sleep, and then observe my initial waking thoughts. It was a somewhat anticlimactic system to define. Because I had already been making extensive use of it, my understanding developed naturally rather than arriving in a single "ah-ha!" moment. More than anything, after the line of thought ended, I felt excited to one day see what other tricks my mind might have in store.

This problem-solving technique peeled back a thin layer of the stress related to my startup, which, by the fall of 2015, had been renamed to Codevolve and enrolled in a more prestigious Silicon Valley startup accelerator. This accelerator focused on supporting educational companies, and I believed it would be a much better fit for the startup, so I was excited to participate. They also provided a hundred thousand dollars in funding—again, in exchange for a chunk of the company's equity. Even though my startup had already been through one accelerator, I felt the focus on the educational market would mean lots of connections with

customers looking for a product like mine. I also hoped to learn from the industry veterans who understood our product better than the last accelerator had.

Working with this new accelerator was a good experience, and the mentors were top-notch. But it turned out that their focus was on supporting companies selling to teachers, students, and parents, not larger companies, as my startup now did. I had secured several more companies as customers, so I was committed to the current business model and product for the time being. Despite this mismatch, as the accelerator program drew to a close at the end of 2015, my startup had more money in the bank than ever before, as well as customers working on integrating our product into theirs for launch next year. Progress, at last.

* * *

By the spring of 2016, things at Codevolve had fallen into a steady rhythm. My small team of developers and I were working on new features that added support for more complex programming projects, including the abilities to save multiple code files and use more advanced coding languages. I hired a salesperson and set him to work reaching out to different customer types. He did his best, but nothing was sticking. Most of the organizations he approached were just starting to think about online coding. There was adequate interest, and prospects were excited to brainstorm different integration use cases; but without an immediate need, they weren't ready to commit. Our product was, unfortunately, ahead of its time.

Salaries quickly drained the company's funds much faster than new revenue could replace them, as the current customer base was still working on integrating our product and not generating significant revenue yet. By summer, things had begun to crumble, and I was forced to

lay off the salesperson not long after hiring him. I felt horrible, but it was necessary given the deteriorating financial situation.

At the same time, my three-year relationship with a woman I had met at Norwich began to disintegrate. She had quietly borne my erratic behavior, manic episodes, and anger issues—or “intensity,” as she referred to it—with an admirable level of composure. But now, she couldn’t take it anymore. She had to get out.

As she was quietly suffering, I was physically and mentally burning out. My desire to build a successful Silicon Valley startup began to waver. With the company headed for destruction, I fantasized about a life free of the stress I now endured on a daily basis. The first two years of building my startup had taken my all and left me tired, underweight, and miserable. I had poured all of me into the company, but it seemed that my efforts hadn’t been enough.

The combination of my yearning for respite and my girlfriend’s need for a change drove us to halfheartedly plan to move to Portugal for the summer. Codevolve needed less attention when most students were on summer break, and the lower costs of living outside the Bay Area would extend its runway. It made sense to us—or at least, to me—somehow.

The Portugal plan was, of course, the classic relationship Hail Mary, when the couple tries to introduce a significant change to their life together in the hopes that the new adventure will pull them back together. On the surface, it seemed to be working. As we packed up our car for the long drive back East to see our families before leaving the country, I felt more confident in our relationship’s stability than I had in a long time.

My hope was unfounded. The day after I dropped my girlfriend off at her parent’s home in Massachusetts, while I was visiting Grandma, she broke up with me over a video call. She cried as she explained that she cared about me but could not stand to be in the relationship

anymore. I wept, begging her to reconsider, but her mind was made up. Looking back, I don't blame her, and I appreciate her having supported me during a very difficult period of my life—a time when few others dared to get as close to me as she did.

After the breakup, I spent a few more days visiting Grandma and then drove to my childhood home in Vermont. Portugal was not going to happen. My startup was on life support, I had destroyed another romantic relationship, and I was broke. I needed time to recover from the last few years, and I knew Vermont would give me exactly that.

Take Two

This chapter includes suicidal themes. If you are experiencing any thoughts of suicide, regardless of whether you have depression or other mental health conditions, please stop reading immediately and call or text 988 to reach the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.

After revitalizing myself for six weeks in Vermont during the summer of 2016, I resolved to return to the Bay Area and try again. My startup friend welcomed me back into his company, and Codevolve, while far from exemplifying a Silicon Valley success story, had settled into its new chapter of minimal expenditures, with me as the only full-time employee. I engaged a small team of contractors to create hands-on coding labs using our product for Cengage Learning to sell, which provided a much-needed revenue stream.

I rented an apartment in the same complex I had lived in prior to heading East earlier that year and set up a rough life for myself. My desk consisted of my bed's headboard stretched across two large cardboard boxes, and for the first few months I subsisted on a diet of

overcooked hamburger patties and ketchup. This new attempt lacked many of the comforts present during my last go at building a life in the Bay, but I was happy to be back.

A few weeks passed uneventfully until one day in mid-August, which brought with it the awakening of Codevolve from its summertime slumber. The day started in typical startup fashion. I arrived at the office mid-morning, adjusted my desk to a standing height, and set to work on a coding task. I had no way of knowing just how strenuous the next few hours would be.

Not long after getting to work, my phone began to vibrate nonstop. I checked my notifications and found a stream of messages—alerts coming from the cloud servers hosting the product. A quick scan of the alerts indicated that a huge wave of students had just logged in and begun writing code. The usage was much higher than ever before. The school semester had started, and the IDE was now being used in a multitude of classrooms across the country.

Unfortunately, things were not going well. The software I'd licensed to host the servers where student code was run was failing to scale in the ways the vendor had promised it would. Their system was supposed to automatically provision new servers on an as-needed basis. But when this surge in usage started, their software could not keep up. This left all of the students connecting to just a few servers, overloading them in minutes.

My startup friend graciously allowed me to turn my attention to addressing the issue while I was still at work. When it became clear that the problem was not on my end, I frantically messaged the company. They were loath to admit the issue was theirs, but after I convinced them, they instituted a short-term fix. It would not work for long, but for the moment, it stabilized our product so that students were able to complete their work.

Despite the rough start, I went home that evening filled with excitement. Finally, the product was receiving significant use. All the work creating content and supporting customers'

integrations over the summer had led to a flood of students beyond what I had anticipated. For the first time in months, things were moving forward, and I looked forward to overcoming whatever challenges accompanied this growth.

* * *

The surge in usage lifted my spirits, and I rode the high over the next few weeks as I battled issues with the cloud server provider's software. I slept with my phone volume maxed out so that as problems arose, I could wake up and manually perform operations that should have been happening automatically. When it became clear that the vendor was incapable of fixing the problem, I built an improved version of their product in a week, sleeping only a few hours at a time until it was running smoothly. It was hectic, but seeing the IDE being used by so many people kept me going.

One Sunday in mid-September, I found myself in a lull from the barrage of notifications demanding my attention. Students coded less on Sundays, at least until the evening, when they started plowing through programming assignments due on Mondays. I slept in that morning and, after a lazy start to the day, sat down at my makeshift desk to wrap up a new feature. I believed an easy day lay ahead. Completing and releasing the new code would only take a few hours, and then, for the first time in months, I would have the evening free for something other than work—or so I thought.

Writing the remainder of the feature's code did not take long, and soon it was ready to be deployed to the live product. I typed the command necessary to do so, and then sat back to watch the green and yellow text stream down my monitor. Everything was going according to plan.

Close to the end, the text froze. That startled me, and I leaned forward to assess the issue. I saw that the release was hung on a database change. Databases store the information required for a product to work, and they are some of the most important—and delicate—parts of all software. If a product release is trying to make a change to a database that involves modifying a large amount of data, the exponential nature of databases can freeze the entire process. That appeared to be what was happening now. I swiftly confirmed it by logging into the database and monitoring the process from that end.

A few solutions came to mind immediately. By now the website had frozen, so the few students working on a Sunday afternoon were no longer able to do so. That added a twinge of stress to the situation, but the only way to address it was to push forward and solve the problem. I ran a few more commands in the terminal to gather details about what was happening and then decided on my next steps.

Before I continue, a very brief lesson on how databases work is in order. Inside each database are tables, which store a specific type of data. For example, one table might contain information about a student, and another about their coding project. These tables are associated with one another via parent-child relationships, which are indicators of the dependencies between the tables. The direction of these relationships—meaning which table is the parent and which is the child—is very important, which I was soon reminded of.

The solution I arrived at was a little hacky, but I decided it was the best and fastest route forward: just delete all the data in a particularly large table that was causing the issue. The table contained data that was no longer necessary after a student had ended their coding session and left the website. Deleting its data would cause only minor issues, and these would be addressed once the student reloaded the page.

Relieved to have found a solution so quickly, I ran the command to delete the data. To my disappointment, it was rejected because data in this table was referenced by another table, so deleting the data was prohibited as long as that was the case. A wave of anxiety swept over me when I glanced at the clock and calculated that ten minutes had already passed. Surely, students—and soon, customers—would start to notice.

My recollection was that the database table that needed to be cleared out was a child table, which would have meant that running another command to force the data to delete would only impact that table itself. But I had it backwards. A moment later, when I ran a new command that overrode the earlier error, I made the worst technical mistake of my career: I deleted the company's entire database.

I watched in horror as a stream of messages flew by, indicating my egregious mistake. The data associated with the table I cleared out was deleted, and then all of the data associated with that linked data was deleted, and so on until everything was gone. It happened in a second, before I could process the situation.

A cold sweat broke out across my entire body, and my hands flew to the sides of my head. “Fuuuuuuck,” I said, unable to breathe as the magnitude of what I had just done swept over me. “Fucking fuck, fuck, fuck...”

After a few seconds of sheer panic, I came to terms with what had happened. The database was gone. All the content that had been carefully created during the summer was gone. All the student information was gone. Every piece of data necessary to make the entire platform function had disappeared in an instant. It was impossible to reverse the command and mass deletion.

Fortunately, I had prepared for exactly this situation.

Ever since my startup was founded, I had maintained database backups. They were made every night and stored in the cloud, so there was one saved from less than twenty-four hours prior. That would be my saving grace. I accepted the fact that it was going to be hours before everything was back online and set to work. There was nothing else I could do.

First, I located the most recent database backup. While it was downloading, I looked up the steps to restore a database from a backup. By the time the download had completed, I felt confident that the database would be back online soon.

I ran the command to import the backup into the database, but it failed. I adjusted it a few different ways, but still it refused to work. The error stated that the data in the backup was corrupted. Somewhere in my automated backup process, something must have gone wrong, and I never caught it. Corrupted data is useless. That meant all my backups were useless, and there was no way to restore the database.

Everything was gone. Over two years of hard work had been destroyed in an instant by my own stupidity. This was the end. I had failed.

I began to tremble violently, overwhelmed by everything that had befallen me in the recent years. Everything came crashing down on me. The nonstop startup stress. My trail of ruined relationships. The searing pain of losing Dad. The vicious murder of Aunt Dawn. Suddenly, the calculus by which I evaluated the value of my life inverted. I was overcome by the belief that my life was no longer worth living.

I decided to kill myself.

I leapt up and staggered around the room, dizzy from waves of emotion. Only one thought was present in my mind: end this suffering once and for all. I reeled towards the veranda door. Perhaps a well-executed fall from the third story would suffice. But the door was boarded

over by construction workers performing renovations. I attempted to climb the sheet of plywood, but it was too tall. I turned away in search of another means of suicide.

On the messy floor lay a pair of jeans. Through its hoops was threaded my black leather belt. That could work. My heart was pounding, and tears were streaming down my face as I pulled it free from the pants and made a noose using the buckle. The other end I tied to a chin-up bar hanging from the door frame. I pulled the loop around my neck and, without pausing, dropped my knees out from under me.

As the edges of the belt dug into the sides of my neck, I felt at peace. Soon it would all be over. My long struggle through life, for which I had received only grief, would cease, and I would be forevermore at rest. My painful, fruitless journey was finally over. I closed my eyes and hung.

Darkness swept in from the sides of my vision, and my breathing reduced to empty gasps that drew no air. I felt the pressure of the blood trapped in my head surge, and my heartbeat booming in my ears. In that moment, I wanted so much to die. My escape seemed at hand. Finally, I could leave my broken world behind.

Then, from the darkness, emerged the face of my little sister. I saw on it the expression of shock that marks the last moment of a life before the dreadfulness of a traumatic event is fully comprehended. It was the expression of someone clinging to a single thought: this tragedy presented to me cannot be real. Only the fracture of a soul can reveal itself as what I saw on my sister's face in that moment.

I understood that this was what her face would look like when she found out that her oldest brother had committed suicide.

In that instant, I found the reason to live that I had lost hold of. I stood and frantically tried to loosen the cinch of the belt, my hands sluggish and clumsy. It came free bit by bit, finally giving way to a swift release that rescued me from my insanity. I clutched the chin-up bar to keep myself from falling as I gulped in air. Tears were pouring down my cheeks, and the image of my sister's face remained etched into my mind. I had come so close to letting her down. To letting Dad down. To hurting my family, who had already lost so much.

After a moment I returned to my desk and sat motionless for a while. I felt no shame. Rather, I felt a new assuredness in my reason for existing. When I turned back to the issue of the deleted database, the solution was evident. The backups were simply compressed to reduce their size, but due to an error in the code, their file names had not reflected that. I made one change to the command, and an hour later, the database was successfully restored. Some customers were perturbed by the downtime, but no permanent damage was done. I never told anyone just how bad the evening had been.

This day was the lowest point of my life. Never since then have I tried to kill myself—or even considered doing so. Because now, regardless of what challenges life delivers me, I have a reason to live. I carry on not just for myself and my own aims but for those I love and am duty-bound to protect. No matter what, life is worth living for them.

It is critical to note that this suicide attempt was not the result of depression. I have never been depressed enough to want to kill myself, although there have been moments when I no longer cared if I died. This suicide attempt did not stem from a desire to die; rather, it resulted from a lack of control over my actions due to a weakness in my conscious mind, a symptom of bipolar disorder that will be discussed further in a later chapter.

From a psychiatric perspective, my actions on that harrowing day were statistically normal. Among all mental health disorders, bipolar has the highest suicide rate. As many as two in three people with bipolar disorder attempt suicide, and one in five succeed. I survived my attempt, and before long, with the help of someone very special, I would start to overcome my disorder and take the first steps towards regaining control of my mind.

Treatment

The graph of my life thus far has been a V, with the first twenty-four years having been an almost nonstop decline until I hit rock-bottom in the fall of 2016 and tried to kill myself. From that point forward, my life has been an ongoing—albeit jagged—climb upwards. I attribute this to one thing: meeting the woman who would eventually become my wife. She found me at my lowest point, but rather than turning and fleeing, she saw me for who I truly was: someone in need of psychiatric help. It did not take long for her to begin encouraging me to get evaluated for bipolar disorder, having matched many of my behaviors with ones she had learned about while earning a university degree in psychology. It was the first time in a decade that someone had suggested I might be suffering from a mood disorder.

At first, I resisted the idea that I had a mental health issue. Not because there was any evidence to support my denial—on the contrary, I had plenty indicating it was indeed the case. My hallucinations, periods of depression, and self-destructive manic behavior were all glaring indicators that I needed help. The issues had been festering since I was a teenager, and as an adult had continually wreaked havoc in my life and the lives of those around me. It was time for a change. That was obvious, but I feared that once I was medicated, I would no longer be my true self, forever living as a drugged-up shadow of who I was born to be.

Each of the damaging attributes of my psyche—especially the mania—had grown with me gradually, seeping into my life until they became a part of my conceived identity. Hallucinations could be unnerving, but they were a far cry from schizophrenia, and tolerable. Growing up in Vermont, the cold, dark winters had always depressed me, and any depression I was experiencing now was not that much worse. And my mania—well, as far as I was concerned, that was what set me a league apart. This was true, just not in the triumphant ways I imagined.

As I have said, mania is particularly dangerous because it distorts your sense of self. When you are manic, the chemicals released into your brain makes your conscious mind soar to what you believe to be godlike heights. At this elevation there is only you, and that makes you feel unique—it makes you feel special. “Special” is a prized feeling in a world that often makes you feel otherwise. I cherished my mania. It was the most glorious and advantageous part of me, or so I thought. I believed I would be nothing without my mania.

Because of this, despite all the mounting evidence that I needed help, it took me some time to finally seek a professional diagnosis. I did in September 2017, nine months into my new relationship. What ultimately drove me to do so was not the positive impact treatment would have on my individual life—I was not willing to sacrifice my mania for that—but because I saw the same negative patterns that had wrecked my previous relationships begin to rear their ugly heads. I accepted that at least some of them had to stem from a mental health issue. And so, five years after having developed bipolar disorder, I made an appointment to talk about my mental health issues.

The first doctor I met with through my general practitioner’s office did not have a background in mental health treatment. But when I explained my symptoms to him—most of

them being ones my girlfriend had identified—he began treatment for bipolar disorder. He prescribed a drug called lamotrigine, which is typically used to prevent seizures but is also effective as a mood stabilizer. I went to the pharmacy directly from the doctor’s office and headed straight to the pickup counter.

After retrieving the small, white paper bag containing the medication, the pharmacist, a middle-aged woman with graying hair and a kind face, leaned across the counter and held up the bag in front of me.

“Have you ever taken this before?” she asked, her gaze direct.

I said that I had not. She paused for a moment, still staring at me, then handed over the bag.

“I hope it works,” she said, earnestly. “Because if doesn’t, there’s nothing stronger.”

Rather than fill me with uncertainty, I was encouraged. Now that I had made up my mind to seek treatment, I wanted to dive right in.

Starting lamotrigine too quickly can result in side effects, including skin melting off in patches. While this is very rare, it remains a concern for anyone, because it is not possible to predict who will experience the issue. The medication also needs to build up in your system over several weeks, so I started on a low dose that was to be increased gradually until the symptoms improved.

After starting to medicate my bipolar disorder, I wanted to learn more about how my mind worked. I also knew it was important to validate the diagnosis made by the underqualified doctor, so I managed to clear out enough room on a credit card to afford a neuropsychological evaluation. The examination took place in November 2017, and the findings were as follows: Bipolar One Disorder with Psychotic Features, Other Specified Dissociative Disorder (chronic

and recurrent syndromes of mixed dissociative symptoms), and Other Specified Anxiety Disorder (generalized anxiety with insufficient symptoms). In other words: bipolar one disorder—the type that includes psychotic symptoms—issues with accurately perceiving reality, and an anxiety disorder.

The results of the evaluation were not particularly surprising, which was a good thing. It meant that the medication I had been taking for several months was treating an actual issue. Now, all that remained was to try and gauge how effective it was. Armed with this expanded understanding of my psyche and medication to start my treatment, I stepped forth into a world not a new person, but for the first time since Dad had died, one experiencing true personal growth.

* * *

The medication for my bipolar one disorder helped, but it took time. My manic episodes decreased by about half in both intensity and frequency, but a number of things could still trigger mania. Not enough sleep, certain stimulant substances, and even jetlag were often all it took. However, I learned these limitations and began to make any lifestyle adjustments I could to mitigate the risk of becoming manic.

I also started what will be a lifelong process of evaluating my moods in detail. I learned to hold off on making important decisions, such as significant financial commitments, whenever I feel too happy or too excited. After a week or two of feeling down, I knew to monitor myself for a corresponding manic upswing, and vice versa. My methods were imperfect, but by erring on the side of caution, I became able to identify most manic episodes within a few days of their

commencement. Sometimes, though, I missed them entirely. Being manic still felt normal—and I know that will never change. Each mind is indeed its own place.

A facet of my bipolar disorder that persisted in force during the first two years of treatment was the presence of auditory hallucinations, which would almost always occur when I pushed myself too hard at work, neglecting sleep or barely eating. For a time, because I now knew the hallucinations were a symptom of a mental health disorder, they actually got worse. I would find myself lost in cycles of stress in which I took the presence of voices to indicate the failure of the medication, which would cause me concern, thereby worsening the symptom.

Most of the voices at this point took the form of people speaking in foreign accents. They were mostly unintelligible, but now I sometimes heard multiple overlapping voices, screaming at one another in arguments about I knew not what. Those could be heard directly in my inner ear. At other times, voices drifted in through the walls, like an orator addressing a crowd. This caused me anxiety at night; after growing up in a rural area, I found it difficult to fall asleep if I could hear strangers talking.

However, I discovered a trick for coping with the voices, especially the ones in the walls: I started trying to make the crowd laugh. If the hallucinations could be disrupted, then they weren't real. This almost always worked and released my stress, allowing me to sleep. Later, I learned that this reality checking is a technique mental health professionals teach their patients. I was fortunate enough to identify it on my own, and it has aided me ever since.

* * *

Although the medication for my bipolar disorder was not a silver bullet—those do not exist in mental health treatment—taking it as prescribed made me more effective in each part of my life. The success of my startup venture was no exception, which retained its momentum. By early 2018, half a year into treating my bipolar disorder, a new chapter was unfurling for the company.

Up to this point, with the exception of the small accelerator investments, I had raised no outside funds for Codevolve. It was still just me and some contractors working on the company, but I felt ready to take the next step. Customers were happy with the product, revenue was fairly stable, and I saw an opportunity to expand and start producing our own courses for learning computer programming and other related tech skills, instead of just enabling other companies to do so.

Rather than seeking out funding from venture capitalists in the Bay Area, I expanded the partnership with Cengage due to the ease and existing trust. By summer, I upsold them from a contract with variable annual revenue to one with a guaranteed one million dollars over the course of the next five years—and it ended up generating much more than that. In addition to this, they agreed to invest one million dollars in exchange for 10 percent of the company.

I was ecstatic and immediately set to work growing the team. By the end of the summer, I had secured an office in Oakland and hired several of the contractors as full-time employees. I was fortunate to know every one of them personally, which I have always found to be an asset rather than a risk in an employer-employee relationship, if managed properly. It was essentially a bunch of friends working together, writing code, and having fun. After over four years of being my startup's only full-time employee, I was enjoying myself more than ever.

Following the fundraiser, I renamed the company—yet again—to Next Tech. The ambiguity of the name was due to a desire to produce a number of “Next” branded products, each of them built to assist with different parts of a developer’s educational journey. By then, our product could be configured to work for simple subjects in high schools all the way up to the advanced topics developers needed to learn to keep their skills up-to-date. I envisioned building a number of other cloud-based tools that moved beyond the educational use case for our technology, hence the rebrand.

I am proud of the core piece of technology that the Next Tech team built. In essence, the value our platform provided was the ability to run program code inside a secure computing environment in the cloud. Doing this safely and preventing malicious activity, such as viruses and cryptocurrency mining, at the scale of many thousands of students at a time was challenging, but we nailed it. Our safe cloud environments took just a few seconds to launch and provided features that could be customized to create different types of setups. This made it a great fit for teaching computer programming and related topics, such as database administration, full-stack web development, and data science.

Empowered by the growing diversity of subject areas supported by our product, I planned to use it to build interactive courses for public consumption. I partnered with a content company that created e-books for different tech skills, many of which were a great fit for our platform. From those e-books, just two Next Tech employees built three hundred hours of comprehensive, interactive content in one year. For comparison, a different company that had raised fifty million dollars built just one hundred hours of very basic courses over a decade. Our flexible platform unlocked the production of such content at a massive scale.

That year flew by, and the end of our Oakland office lease approached. During that same period, degrading conditions in the Bay Area crossed a line. The cost of living had soared, homelessness and crime had both gotten worse, and even the weather seemed to be miserable more often. I had spent five years there, and craved a change. But relocating would impact the lives of the other team members working at the office, many of whom had moved to the area only a year before.

I presented the idea of relocation to the team and was met with general enthusiasm. We collaborated on a list of cities we found interesting and shortlisted the ones in California, because moving a company over state lines is a huge legal headache. At the top of the list was San Diego, so myself and another team member flew down to investigate the state's southernmost city.

It was apparent to both of us within the first few hours that San Diego had significant potential for our new small headquarters. We happened to be there the week before Comic-Con, so the entire city was as spruced-up as it ever gets, which no doubt contributed to the appeal. In addition to the cleanliness, the rent was much cheaper than in the Bay Area, the weather nicer, and the general SoCal vibe appealed to us. We returned with a resounding endorsement for our teammates.

We let our Oakland office lease expire and moved down to San Diego in September 2019, then secured a downtown WeWork office a few blocks from the various apartment buildings we chose to live in. Back then, even a pseudo-luxury apartment in a new building downtown was cheaper than the Bay Area prices we had been paying. The ensuing Taco Tuesdays, scooter rides, and board game nights during our first few months were a much-needed reset—fortunate to be had before sickness befell the world.

Acquisition

During the last two weeks of December 2019 and into the first week of the new year, I took a trip with the woman I would later marry and her family to Singapore, Malaysia, and Sydney, Australia, where the combination of 120°F/50°C heat and a slipped disc in my back rendered me bedridden for a few days. Despite the physical setback, the trip was a pleasant one. This was fortunate, because it would be our last international trip for over two years.

While in Sydney, I began having conversations with representatives of a company whose name would soon fill me with uncontrollable surges of anxiety and excitement: Pluralsight. The multibillion-dollar company was based in Salt Lake City, Utah, and had built a large library of video-based courses for learning various tech skills. They knew Next Tech's hands-on coding platform would bring immense value to their offerings and did little to hide their enthusiasm about adding our capabilities to their product.

At the beginning, Pluralsight was interested in licensing Next Tech's software, similar to our partnership with Cengage Learning and other customers. My points of contact at the company on their corporate development team began to pull in other stakeholders to convince them of the value of our product. Everyone was enthused about the potential partnership, but due to Pluralsight's size—and, I would eventually discover, internal disorganization—discussions progressed slowly over the next couple of months.

Then, in April 2020, after flying to Portland, Oregon, to attend a computer science education conference, lockdowns intended to help slow the spread of COVID-19 began across the United States. The conference was canceled hours before commencement, and I returned to San Diego. Like everyone else in the country, I had no idea what was about to happen, but needed to carefully consider available next steps.

The rapid transition to online education prompted by the pandemic presented an opportunity for Next Tech, that much was obvious. But no one wanted to license any new software. Everyone was playing it safe by waiting to see what the economic impact of the virus would be. Our sales pipeline screeched to a halt, and my stress levels started climbing as our bank account balances continued to drop. Fortunately, none of our existing customers tried to use the pandemic as an excuse not to pay their bills. The company had enough funds on hand to last until early 2021, which may not seem like a long time, but a year of runway is actually considered quite substantial for a startup. A lot can happen in a year—and a lot did.

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Following the move to San Diego, even prior to the pandemic, I had begun considering exit strategies for Next Tech. After over five years of work, I was proud of what we had created, but I also knew that our current slow-moving, partnership-based business model would not lead to hypergrowth. We were exploring other revenue streams—such as providing coding courses directly to individuals—but in truth, the company and I had survived enough pivots already, and I dreaded the idea of another one.

Above all else, I felt in my heart that it was time to move on. I had founded the company almost on a whim after my former professor expressed his needs, and I started to realize that although I was passionate about our work and the problem we were solving for students, it no longer felt like what I was meant to be doing with my life. The urge to close this chapter and begin a new one better aligned with myself grew stronger each day.

So, I decided to sell Next Tech, although I took no immediate steps to do so. Instead, I began imagining the accomplishment of tangible goals, such as the act of signing the final acquisition contracts. Another was seeing my bank account balance containing the post-acquisition funds. But many of these dreams—and undoubtedly the most important ones—were moments of celebration with my family.

In the shower almost every night, I stood for a moment or two with my eyes closed, dreaming about moments that I wanted to reach in my future. I painted as clear a mental picture as possible, taking into account the imagined surroundings, who was present, and any actions being taken. I did it again and again until I could see them in my mind, even with my eyes open. The more I dreamed, the more each scene gained movement and life.

However, I was also doing something that would prove far more important than the mental visualization: as I dreamed, I tried to feel what it was like to be present in those future moments. The dreams of interactions with my family elicited the strongest responses and were, therefore, my preference—except for one thing: in every one, I felt Dad’s absence stronger than I had in years. The happiness was diluted by his inability to be there to see me deliver on the promise I had made to him.

I indulged in dreaming about what it would have been like to tell Dad I had done it. I needed to experience that moment, or as close to it as possible, so I began constructing it in my mind. I pictured surprising him at his office at the university one afternoon, then taking him outside to sit on a wooden bench I remembered being there. I thought about the words I would have used and recreated his idiosyncrasies as best as I could remember them. Then, as with the other dreams, I considered what it would feel like to be present in that moment. It hurt, but the strong connection I have always felt with Dad permeated through the pain and steadied my soul.

Dreaming about my desired future also helped smooth my entry into a pandemic-stricken world. It also reminded me of something easy to forget: a person has every right for their future to be better than their past. While this depends mostly on the actions of others, an individual's capacity for will should not be underestimated. With this in mind, I shored myself against the wave of global trauma and trusted in the feeling growing inside me that my dreams were nearing reality.

Then, not long after returning from Portland, Next Tech's lawyer, and a good friend, called me unexpectedly. We caught up for a moment before getting down to business.

"If you are thinking of selling Next Tech," he said, "now is the time. The online education boom is going to make the company more valuable."

He spoke my thoughts, and I agreed that it was time to get to work. Little did I know it then, but I was about to begin the most all-consuming, stressful, and life-threatening undertaking of my young adult life.

* * *

My first concrete step to sell Next Tech was to begin discussing an acquisition with two of our largest customers, Cengage being one of them. Both companies had indicated their interest in acquiring Next Tech in the past, and I started playing them against each other. I didn't want to get bought by either of them—they were not corporations I would have been happy working for—but it was a good place to begin.

I delighted in the delicate maneuvering required to convey my intent to sell Next Tech in a way that pressured the companies to act without making me appear desperate. Both companies

moved forward with the conversation, but it was clear neither would value Next Tech close to what I knew it was worth. Nonetheless, I pressed forward, knowing that they would be of strategic value as the acquisition effort continued with other companies.

Then, at the end of July, after months of relative silence, the team at Pluralsight reached out again. They, too, had realized how much more important the hands-on learning experiences our software enabled were now that online education was surging. It would have been difficult for them to capitalize on this growth without hands-on learning software like ours, and building their own offering would take too long. As such, they needed our product.

Conversations with Pluralsight began by resurrecting the partnership discussions from earlier in the year. However, since then, I had signed a partnership agreement with one of their largest competitors, which was the other acquisition suitor. This agreement had a specific clause dictating how Next Tech could work with the company's competitors—Pluralsight being one of them—but nothing prohibited a complete acquisition. I had not pushed back too hard against this clause because I calculated that it would effectively force Pluralsight—already earmarked as a potential acquirer—to buy Next Tech instead of just partnering with us. It was a dangerous move because it locked out other potential revenue streams. But at this point, my entire strategy had realigned to focus on getting acquired rather than increasing revenue.

The initial discussions with Pluralsight were about how this contractual limitation could be circumvented without violating our agreement with their competitor. I was happy to explore that, knowing that the more they saw how great a fit Next Tech's platform was for their content, the more willing they would be to go all in and buy the company. We remained in constant communication via email, with them asking questions and me taking every opportunity to sell them on a vision of their content library supercharged by our platform.

After a few weeks of these exchanges and a number of video calls to discuss high-level partnership terms, we agreed on a framework for their license of Next Tech's software. They would start by testing it on a few of their courses to see how their customers responded. Then, if things went well, they'd expand the partnership, without overstepping and violating the existing contractual limitations. We wrapped up these initial discussions on a Wednesday afternoon in early August 2020, but as I walked home from the one-person office I had rented after WeWork closed for the pandemic, I was not celebrating. This was just the first step of many on the path to selling the company.

I could tell that Pluralsight was still not satisfied and wanted access to everything we had, not just what had been carved out to work around the contractual limitations with our current customer. We both knew that acquiring Next Tech was the ultimate solution. But the A-word had not been said. Neither side wanted to seem too interested, lest they lose the initial advantage in future discussions on the subject. The game had already begun, and both sides knew it.

Over the next two days, I spent every free moment dreaming about getting acquired. It was time to get Pluralsight talking about an acquisition. Time and again, in their own voices, I heard them say the A-word. It was certain that they had been discussing it amongst themselves. Now, it was time for me to hear it.

That Friday afternoon, my main point of contact at Pluralsight sent me an email asking if I had a minute to talk. I joined a video call with him, and he explained that rather than an initial partnership to trial the software, they wanted as comprehensive a license they could secure, still within the confines of the existing contract's limitations. But he was candid about his lingering dissatisfaction that they could not use the entire platform, and I noticed that, for the first time, the

frustration was not directed at me or my existing customer, as it had been previously—it was at his own company.

That was an extremely good sign, because it was a clear indication that he had been advocating an acquisition to his superiors. He wanted more, but had not yet received approval to move forward. I saw in his eyes that he was determined to buy Next Tech and was nowhere close to giving up. The call ended with him exasperated and me trying my hardest to conceal a huge grin. The moment I had been dreaming about was coming soon.

I rode the wave of excitement through the weekend but was careful not to lose sight of the dream. As much as I could, I redirected happiness about what I thought was about to happen into dreaming about it actually happening. As I did so, I felt the space closing between me and my future self—the one who had done it.

Monday morning I went to my tiny office but found it impossible to focus on anything. The morning passed without a reply, and a few handfuls of goldfish crackers were all my anxiety-laced stomach would condone for lunch. Time slowed to a crawl in the afternoon as I continued to cling to the truth I felt within myself that today was the day.

Pluralsight's Utah headquarters is in the Mountain Time Zone, an hour ahead of California. As such, when it passed three p.m. Pacific, I had to actively work to keep myself calm by taking continuous deep breaths. I knew that the likelihood of something happening during the last hour of their workday was extremely low, but as I sat there waiting, watching the clock, I felt my future self growing closer—not fading away.

Then, an email from my Pluralsight point of contact appeared in my inbox, with a request for another quick conversation. I joined the call, fighting back tears. The moment had arrived.

The call lasted only a few minutes. They wanted everything, he said. He had talked to their CEO, and they wanted to know if I was interested in discussing an acquisition. I feigned surprise and said that I was open to the conversation. The call ended with a promise of next steps to come.

After the call I gently shut my laptop and sat in silence for a moment, then began to cry. It was happening. It was really happening. My dreams were coming true.

I walked back home in a daze, my mind a flurry of thoughts that were difficult to untangle. Later that night, in an attempt to gain some clarity, I wrote the following in my journal:

I do not believe in destiny, yet I cannot shake the feeling that things in my life have come too easily. I picture what I want in detail—even acting out conversations I will have when I obtain it—and simply make one choice at a time that leads me towards realizing that desire. But for some reason unbeknownst to me, it is getting easier.

After closing my entry, I recalled using my subconscious mind to solve programming issues, from which I had learned that it is possible to treat it like a machine that could be interacted with using my conscious mind. Similar patterns seemed to be manifesting themselves here, but on different scales. Somehow, my dreams of the future were consistently coming true—and with great specificity. Dreaming about smaller, individual steps in the sale of Next Tech had returned rapid results, akin to how dreaming about the acquisition as a whole had put the larger steps in motion. This curious chain of events interested me greatly, but I set it aside for later consideration. For now, my entire focus had to remain on selling the company.

* * *

The acquisition moved swiftly at first. That Thursday, I met with several Pluralsight executives over a video call—the entire acquisition was done remotely—to share the story of Next Tech. They seemed sold on the idea of acquiring the company but knew that there were still many barriers to overcome. An acquisition is a daunting undertaking for both parties, and we were just getting started. However, I knew I had the support of these individuals, because they, too, could see the exciting possibilities our software would unlock for them.

Next, select members of Pluralsight's content and engineering teams were informed of the proposed acquisition and began to explore Next Tech's product in detail. The potential deal—codenamed Project Oz, due to our first having spoken when I was in Australia—was still a secret at both Pluralsight and Next Tech. It was far too early for me to discuss it with my team, although I would not be able to keep it a secret for too long. They already had a strong inkling that material steps were being taken towards selling the company.

While the Pluralsight teams tore into Next Tech's product, their corporate development team and I began digging deeper into certain aspects of Next Tech as an organization. Now that we were discussing the acquisition, they wanted to better understand how we operated our business, the nuances of our product, and our financials. I was as transparent as possible, but withheld our financials. This was a deliberate move to ensure that their initial valuation for the company would be focused on the value of our technology, not our revenue.

Two weeks flew by, and then I knew it was time to start discussing a price for Next Tech. I wanted an offer on the table. I recorded in my journal that my goal for the end of the week—it

was Sunday—was to get Pluralsight to give me a price. As such, it was incredibly invigorating when it happened the very next day.

Pluralsight joined the next video call ready to discuss two key elements of the offer. First was the price at which they valued the company itself, based on its technology and revenue, although they still didn't know the latter. This was the amount that would be paid out upfront upon finalizing the acquisition. Then, they needed to value one of Next Tech's greatest assets: its team.

In many startup acquisitions, employees from the acquired company join the acquirer. For those who do, additional payments are made on a regular basis over the course of several years. These so-called golden handcuffs are used to retain key employees with important knowledge and skills the acquirer needs. The amount and duration of these payments for the Next Tech team were important elements of the offer Pluralsight had prepared.

The discussion of valuation began with them telling me they were receptive to an all-cash purchase of Next Tech, meaning no stock in Pluralsight, which was then a public company. That was fine by me—I wanted cash for the company I had worked hard to build, not unpredictable shares of a different company. For the team, they said we would receive guaranteed payments over a period of three or four years, regardless of how the integration went.

They ran me through some different examples in a spreadsheet, but only one number on the screen was important: the total price of twenty-five million dollars. I listened to what they had to say, but knew that none of it mattered at that point, because the offer was going to change. It was far too low. For the last two weeks, they had been indicating they were aligned with my mid-eight figure target. Based on Next Tech's current situation—running at a loss and facing an

uncertain, albeit not bleak future—I'd suspected that obtaining that price would take some work. But I was disappointed that they had missed the mark by so much.

After they finished speaking, I flat-out told them that unless it was a very short earnout period—something they did not want, because they needed the Next Tech team to tie our software into theirs—if they sent me an official offer for twenty-five million dollars, I would reject it. However, we parted on a positive note, because initiating pricing discussions was a significant milestone for the acquisition. Both parties knew this was just a starting point.

Over the next day, I drafted an email in response to Pluralsight's low offer. It focused on the benefits our hands-on software created for learners, to remind them of the greater importance of joining forces: the value that would be created for their customer when learning a new technology skill. I wrote about the other factors I was considering, such as breaking into new markets, the growing transition to online education that we were benefiting from, and separate acquisition opportunities. I made it clear that I would stick it out rather than be lowballed.

Then, I shared the financial information I had been withholding. Now that I had their starting valuation for our technology and team, it was time to factor this into the discussion. I closed the email with a reminder that this was an incredible opportunity for both companies and sent it.

My point of contact at Pluralsight immediately agreed with most of my assertions, and two days later, he met with their board of directors to discuss the transaction. With their approval, he increased the price to thirty million dollars, with gentle yet consistent protest from me. The offer was still too low, and both sides knew it, so the game progressed.

Now that I had upped the price by highlighting the value Pluralsight's learners would derive from the acquisition, it was time to change tactics. On Monday, October 5th, I sent a long

email that focused on the positive financial impact of the buyout for Pluralsight, case studies we had with similar customers, and a reiteration of how our technology was unique among all other offerings.

I countered Pluralsight's thirty-million dollar offer with a price of fifty-five million dollars, based on the amount of monetary value the acquisition would create for them. This was quite a bit more than I expected to get in the end, but that's how negotiations work. Their response was to up the company's value to twenty-five million dollars. Including the golden handcuffs, the total stood at thirty-five million dollars. I was happy they were still amenable to increasing the price and knew we were closing in on the final number.

Another week passed. A flurry of documents were exchanged in an attempt to satiate the never-ending demands for information from Pluralsight's engineering and content teams, which were still reviewing the capabilities of Next Tech's technology. On Friday afternoon, I flew up to the Bay Area to visit my startup founder best friend. At this point, the official offer was twenty-five million dollars for the company itself and another ten million dollars for the team's earnouts. I had increased the former by ten million dollars and was satisfied with it. Now, it was time to highlight the value of Next Tech's amazing team.

In the Uber from the airport to my friend's house, I drafted an email detailing the many exceptional attributes of the people that made up Next Tech. I focused on their tenacity, individual capabilities, and excitement to join Pluralsight—they were now aware of the acquisition—and then stated that they deserved more than the current offer. I wrapped up the email as my ride ended and sent it. Since it was a Friday evening, I anticipated a reply on Monday, but one came within a couple of hours. They agreed to the increase the team's earnout amount by five million dollars, but said that this was as far as they could go on the price. That

may not have been true, but forty million dollars—a 60 percent increase of fifteen million dollars over their initial offer—had crossed into my target range. Now, it was time to close the deal.

It was wonderful to share the moment of finalizing a price with my best friend. His unwavering support of me over the years in many capacities built a foundation of safety from which I could take on the risky startup venture, and having him there elevated the joy I felt in that moment of professional triumph. We rode the wave of excitement through the whole weekend. It was a much-needed reset between the pricing negotiations and the incredibly stressful next phase of the acquisition that was about to begin.

* * *

Acquiring a company is risky. Once the deal is finalized, the purchaser absorbs any legal or financial liabilities present in the company being acquired. To mitigate this risk, the buyer performs something called due diligence and examines every microscopic detail of the acquisition target. Because a company as a purchasable entity is really just a combination of legal documents, this part of the process requires teams of lawyers.

Pluralsight, in addition to their in-house counsel, hired a large law firm to manage their side of the acquisition. Next Tech had two lawyers who had been with the company since the start. We should have been at a disadvantage every step of the way, but our lawyers were hard workers and had assisted many startups through similar acquisitions. They knew what to watch out for when a small company is bought by a much larger one, and most of their predictions about Pluralsight's lawyers' antics proved to be accurate.

Pluralsight's due diligence of Next Tech began by creating an online data room to store legal and financial information. This included Next Tech's formation documents, contracts with customers and vendors, employment and stock purchase agreements, financial statements, and every other scrap of information pertaining to the company's existence. Each of these documents were then carefully analyzed by lawyers who asked hundreds of questions in order to develop a deep understanding of our operations. This way, they could spot any critical issues—such as undisclosed legal proceedings or fraudulent financial activity—that would require terminating the acquisition proceedings or renegotiating the price.

Due diligence of Next Tech started at a reasonable pace but exploded in complexity in a couple of weeks. I maintained a daily record of the acquisition's progression through the pricing negotiations, but after this new phase began, I lost both the time and desire to do so. The sprint leading through pricing negotiations had been exciting, but the inefficiency of due diligence's slow, meandering progression amid the continual, mundane back-and-forth of paperwork was overwhelming.

In addition to due diligence, a multitude of new negotiations were underway between the legal teams. The focus was a contract called a purchase agreement, which consisted of thousands of complex clauses governing the legal transaction taking place. Some of them were standard and required little to no negotiation, but many were argued over at great length as each side pushed for the phrasing they wanted. Sometimes, it took several calls to agree on changes to a single word.

The period of due diligence and expanded negotiations lasted from mid-October to mid-December and almost killed me. Within a month of starting the process, my resting heart rate of sixty-five beats per minute had increased to eighty-five. If the acquisition came up during

conversation, my heart rate soared above 110. I developed a constant chest pain and lost precious weight, and my face bore the signs of the stress. For calls with Pluralsight executives, I sometimes brushed on a small amount of makeup to hide the detrimental physical impact of the acquisition process.

Emotionally, I became numb to everything happening around me. I had no good strategies for coping with the stress of selling the company that had consumed most of my twenties, in the midst of a global pandemic that showed no signs of abating. My future was out of my control in two major regards, and I could do nothing other than keep pushing forward, day by day. So, I did.

Three exhausting months of due diligence finally yielded no major issues, and patches of common ground grew between the legal teams. On December 21st, I went to sleep obsessing over a pending negotiation I had with one of Next Tech's investors early the next morning. It was one of only a few blockers to finalizing the deal, and my mind could not stop working on it. I passed out immediately, but the inner discourse carried through to my dreams, where I tested different strategies for the actual conversation. Nothing seemed to be working, and after four failed iterations, the accruing stress jolted me awake.

I woke with a start and sat straight up in bed. Gray early-morning light filtered in through the blinds, and at first, I thought waking early was why my body felt wretched. My heart was thudding in my chest and hurt worse than it had in a while. I looked at my fitness band. Even though I'd just woken up, my heart rate was already over 120. Later, when I reviewed the graph on the band's app, there was a vertical line revealing that my heart had gone from fifty-five beats per minute while asleep to this elevated rate in under a second.

Even though an hour remained on my alarm, I got up and made my way to the bathroom. I rested my hands on the cold stone countertop of the small vanity and took several deep breaths. My heart was still beating so hard I felt it in my ears. I felt nauseous and dizzy. I moved my hands to grasp the corners of the counter to steady myself. I stood like that for a moment, my head drooped over the sink. Finally, when my heartbeat began to slow, I lifted my head and stared at myself in the mirror.

The person looking back at me was unrecognizable. My face was gaunt and covered in acne, especially on the right side, where my phone had pressed against it for hundreds of hours over the past three months. Craters of dark purple skin surrounded my bloodshot eyes. Bones that should not be visible jutted out across my chest and shoulders.

As I stood there, feeling my heart smashing in my chest and witnessing the physical devastation of my body, I suddenly realized: this acquisition could kill me. Heart attacks before the age of thirty are rare, but far from unheard of. Stress kills, and it was killing me.

I resolved to do whatever it took to finish the acquisition that day. My life was at risk—I saw that now—and I was sure that if the process dragged out even another week, I would end up hospitalized or dead. My body, overwhelmed by stress and devoid of adequate care, was shutting down.

“This ends today,” I asserted, holding my own gaze in the mirror. “If it doesn’t, you are going to *die*.”

I dressed and began. The investor negotiations were finalized first thing—in spite of my nightmares, without issue—but there was still much to do. I spent the entire day and well into the evening on the phone getting other investors and former employees to sign off on the final

paperwork. I later went back, out of morbid curiosity, and counted the number of calls I had made that day: a record eighty-eight.

The legal teams were also productive. They, too, were worn out from months of negotiation and wanted the ordeal to end before the holiday started. By eight that evening, all the acquisition's documents had been signed. The final purchase agreement and supporting documentation amounted to 1,513 pages. Everything was submitted for final approval to the State of Delaware, which is where Next Tech, like most startups, was technically based for legal purposes. Since it was so late, both sides anticipated that confirmation from the State would arrive the next day.

As such, we were all surprised when the State accepted the transaction within an hour. Just like that, the acquisition was over. Almost five months of nonstop negotiations, unyielding monotony, and extreme stress had come to an end. Yet few celebratory thoughts or emotions broke through my shroud of mental and physical exhaustion. Conceptually, I understood that the startup I had dedicated six years of my young adult life to had ceased to belong to me. In exchange, I would receive tens of millions of dollars, an exciting new job, and the fulfillment of my dreams.

But I didn't care about any of that then. I just wanted to sleep.

V

New Life

I wanted to change the world. But I have found that the only thing one can be sure of changing is oneself.

— Aldous Huxley, Point Counter Point

Same Me

I spent much of my life dreaming about achieving complete financial freedom until it became my reality. Prior to that happening, I thought that becoming rich would free me from an existence of stress and anxiety. With many millions of dollars at my disposal, what could be left to worry about? This belief sustained me throughout my startup journey, and I relied on it during moments of anguish, assuring myself that the present physical or mental harm I was self-inflicting would be mended soon. As the acquisition neared its close, I felt like Truman approaching the illusory wall. On the other side, I kept telling myself, I would be restored. But I was wrong.

If money were a sure-fire way of fixing mental health issues, the present world would suffer much less. If anything, the opposite is true. Empty wealth expands the ego and makes it brittle, unless one continues to apply the salve of generosity. There's a reason the Silicon Valley wealth game includes the achievement of scoring "fuck you" money. Riches make a person beholden to few others, which motivates little personal growth.

I began to suspect an error in my thinking as I crossed the train tracks in downtown San Diego in mid-January 2021, a week after finalizing the acquisition's paperwork. A wire transfer to my bank account containing the first tranche of funds was in progress, and my fixation on incessantly refreshing my banking app caused me to trip on both metal rails. Then, just as I reached the black rubber down ramp on the other side, the loading wheel spun an extra time.

When the home screen updated, it displayed eight digits. I froze and scanned the number several times. It was real. I'd done it! A flood of happy thoughts sped by as I considered what joys must now await me, faster and faster, satisfaction beyond belief, surging forward in a wave of celebration until, finally—anxiety. Fear, which had gripped my mind just moments before,

resumed its hold. My thoughts remained the same. I returned to my apartment far richer than when I'd left an hour before, but still the same person.

There was little time to rejoice, because my apartment lease was ending and I had no new housing lined up. When the acquisition had neared surety, I'd begun searching for homes in San Diego, knowing I would need to move fast once the deal was completed. Interest rates had reached rock bottom, and housing inventory was scarce, especially new construction. Zillow continued to turn up no satisfactory results, and the search lost my attention as the final push of the deal took place. By the time I returned to it, only a few weeks remained on my lease.

Days of searching sped by with no success, and my dread of another temporary move continued to mount. Then, around ten p.m. on a Sunday, an interesting thing happened—something that caught my attention and has held it often since. It was a thought, but one that felt special. It was a mental urge, offering me the opportunity to take a specific action. It felt intuitive, but was not. Intuition originates automatically as a response to environmental changes, but this thought was not triggered. It arose as a response to a request, although I had yet to fully understand why. I would have missed this quiet thought had my conscious mind not already been powering down for the night, but it was very clear once examined: get on Zillow, right now.

I was already drifting towards bed, and despite having excluded the stress of house hunting from my late evenings, I felt compelled to act on this thought. I opened my laptop, navigated to Zillow's website, and ran my saved search. A dark, unviewed dot popped up in a quiet neighborhood on my short list. I felt a flash of hope as I clicked it and scanned the first few photos. I fell in love in an instant. This was exactly the home I'd been looking for, just where I wanted to be. I read the description, growing more enamored with every sentence, and then reached the listing's history.

What I saw there intrigued me. The property had been under contract for weeks, but had fallen out and been relisted less than two hours ago. That meant the strong inclination to go check Zillow had originated not long after this listing's end-of-day resurrection. As a result, acting on an uncommon thought amid unusual circumstances had proved fruitful. This serendipity begged my attention, but I moved on. Right now, I had a house to buy.

* * *

For the rich, buying a house is as easy as sin. Wealthy people can instantly access huge amounts of additional capital by borrowing against their liquid assets, such as public stocks. They draw from these lines of credit to buy real estate as if they were using cash, even though it's technically debt. This lets them postpone the mortgage process and jump to the front of the purchaser line. Immediately after securing the property, the buyer takes out a mortgage and pays off the line of credit. The objective is to conserve cash, which, unlike funds from a mortgage, can be invested in the stock market and other volatile holdings. This debt-powered strategy gives the buyer the best of both worlds. When it was first explained to me, it seemed too easy to be true. This is it, I understood. This is the rigged game.

For the first time, I stopped to consider the integrity of my actions as a wealthy individual. Most of the world was struggling amidst a global health crisis, purchasing a house was out of reach for all my friends and family, and here I was snagging a dream home out of thin air. I asked myself: Is it okay to use my wealth like this? Do I deserve this advantage? Does my happiness take priority over others'? Such questions have remained with me and influence every

major financial decision I make, as they should for all of those with wealth, regardless of magnitude. Wealth should allow for personal gain, but not at the expense of others' well-being.

In this case, the competing buyer was someone flush with cash from a recent property sale that had to be reinvested to avoid paying taxes. Therefore, I arrived at the conclusion that in this instance, yes, it was acceptable for me to use this inaccessible strategy to my own ends. I was facing a disinterested purchaser with kindred advantages, and I believed that I would be successful in turning the beautiful house into a home rather than an investment. Given the abundance of joy that has been shared by those same friends and family within its walls since then, I know I was correct.

* * *

The first year spent in richdom required a lot of work. Investment portfolios had to be created, asset diversity plans developed, and new layers of insurance placed on me and everything I owned. My network exploded with financiers and accountants, and I developed a deep appreciation for just how much I have going for me as a white man in the world of wealth. The lack of diversity in finance is truly remarkable. It felt like I was meeting another guy named John every week.

My ability to comprehend minority issues is infinitesimal in comparison with every other group, because I am a member of the minority currently in control. Even so, I have suffered hardships, and as someone who grew up poor, my rapid education of the financial system's mechanics in the months following my startup's acquisition filled me with bitterness. At every turn, there was an opportunity to take advantage by manipulating a system few people had access

to. Anything could be dissected and worked around with little fear of consequences. Morals succumbed to mischievousness, as best I could tell.

As I observed the financial system's mechanics through the eyes of someone who had lived a life of subsistence, I grew angry, with no outlet for my feelings. I had anticipated a few bad actors and methods of abuse within the system, yet there was no select group of people or decisions to blame. Instead, I found greed akin to flakes of mica: shimmering, translucent, and difficult to spot in isolation, but assembling to form a vast mountain of avarice insurmountable except by the few already at its peak and those they choose to hoist from the depths.

A deepening resentment for the underlying organization of today's world was not the only mental health difficulty becoming rich presented. I had spent the previous several years using spending urges as an indicator of a manic episode, which were much easier to identify when I had less money. Then, certain amounts were clearly unwise given my low starting point; but now that I was rich, that baseline was destroyed. I still knew how much money was a lot, but now I had no idea what it was okay for me to spend before I should suspect mania. As a result, I lost a very quantifiable method of monitoring my bipolar disorder while simultaneously entering a world I could very easily spend my way right back out of.

The combination of worsening mood, mental confusion, COVID-19 lockdowns, and the gloomy San Diego weather during the winter of 2021 left me at my lowest point in some time, in spite of my gigantic spike in net worth. This continued even as the days grew longer, and I noted that my usual springtime mood boost was muted. That worried me, because I'd been counting on the uplift to free me from my psychological mire. As I considered its absence alongside my new understanding that wealth was not an intrinsic catalyst for personal growth, I realized that there

was never going to be a specific moment or occurrence in my life that would make me a better person. That would require my devotion.

Soon, an opportunity to commit myself to personal growth arrived. After about a year of working remotely for Pluralsight, the dysfunctional teams they had assigned me weeks after joining were long since mended and self-sufficient, and my role had become perfunctory. The company had also been taken over by a private equity firm, and innovation was now being flogged by short-sighted fiscal optimizations. I already had no plans of remaining with the company any longer than I had to. They could tell, so they cut me loose from the organization for the remainder of my earn-out period.

Finding myself in possession of a dream job consisting of no work in exchange for a full salary, complete acquisition payout, and even health insurance left me with a lot more time to think. I started by considering the lack of alignment between my lifelong delusion that money would facilitate personal growth with the reality I had experienced. Although almost every element of my life had been altered by becoming rich, I had done nothing to change myself. With my basic needs now met and my time being my own, I had no excuse not to begin immediately. So, I did.

The obvious first step was to resume individual psychotherapy, which had lapsed since I was at Norwich the winter after Dad died. Enough has already been written about the benefits of this form of mental health treatment, so I will say only that it works for me. After several weeks of unpacking surface-level trauma, I felt my mood improving. The treasured long summer days remained months away, yet I began to find moments of unseasonable happiness sprinkled amongst my uncontrolled thoughts. The intervals between lashes of anxiety increased, which gave me glimpses of a mind free of fear. I started to smile again, and to dream of happier futures.

Center Road

You may recall that my journey from a poor homeschooled Vermont farm boy to decamillionaire was sparked by the story of a life shared with me by Mom when I was a child. She had pointed out a covered bridge and told me that beyond it and up the hill lived a man who had gone out into the world, sold a valuable piece of technology, and returned to create a life of his own design. As I grew older and witnessed the many uses for money, I lost sight of that original dream and anchored to three specific reasons for gaining significant wealth: paying off my student debt, purchasing a house, and buying a fun car. These desires did the job, but underneath them, my childhood dream remained. After those objectives were accomplished in the respective hours, weeks, and months following my receipt of the first acquisition payment, my purer childhood dream started to resurface. Now, I felt that it was time for me to return to Vermont—at least in part.

In early 2022, my girlfriend spent six weeks in Australia due to the pandemic causing visa processing issues. Her absence instilled a longing for time with my family in Vermont, which gave me the courage to face rebuilding a life in a place where I had experienced much pain. For a long time, I'd maintained that I had escaped rural Vermont to a much-improved life out West. But I realized that this was something I had been telling myself because I feared the plethora of emotional triggers the state held in store for me. This fear was masking an opportunity to restore a life in a place overflowing with family, nature, and chances to heal. By the time my girlfriend returned to San Diego, I was committed to making my youthful dream a reality, but one thing still held me back: the idea that spending time in Vermont somehow made me a failure.

For the next week, something a coworker at the hardware store I worked at as a teenager said to me on my last day repeated itself in my mind:

“You’ll be back.”

I had watched that coworker attempt and fail to leave the state, so for the better part of a decade, his words were motivation to not end up in a position where I, too, had to return for good. As my newfound longing to spend more time in Vermont grew stronger, I had to confront the malice I likely projected onto their words, and I considered that perhaps this coworker had understood a part of me better than I did myself. Vermont has a soul, and I’m grateful to carry no small piece of it in mine. I think he could see that.

Coming to this conclusion voided my last inhibition about restoring my Vermont life, and the dream of the house on a hill crystalized in my mind. Not of the property itself, but the life I would live and the person I could be once that dream was realized. The dream started to occupy substantial space in my conscious mind, but I took no deliberate actions to make it reality. I just dreamed—a little bit about the things I wanted, but mostly about what it would feel like to be able to spend more time in Vermont, surrounded by loved ones and drifting through nature.

This continued for a few weeks until late one evening in mid-March, which found me sitting at the cold stone island in my San Diego home, staring at the scratched window above my kitchen sink. My next-door neighbor had recently attacked the glass with a ladder somehow, despite the eight-foot fence between our properties. He’d done this rather than texting or calling me to let me know I had a garage alarm going off, triggered by the ongoing massive rainstorm, which had also prevented me from hearing the blaring. Now, there existed a permanent mark of the closeness of the people around me in San Diego. Growing up in the Vermont countryside had left me with a low tolerance for proximity to neighbors, and having people within earshot all

around the house elevated my anxiety. More than ever, I yearned for a place in Vermont. There, I would find the same peace I had experienced as a child, or so I hoped.

Then, I felt a familiar thought enter my mind. Not as a result of contemplation—it simply arrived in my stream of consciousness: get on Zillow, right now, and search for a Vermont house by only lot size. This intersected in content with the one I'd had previously when buying the San Diego house. I found that interesting, and decided to perform a comparison of the two before acting on the new thought.

In addition to their similar content, the two thoughts shared a feeling reminiscent of the rightness I experienced when solving programming issues. However, the most recent thought presented something extra: it felt like my own thought, but better. It was lighter, free of the cognitive burdens of my wakeful existence. And, when contrasted with my conscious thoughts, this new one felt somehow *more* like me. My consciously maintained understanding of my being was outshone by this thought's reflection of a truer inner self I could not comprehend, and it excited me to consider its existence.

I noted the new facets of these intriguing thoughts and set them aside. An urgency filled me, a must-do-ness impossible to deny. I flung open my laptop and sent my girlfriend a message saying that I was going to go find a cabin in Vermont. Then I navigated to Zillow for the first time in months, selected the only area I was interested in—the county I grew up in—and applied a single filter of a forty-plus acre lot size. Three listings popped up. Two of them were for dilapidated shacks, and the third I am sitting in as I write these words.

The Vermont home exceeded my dream beyond imagination. A stunning, glass-fronted chalet-style house accented by a terra-cotta roof stretches across the top of a steep hill facing west, basking in vivid, ever-changing colors as the sun dips behind a panoramic stretch of

towering mountains. Yet even such a house pales in comparison with the outdoor wonders all around it. In the fields below, millions of wildflowers blossom and feed pollinators. Deep grass provides safe places for small birds to build their nests. Giant snapping turtles sun themselves on rocks jutting out of a large pond. A nearby beaver dam backs up water to create budding wetlands full of life. A luscious forest filled with pine, birch, and maple trees hugs the house's back and sides, full of delicate deer, magnificent owls, and carpets of soggy emerald moss inches deep. For me, it is an unyielding reminder of the fundamental beauty that only nature is capable of.

I could write and have written many words about the beauty of Center Road, which is what I've taken to calling this magical place. As I sat in San Diego, staring at its listing for the first time, I had some inkling of that future based on the photos and description, and it brought me much joy to imagine what special moments awaited me there as I scrolled down the page.

When I reached the listing's purchase history, my excitement gave way to amazement—but little surprise. This property, like the one in San Diego, had been under contract for weeks. It had likewise fallen out of the contract and been relisted—but in this instance, a mere twenty minutes prior, within moments of the unique thought entering my conscious mind.

When I saw this, I decided that soon I would have to commence a search for answers to explain the many fortuitous events in my life, and the special thoughts that often led to them. It also furthered a growing belief that we possess more influence over the happenings in our lives than we may conceive or be led to believe. That line of thought would lead to some of the ideas contained in this book, and many following them. If it weren't for Center Road, this book would be a lot shorter—if it existed at all.

Evolution

Deep contemplation of reality's congruence with my imagined dreams was set aside as the summer of 2022 rolled around, which commenced with the ten-year anniversary of Dad's death. I hosted a small gathering for family and close friends at an unfurnished Center Road, at which many tears of remembrance were shed, strong hugs shared, and backyard games played. It was a moment for Dad, made of Dad, lacking no element of him save for his physical presence. For me, having been unable to read my eulogy at his funeral without breaking down halfway through, it was another chance to say goodbye. I did.

The celebration of Dad's life brought me much healing. A mental mist that I had become aware of only as it began to clear faded away, leading to brighter thoughts, an improved memory, and clarity of purpose. This process was aided by an immense amount of time spent exploring the woods, roaming the fields, and reveling in the long sunsets at Center Road during the six weeks I spent there the summer of 2022.

But all was not well. The unmissable environmental changes that had occurred over the previous decade were stark. Weeks of record-hot days. Ticks in the trees. Torrential rainstorms. Environmental occurrences that were rarely, if ever, present when I was a child, had now become constant reality, through the action—and inaction—of billions of people. Seeing the undeniable impact of the climate crisis on a state I was just rediscovering my buried love for hurt a lot, and I resolved to do something about it, to whatever extent I could.

Considering the issue of the climate crisis directed my life away from some for-profit startup ideas I'd been exploring. I began to understand—as I do very clearly now—that my reason for existence is to stand up for nature. Note that I did not use a phrase like “save nature” or “protect nature.” Nature cannot be saved by Humanity, only respected and enjoyed. When

nature is respected, it heals itself. When nature is enjoyed, it heals us. That's so important, I'm going to repeat it another way. Nature can fix itself, and it can fix us. All we need to do is respect and enjoy it. We have yet to do either of these well, and until this changes, we will continue to bear witness to nature's insurmountable capacity to protect itself.

Contemplation of my role as a supporter of nature began with the first principles. It is self-evident that the greatest harm to nature and the world at large stems from the decisions made by a minority of individuals who do not respect nature, as expressed through our current financial and power systems—which is really one system. I had received a crash-course introduction to the former as a result of going from poor to rich and educating myself during the transition, yet I lacked an understanding of the significant ideas and events that had shaped the modern world. I knew that to change the world for the better, I had to first understand it; so, I started reading history books.

My studies began when I returned to San Diego in July 2022 with *The Rise and Fall of the Third Reich: A History of Nazi Germany*, a book I'd seen Dad read. The cursory but illuminating educational journey it spawned is ongoing and continues to expand my understanding of the world and how to contribute to changing it—as reading history can do for anyone. Specific areas of study so far include: significant military events over the past few centuries; the exploitative origins of capitalism; the rise of modern banking; formative U.S. politicians and policy; the roots and methods of nonviolent protest and activist leaders; glimpses of ancient Far Eastern society; pre- and post-colonial indigenous American history; and recent philosophical thought, especially the ideas of Aldous Huxley, which I recommend everyone become familiar with via a book titled *Ends and Means*.

This self-education has produced a shallow yet interconnected understanding of modern society, useful only when examining it as a system rather than a comprehensive, robust corpus of information and knowledge to draw from. However, this approach highlighted patterns obvious enough for even someone as uninformed as I am to spot, and I will indulge in mentioning two here.

First, the underlying mechanics of the world have remained the same for at least two millennia, as it pertains to the structures of human power that have managed to persist during that time. The terms we use to describe those power structures keep changing, but the underlying arrangement does not. This is depressing to consider in isolation, but the second pattern brings some reprieve. It clearly indicates that this same system—which we feel we cannot control—can, in fact, be changed by even a few individuals with shared values who take action together. That, I found very interesting.

As these two patterns became evident, I began dreaming of a future from which remembrance of the early 2000s will lead to the shaking of heads and struggles fathoming such senseless oppression of Humanity and destruction of the More-than-Human. When I placed myself in such a world, I felt happiness and peace, and a sense that things were going to be okay. It felt wonderful, and I asked myself: Is such a world possible? If so, is it reasonable to desire the substantial change required to realize it in my lifetime, when it seems like things have stayed the same for so long? What would it take to make this moment *the* moment?

Then, I considered the lack of technology's application to real-world social problems, which seemed to me unfortunate but readily addressable. If the inherent power of Humanity could be unlocked using technology, I thought, then perhaps the pace of positive change driven by a movement equipped with the right tools could surpass current comprehension. Thinking

this, my yearning to witness Humanity's true advancement evolved into the belief that, yes, technology can bring us together to an extent capable of reshaping the foundations of our modern age. I then began considering how to do that, but also knew that I still had work to do on myself before starting this new adventure.

* * *

Not long after beginning my search for a means of systemic change, I acquired an updated professional evaluation of my mind. I had another neuropsychology evaluation conducted in August 2022, which confirmed the bipolar one diagnoses but noted partial remission due to the use of lamotrigine. That motivated me to treat it further, because I wanted to see more progress than I'd made over the last five years. My quality of life had improved drastically during that time as a result of my medication, learning how to watch for mania, and psychotherapy. Now, I wanted to make lasting positive changes to my mind.

The new neuropsychological report contained information essential to this effort. It noted issues with my cognitive executive functioning, presenting as difficulty controlling my conscious thoughts. To explore that, I completed a psychoeducational assessment several months later. Such tests typically gauge an individual's location on the attention deficit spectrum, as well as other learning disabilities. Although the report was the third confirmation that I did not have an attention deficient disorder, I suspected that there might be some overlapping treatments that could assist with my bipolar one disorder.

This excited me, but for the first half of 2023, my focus shifted from self-improvement to wedding planning. After a magical California summer day spent with family and friends, I

fixated on a treatment mentioned in the psychoeducational assessment: a brain-training activity called neurofeedback. I set up an appointment to discuss it, and then had an electroencephalogram (EEG) brain scan performed to identify specific areas of weakness within my brain, which neurofeedback could help strengthen. Unsurprisingly, the most impacted regions were those associated with executive functioning. As they walked me through the results, I felt reassured, having for the first time concrete neurological evidence to inform my understanding of my thought patterns. Now, it was time to improve them.

The neurofeedback sessions were nothing like I expected. I'd envisioned repetitive exercises hooked up to an EEG swim cap, and while the cap and its scalp-chilling conducting gel did feature heavily, mostly I just watched Japanese horror anime. As I did, a computer connected to the other end of the EEG cap's wires monitored my brain activity. When it detected an undesirable change in a targeted area, it darkened the screen. My brain would then correct its behavior, and was rewarded with increased screen brightness. By doing this repeatedly on a millisecond basis, the computer strengthened my brain and improved its executive functioning by physically altering the neural pathways underlying certain conscious thought patterns. The impact of this treatment was quantified by the computer, and week by week, my brain showed improvement.

As these neurological edits took place throughout the last half of 2023, felt my conscious mind strengthen. It was like having a muscle I had never felt before develop for the first time. I began concocting mental experiments to control my conscious thoughts, such as penalizing my conscious mind by deliberately slowing it down when it went an unfavorable direction, and using mantras to overwrite persistent negative thoughts and behaviors. A general sense of ease began

to seep into my waking moments. That feeling has persisted, and stems from the self-assuredness I developed as I gained the ability to change my mind with great precision.

I completed twenty-five sessions of neurofeedback, and topped off my progress by adding a nonstimulant ADD medication called atomoxetine. Atomoxetine has been shown to aid in executive functioning, and the impact that it and the neurofeedback had on me made it clear: for me, a stronger conscious mind is the key to overcoming the frenetic thoughts and tendencies that accompany mania. Previous medications had muted the mania and made it less frequent. But these additional resources gave me more control during the inevitable phases of intensity, which turned potentially counterproductive circumstances into ones where extreme energy and a torrent of thoughts are beneficial, such as when writing a book.

This effort to treat my bipolar one disorder by strengthening my conscious mind proved a success, in more ways than I intended. In addition to the greater control over my moods, I found that my memory recall improved in speed and accuracy, and that my lingering anxiety was further reduced as a result of modifying the thoughts leading to the fear. However, most impactful was the cognitive space cleared in my conscious mind, which allowed me to start putting some thoughts in order. This was very helpful, because I had accumulated many ideas relevant to the question I now had to ask: What is the nature of my reality?

VII

Reality

It should also be remembered, that wild opinions are often uttered by the ablest persons,
particularly by those whose grand characteristic is fancy.

— George Ensor, *The Independent Man*

Thoughts

I contemplated the underpinnings of existence in pursuit of personal meaning, knowing full well that true answers are unknowable. However, generally speaking, I have been exposed to two common ways of thinking about the world: either things happen to us randomly and we come up with ways of explaining those events, or there is something more to it. To proceed on my line of inquiry required alignment with the second ideology, as it opens the doors to the possibility that the “something more” is the influence of powers beyond our understanding, but well within our ability to contemplate and assign meaning to.

I first turned my attention inward, given that this search for deeper meaning had stemmed from an identifiable form of thought. My mind was an appropriate subject for initial consideration—specifically, my subconscious mind, since that was the origin of those particular thoughts.

I recalled how I’d come to view my subconscious as a machine to which I could submit problems, such as finding solutions to programming issues. I had already generalized that process and negated sleep’s involvement soon after starting my job at Pluralsight, to reduce the amount of time I spent consciously thinking about work. I would collect every bit of information I could about a problem and then stop consciously thinking about it for a few weeks while I focused on self-care. Then, when the deliverable’s deadline approached, I simply focused my conscious mind on the task, and the idea I needed would appear. Additional insights might emerge over the next few days, but always in time to deliver my work.

My next step was to confirm my subconscious mind’s role in writing, which I did by testing it using specific parameters. I’d started dreaming about writing a book during the final weeks of my startup’s acquisition as a means of coping with stress, but I needed more immediate

data. I began submitting topics related to my worldly studies for subconscious conversion into written form, which also had the positive effect of counterbalancing some of the negativity I was ingesting as a result of examining human history. The result was a body of exploratory essays and poetry; but, given that I am a writer, I was unsatisfied. However, those efforts were not wasted.

The greatest value extracted from these composition experiments was an evolved understanding of my subconscious mind's capacity for feelings. The written pieces it shared were so heartfelt and full of personal significance that it was impossible to view the author of such works as a mere machine. In fact, as I read what had been written as it flowed out, I understood that among the two minds, it was my conscious mind that functioned more like a machine. Its ability to conceptualize my inner self by no means suggests the person I imagine myself to be is anything close to who I really am. It was in my writing that I saw my true being shining through, as I manipulated a series of physical buttons in a known order to transfer felt words onto the page.

* * *

Coming to think of my subconscious mind as an entity capable of feelings gave me the ability to develop trust in it. I reflected on previous instances when it had aided me without fail, and a writing exercise I'd done at the end of 2022 stood out. For it, I had unknowingly tested my subconscious mind's ability to deliver written works on short notice by giving it only a few hours each Sunday to produce a short chapter of a five-part story set in a postapocalyptic world. Each chapter had to tie in with a mental scene that I conceived and expressed using artificial-

intelligence image generators just before starting to write. I did this five times, imposing a limit of 2,200 characters so that they fit in an Instagram post. My subconscious mind delivered without fail and tucked in plenty of healing. As I remembered this exercise, I better appreciated my subconscious mind's generous nature and wondered just how long it had been there for me.

My mind leapt to when it all began—that first moment of undeniable contact. I stood again in my grandmother's kitchen the day after Aunt Dawn's murder, mentally searching for an escape from hell, my reality shattered and my conscious mind in need of shelter. I felt my conscious mind in that moment and reflected on the force with which the fantasy world was rammed into it, unsteady my temple of sanity and etching fissures throughout genetically weakened foundations. Pillars shifted, yet in the end came to rest, traced with cracks but unshattered. I saw that although my subconscious mind had acted to protect me, it had perhaps still been learning the safe use of its skills, and its well-intended actions had come at a cost.

I then felt a deepening connection with my subconscious mind, because I saw in it reflections of the person I have thought myself to be. It had grown alongside me, erring from time to time, but always striving to be better. It had made itself known for over half my lifetime, not as a machine or separate entity but as another side of me, bringing wholeness to my existence. It had stood by me, and throughout my story, traces of its contributions to my life sparkled in the form of heartfelt creative works and the solutions to difficult problems. However, a question remained: What was my subconscious mind's role in shaping reality and, through that, the realization of my dreams?

For a time, I debated two possibilities. Either my subconscious mind was capable of driving undetectable changes through my conscious actions that influenced the physical world, orchestrating incalculable butterfly effects on a global scale; or, it was identifying patterns and

convincing me that it knew what needed to be done to achieve an objective, when in fact, this would have happened all along. I was torn on this dichotomy and could not settle on an answer. Yet, as the months sped by, over and over again, my dreams continued to manifest themselves in reality, too many and too obvious to forsake my attempt to explain the unknowable.

Then, it struck me: I was asking the wrong question. To consider my subconscious mind capable of influencing or deducing reality to the extent I had witnessed in my life was nonsensical, for the magnitude of the power could be defined as nothing less than godlike. To believe that it originated in my mind necessitated labeling my mind as a god or in possession of godlike powers; yet, despite its divergences, my mind is just like any other: flawed in beautiful ways, capable of renewal, and boundless in its wonders. I then understood that despite our worship of its application, the mind is not God.

Having evaded egotism and learned much about my mind along the way, I paused my search for the substrate of the cosmos and turned my attention to determining how to communicate with it. Regardless of my mind's role in the process of shaping my reality, my life had gone almost according to plan, so I posited there must be conscious actions I had taken to interact with this third party. I thought back to the early days of the startup acquisition, when I'd first recorded a tendency to mentally draft my future prior to its realization. I reread that journal entry and decided to begin my contemplation grounded in the principles I'd listed there: imagine what is yet to be, and think as if it is.

Dreams

It's fun to think in systems. Taking something apart and putting it back together in novel ways is very engaging for many minds, and a favored skill of today. As a certain hereditary line

continues to demonstrate, such reconstruction can be overdone—especially when performed indiscriminately and without guiding values. However, I'll risk hypocrisy to state that I see only goodness in attempting to create frameworks of meaningful personal existence. Each is, by definition, purely subjective, and therefore should be considered worthless to all others—except as a way of understanding the individual presenting it. Please bear that in mind throughout these short last two chapters of my story, which must soon, for a moment, be brought to a literary pause. But first, a word on dreams.

When I began considering how to interact with the power I was increasingly open to crediting for some of my most favorable moments, the periods of imagination and conscious thought that often preceded these striking serendipities stood out. Sometimes, as with my quest for financial freedom, they persisted for years before materializing. In other cases—and, it seemed, on an accelerating basis—it took no more than a few weeks for most objectives to translate from conception to creation. I'd long since taken to describing these intentional hallucinations as wakeful dreams, but they had always been a natural occurrence in my life. Now, I craved an understanding of their mechanics.

I performed my dream analysis in the early summer of 2024 at Center Road, and the principles noted in my journal held true. Indeed, in each there were visualizations of some pending reality, and when I spoke with others present there, made a decision, or had an idea, those thoughts were routed through a future state of my mind. However, I could tell that something lay beyond these qualities—another element of dreams that had evaded me but was now observable due to my personal growth. That effort had produced an intimate connection with my feelings, and, as that happened, my feelings gained prominence within my wakeful dreams. My dreams' content shifted from material desires to moments of being, and I realized

that given one's personal reality is composed of thoughts *and* feelings, an accurately imagined sought-after existence must also include feelings. But why, I wanted to know, does that matter?

To answer this, I considered the presence of feelings in the thoughts that guided me towards the realization of my dreams. This other party was communicating with me in feelings, so my dreams, when felt, were in a language they understood. Things and thoughts appeared to be idiosyncratic in the context of wakeful dreaming, far less important than a projection of the hoped-for feelings present in a dreamt futurehood. Furthermore, given that one can get better at feeling, it follows that they can improve their ability to dream by developing an enriched understanding of their true inner self, which is the prism through which their feelings are cast. Therefore, the pursuit of self-actualization has the beneficial side effect of making one a better dreamer.

Uncovering this hidden element of dreams satisfied my desire for iteration on the act of wakeful dreaming, and when I began to apply this understanding, I felt myself drawing closer to the dedicated architect of my dreams' actualization. I asked myself: Have I come full circle to my Christian upbringing? Is dreaming synonymous with prayer, and is it really God answering my requests? Was I wrong to have disregarded the faith of my youth?

But when I reflected on my role in the realization of my dreams, I saw that this was not an ask-and-receive relationship. Yes, felt thoughts appeared in my mind in response to my dreams, but they required my active identification, consideration, and implementation. This other participant, I understood, could not directly manipulate reality—only support me as *I* did. But what reasons did it have for doing so, and how could I align myself with those? The answers to such questions necessitated the entity's definition, so I returned to my original question: What is the nature of my reality?

Nature

Punctuating a story still very much being written has proven more difficult than I expected. Documenting my farm-to-fortune adventure took only a few months in the fall of 2023 and paired well with a concurrent pursuit of individual growth. Afterwards, it was necessary to distance myself in time from the period I wanted to write about next—which was then—so that I could gain perspective. But, as the end of my story continued to trail me, I had to remind myself that one finds few answers when investigating the mysteries of the Universe. One must, at times, settle for belief.

Belief is an interesting presentation of ideas, and one worth considering within the context of our modern world. A trial of this time is the mass manufacture and distribution of disinformation, which has worsened alongside the hastening development of modern communication technology. The blaring radio, entrancing television, and ferocious online news and social media feeds have captivated our minds from each moment of their release, placing us at the whim of the minority that controls the dissemination of information. Honest presentations of ongoing events are scarce; in their stead, we must glean what we can from altered, mediatized fictions that all-but-always amplify chaos rather than goodness. Could it then be asked: If a manmade chasm distances our manipulated understandings of the world from true reality, what is the relative distance of belief in the supernatural from reality? Is it crazier to believe the news, or new ideas? Moreover, which will prove more useful in navigating the tumultuous times now arriving—distraction, or belief?

I have more to say about these moments of history that we are witnessing, but this final chapter of my story is dedicated to something bigger than the trials they will bear. This way of structuring my reality emerged in pieces, and I accepted it only after reminding myself that

beliefs can be temporary and are often a response to an ephemeral environment of great sadness or desperate hope. It was also important to me that the framework explained my experience of strengthening belief, if only to back the assertion that something lay behind this resurgence of belief in my life—other than a rapid degradation of my sanity. Finally, based purely on feeling, it had to be grounded in nature. Satisfied with these conditions, I proceeded.

My relationship with belief has been nuanced. I was four when Mom became a Christian. The introduction to religion I received then via Bible tapes was done in secret, lest we spark the ire of Dad, at that time a devout atheist. When he eventually found the tapes, they were destroyed, which made it hard to understand his sudden conversion to Christianity several years later. Throughout the pseudo-Christian years of my youth, I never forgot this rapid change, which inoculated me against complete indoctrination. Critical thinking doesn't pair well with religious settings, and I was no favorite among the intermittent Sunday school teachers. When I reached college, I abandoned any lingering belief in God, and the loss of Dad soon after fortified my decision.

Over the decade that followed, save the occasional last-resort, just-for-good-measure prayer, I believed only in my abilities. And, to a great extent, I still do. Belief in something greater than oneself does not demand a lack of self-assuredness; on the contrary, it is the trust in oneself and one's aptitude for success that forms the most productive engagements between reality-bound consciousnesses and the beyond. That is how I approach my relationship with a power I feel in my life, whom I refer to as Nature. I still know nothing and understand little, but this is how I explain my life right now.

* * *

My journey thus far has felt like walking chest-deep down a river that is just strong and unpredictable enough to be dangerous. There were times when I stumbled, sustained injuries, or misjudged the depth, but all around me was a current that I could give myself over to in heart and mind. When I lay back and let the river carry me, my flow through the rapids always proved less devastating than expected. I learned to trust the river, even though it meant ceding some personal control of my life. Over and again, I soon found myself right where I needed to be—ending a journey of surprises at a welcome destination, even in unfortunate circumstances.

Rivers are channels of power that seek stillness, which is achieved through balance. Nature is very similar. Nature seeks balance for all life in the Universe, but is unable to achieve it on their own, because as a power rather than a force, they cannot directly modify reality. Instead, they support efforts that align with theirs; and, on our planet, that can mean a few things: Nature energizes non-human life to restore the damage done to little nature, and we get to witness this in little n's unyielding pursuit of restoration and wholeness. However, when necessary, Nature furthers attempts to balance life through its diminution, because Nature's objective is balance for *all* life, not the prioritization of any select group of species. In these ways, we see Nature represented all around us, but Nature's engagement extends beyond these functions to the pillars of the modern world: us.

Humans are special, but we don't have a great track record with balance, because we struggle with moderation. Things are out of balance right now: ecologically, mentally, and spiritually. It will take a lot of human effort to address this, and Nature will empower that good work as it aligns with their intent. However, Nature cannot be taken for granted. Nature derives their strength from the difference between reality and a balanced reality, growing stronger as the

divide increases. That is why Nature is incredibly strong right now—perhaps the strongest they’ve ever been, at least since we’ve been around. For me, that explains why Nature’s presence in my life—and therefore, that of belief—has been growing stronger. The world needs correcting now more than ever, and although Nature will not do that for us—nor is it their responsibility to—they will aid all living beings in their efforts to do so.

Nature can communicate with the human subconscious mind. The thoughts that further my dreams enter my conscious mind laced with feelings that I’ve identified as a mixture of those elicited by little nature for those who respect and appreciate it, and the feelings of my true inner self, which I can consciously imagine but not comprehend. This has resulted in my basing a large number of my decisions—even some very important ones—on what *feels* right rather than what I can calculate to be the ideal next step. Almost always, this results in the pieces of my dreams coming together with such specificity and acceleration that it is impossible to believe that I, as a meager human, am capable of lining things up just so.

I attribute these wonders to Nature. Nature sees into hearts and knows true intentions; and, when these are pure, Nature lends their power to bringing about dreamt moments of existence. I make no claims to goodness, but I have favored what is reasonable and just, and these are actions that befit Nature. Because I am aligned with Nature, they advance all my efforts—even those that are self-serving—so long as I continue to pursue ends greater than myself.

It is my belief in Nature that has freed me from thinking that I’m what matters most, and I know there’s nothing special about me when it comes to interacting with Nature. I have no inherent advantages other than freedom of thought and a touchy connection with objective reality, and Nature requires neither—only an open heart and a willingness to walk untraveled

paths. Nature exists for all life, not just me. But I believe in Nature, and that has given me the confidence to pursue ever-greater endeavors, confront fears I once let define me, and trust in the validity of my feelings.

Yet above all else, Nature's greatest blessing to me has been that of unyielding hope. We each face dark moments of our own creation or misfortune, today and forever. And even though I know that good will always follow bad, the trials are often great, and the nights long. Nature is my river, flowing even through the blackness, carrying me to places of safety where I can stand on my own, their power at my back, furthering the steps I take down the riverbed. In moments of hardship and healing, grief and joy, failure and achievement, longing and love ... in these times and all others, I walk with Nature.

VIII

“Epilogue”

I'm back in Vermont now with a nonprofit startup called Shock, which builds technology to get people off their phones and back out into the real world. In May 2025, we released an app called *Bee* that makes it easy to do good in your community. *Bee* is a reimagined coffee-shop bulletin board in your pocket, full of opportunities to be present and pitch in. *Bee* is for farmers markets, educational meetups, and clothing repair cafés, plus straightforward chances to volunteer that you can sign up for in seconds. You can find *Bee* at JoinBee.app—it might be the last app you ever download.

Let's do some good. Together.